

Nova Scotia public guide

Beyond the Tax-Sale Packet

How Nova Scotia municipal tax sales work, from unpaid taxes to the deed

A plain guide to the whole process: the notices, the redemption months, the auction or tender, and the deed. Learn to read a sale notice, build a dated research file, and take each open question to the person who can answer it.

Illustrated edition, 2026
Facts as of July 2026; sale dates as of October 2026.

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About this book

Every year, Nova Scotia municipalities sell land to collect unpaid property taxes. The sales are public, the notices are published, and the rules are written down. Most people still meet a tax sale as a short line in a newspaper or a long PDF on a municipal website, with no map of how the pieces fit.

This book is that map. It follows the whole process, from the first unpaid tax bill to the deed and the years after it, and it teaches one research habit along the way: keep each record attached to its source and its date, and take each open question to the person who can answer it.

Who it's for

Anyone meeting a Nova Scotia tax sale for the first time: a curious neighbour, a first-time bidder, an owner or family member behind on taxes, a journalist or a student. You don't need a legal or real-estate background.

How it works

The chapters follow a sale in order. Inverness County's August 2026 sale in Port Hood is the main real example, compared with other municipalities. Harbour Road and the other named cases are fictional composites, built to show one lesson each without pointing at anyone's property.

How to read it

Each chapter opens with what it teaches and closes with its official sources. **Try it** boxes in the margin test one idea with a short answer. The footer of every page explains the abbreviations and new words used on that page, and the glossary at the back collects them all.

Words on this page

PDF Portable Document Format: a file that looks the same on every screen and printer.

Careful: This is a guide to a public process, not advice about a property. Laws, municipal practices and sale lists change, and every sale has its own terms. Before any decision, read the municipality's current notice, check the current statute, and ask a lawyer, surveyor, planner, inspector, insurer or accountant about the questions that belong to them. This book describes how to organise those questions. It never ranks properties or suggests what to bid.

What's dated

Laws are quoted as consolidated in 2026: the Municipal Government Act to 9 April 2026 and the Halifax Regional Municipality Charter to 1 May 2026. Municipal examples carry the date they were checked, mostly July 2026. Historical sale results come from the municipalities' own published results.

About this edition

This illustrated edition rewrites the 2026 text in plainer language and adds new diagrams and charts drawn from the official records. The facts, examples and sources are the same. The audiobook in the KinNoKi Labs Listening Room narrates the earlier text, so the wording you hear there differs from this book.

The interactive map used in Chapter 5 is NS Marks The Spot, at kinnokilabs.com/apps/nsmarksthespot/map, a free public tool by the same author.

Words on this page

NS Nova Scotia

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Earlier words: **NS** Nova Scotia · **PDF** Portable Document Format

Chapter 1

1 The Last Scene First

Why a municipality sells land for taxes, what happens before the auction, and the one habit this book keeps coming back to: separate what a record says from what you hope it means.

Picture an August morning in a parish hall in Port Hood, a few minutes before a tax sale begins. The place comes from Inverness County's notice; the room itself is a composite. A municipal treasurer has a list. Registered bidders wait for the first parcel to be called. Outside the room are owners, lenders, heirs, neighbours and sometimes people living on the land, and each of them has a stake in the row that is about to be read out.

FIGURE-01

Auction morning is collection work



A tax sale begins as municipal collection work, not a treasure hunt.

Auction morning at a Cape Breton community hall: the public part of a long collection process. (Illustration.)

Words on this page

treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

The auction is the part of a tax sale that people see. It is also the last scene of a much longer story.

Most people meet a Nova Scotia tax sale through an advertisement: a location, a parcel number, an amount owing. Inverness County gives readers far more than that. Its August 2026 packet is a substantial document. A typical entry combines the municipal account and parcel facts, an aerial image with the property outlined, a Property Online map and the legal description from the land registry. The packet also reminds readers that its map is for orientation and encourages them to research title.

That is good public work, and it saves a curious reader from starting with a blank page. It also invites a better question than "What can I add to this packet?" The better question is: **what does each part of this packet establish?**

One parcel, many jobs

Take a fictional composite parcel we will call Harbour Road. It is not one of the live properties and has no owner attached to it.

The municipal page gives Harbour Road an account number and a parcel identifier. It places a shape over an aerial photograph, reports the assessment, quotes the registry description and may say whether a dwelling is listed. Each item is useful, and each comes from a different system with its own job:

- the parcel shape helps you find the land; a surveyor locates the boundary;
- the aerial photo shows what was visible on the day it was flown;
- the legal description is the registry's wording, which a lawyer reads for rights and access;
- the assessment is a taxation record;
- a "no dwelling listed" entry is a line in the assessment, worth checking against what is on the ground.

Words on this page

legal description the registry's written description of a parcel: its boundaries and the rights that go with it, read by a lawyer or surveyor.

Maps make this easy to forget, because a coloured line around a piece of land looks like an answer. Treat it as an excellent starting point that tells you which records to pull next: the deed, the plans, the planning rules, a site visit from the road.

The Inverness packet also shows something useful about official records: they can disagree and still be worth using. Its first-page schedule lists **45 lien entries**. The detailed portion holds **44 property sheets.** Lien 6 appears in the summary with no matching sheet, and two recovery amounts differ between the summary and their detail pages.

Those differences are a question for the municipality. Careful research keeps both versions, names the two sources and asks the authority that runs the sale which one controls. Choosing the friendlier number because it makes the arithmetic work is the habit to avoid.

This is the first skill the book keeps returning to: **separate the record from the conclusion you want to draw from it.**

A set of smaller questions

"Due diligence" can sound like one giant mystery. It is really a set of smaller questions, each with its own source and sometimes its own professional:

- Which legal interest is being sold?
- Which parcel does the identifier point to?
- Is there lawful access?
- What do the current planning rules allow?
- What is physically on the land, and is anyone living there?
- What can happen between a winning bid and a deed?
- Which answers can a public record give, and which need a lawyer, surveyor, planner, inspector or insurer?

Words on this page

recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected: the amount a municipality advertises for a lien. Some call it the minimum or opening bid.

The route through those questions is the same in every chapter: **notice, parcel, context, unknowns, handoff**. Later chapters carry the research file into a written bid decision, the sale, the certificate months and the deed. One fictional parcel can't show every branch (a redeemed file never becomes a deed file), so Harbour Road opens the method and a few other composite cases test it under different facts.

Throughout, the researcher organizes the questions and the bidder makes the decision.

That division matters because tax sales attract the language of hidden gems and bargains. That language turns a municipal collection process into a treasure hunt and pushes the people outside the room out of the story. A clearer account gives everyone their place. The municipality is collecting taxes under a legal process. Owners and interest holders keep their rights until the law says otherwise. A bidder takes on uncertainty in stages. A researcher improves the evidence and marks what is still open.

So we start by giving the Inverness packet full credit as a strong first source. The value of the next layer comes from four steps: reconcile the records, add lawful public research, mark what remains open, and route each open question to the right authority.

Before Harbour Road can be called, though, we need to go back to the beginning. Why is the municipality selling land at all?

The first clock

The process starts with unpaid real-property taxes. The municipality is enforcing a debt, and that debt is attached to the land.

A **tax lien** is the municipality's legal claim against a property for unpaid tax. Under Nova Scotia's municipal statutes, it ranks ahead of other claims, liens and encumbrances, and it holds that priority

Words on this page

tax lien the municipality's legal claim on a property for unpaid tax: it ranks ahead of other claims and needs no registration.

encumbrance a claim or charge registered against land: such as a mortgage, lien or judgment.

without being registered. That is why the treasurer is in the room: the municipality is enforcing a charge created by law.

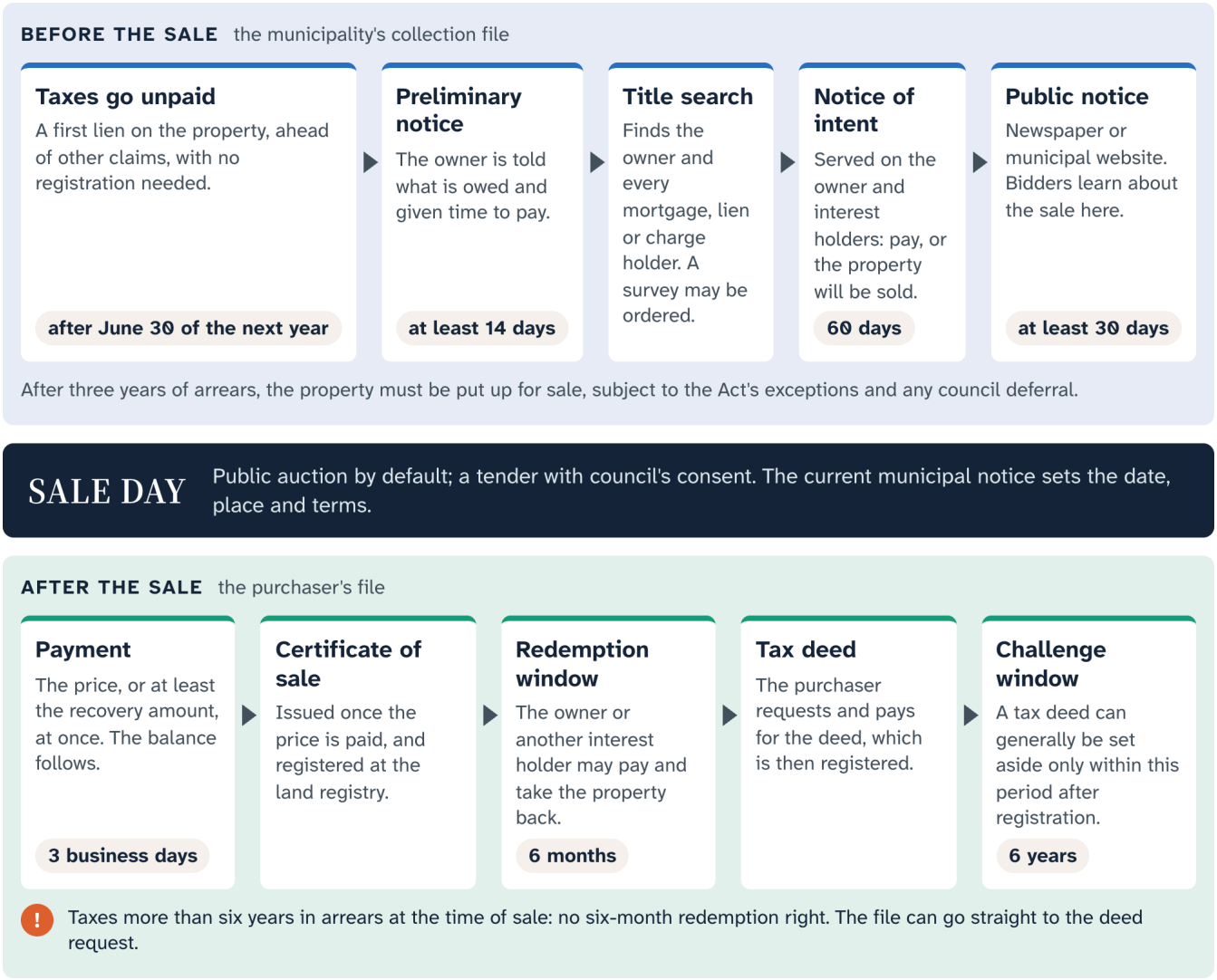
The lien starts a clock.

Outside Halifax, the Municipal Government Act lets a municipality begin proceedings for taxes unpaid from the immediately preceding taxation year, but not before June 30 of the following year. It also sets a backstop: subject to the Act's exceptions and a possible council deferral, a property must be put up for sale once taxes are unpaid for the three preceding fiscal years. Within that window a municipality may use a shorter trigger. Inverness and Chester, for example, describe accounts as eligible for sale after two years.

The provincial Act sets the outer frame, and each municipality describes how it works inside it. If Harbour Road sat in a different municipality, we would read that municipality's current process and notice.

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale



Municipal Government Act ss. 133–155 (Halifax: Charter ss. 147–170); Marketable Titles Act s. 6. Consolidations checked July 2026.

The whole process on one line. Everything left of the sale belongs to the municipality's collection file; everything right of it belongs to the purchaser's certificate and deed.

People before bidders

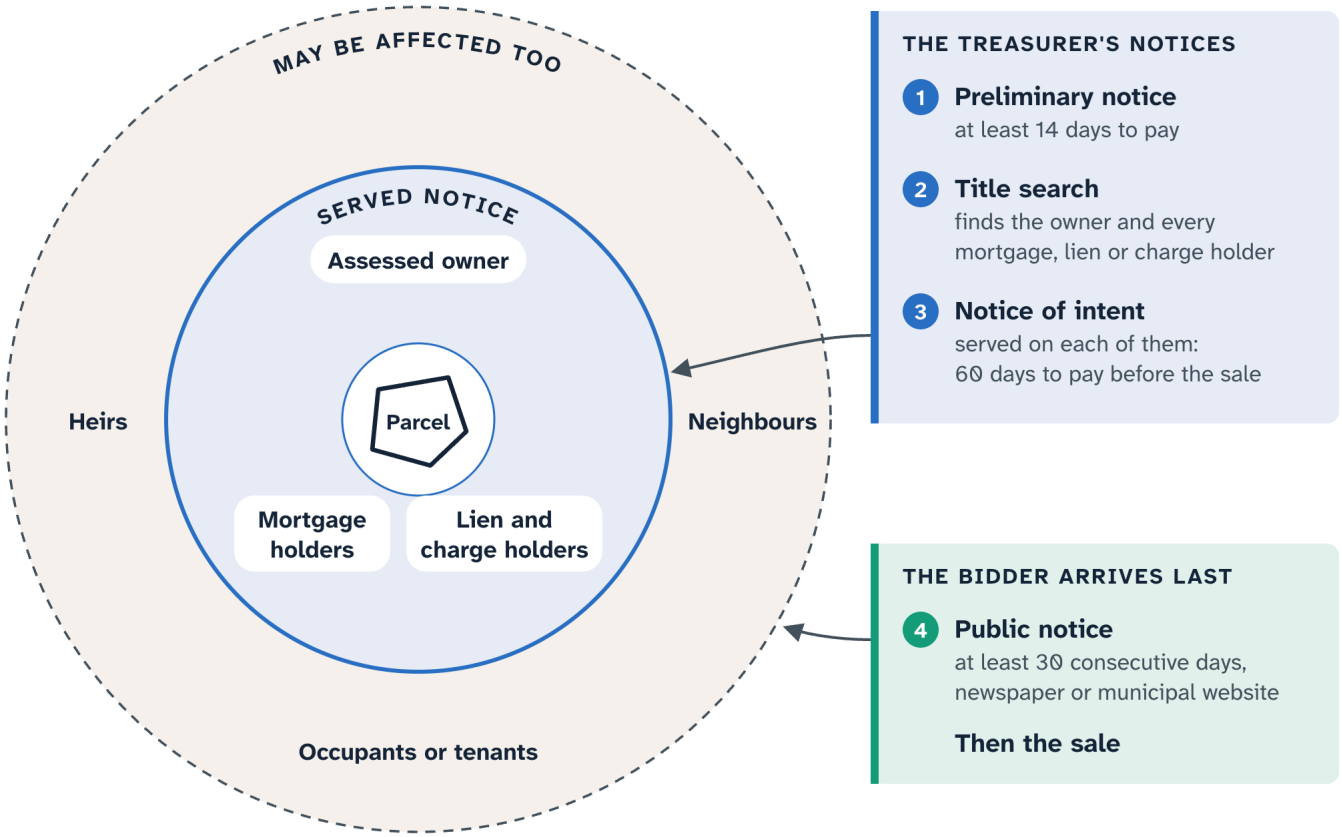
Before any sale, the municipality sends a **preliminary notice** giving at least fourteen days to pay. When that period ends, it runs a title search and may order a survey. The search identifies the owner and anyone whose mortgage, lien or charge gives them an interest in

Words on this page

Earlier words: **encumbrance** a claim or charge registered against land · **tax lien** the municipality's legal claim on a property for unpaid tax · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

the property. Each of them then receives a further notice giving sixty days to pay before the sale.

That further document is the **notice of intent**: a formal warning that the municipality will sell if the amounts stay unpaid. At this point the owner and the interest holders are in the story, and no bidder has appeared yet. The file is organized around legal identity and process because its first audience is the people who can still pay.



Municipal Government Act ss. 137–142 (Halifax: Charter ss. 151–157); CBRM tax-sale FAQ. Checked July 2026.

Who is in the story before a bidder arrives: the owner and anyone with a registered interest receive notices; occupants, heirs and neighbours may be affected too.

Only then does the sale go public. A sale or tender must have at least thirty consecutive days of public notice, either in a newspaper

Words on this page

notice of intent the formal warning that a property will be sold: served on the owner and interest holders, with sixty days to pay before the sale.

tender a sale by sealed written offers: opened after a deadline, used instead of an auction with council's consent.

in the way the statute requires or on the municipal website. The advertisement may describe the property briefly and send readers to the treasurer for the full description.

Imagine a municipal website posting this fictional line: “Harbour Road, parcel identifier ending 421, taxes and expenses owing.” Its job is to identify a property in a collection process and tell the public where the full record is. It is a notice, written for the law’s purposes. A map marker built from that notice does the same job: it takes you to the event and the apparent parcel.

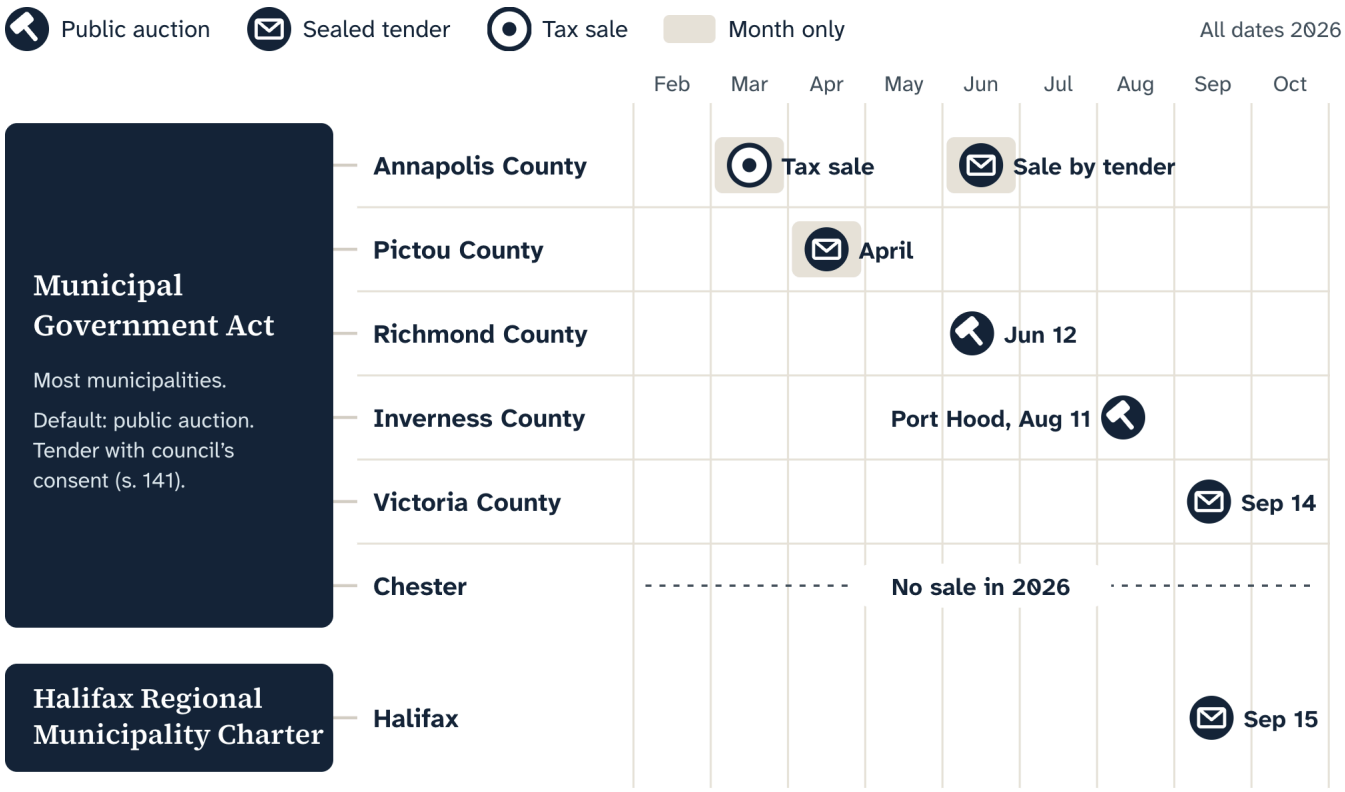
One law, many local events

The statute’s default is a **public auction**. With council’s consent, the treasurer may call for **tenders** instead, and council may set an acceptable minimum when a property might not recover all its taxes, interest and expenses.

Dated municipal examples show how much this varies. Inverness and Richmond have used open auctions. Pictou has used a sealed tender. Annapolis published results from a March tax sale and then from a June sale by tender. Chester said it would not hold a sale in 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **tender** a sale by sealed written offers



Municipal Government Act s. 141; Halifax Regional Municipality Charter s. 156. Municipal notices and results checked July 2026; Victoria and Halifax: September 2026 tenders. Dated examples: check the current notice.

One provincial framework, many local events. The Municipal Government Act sets the rules for most municipalities; Halifax follows its own Charter. Each municipality's current notice sets the event.

The provincial frame explains why a sale can happen. The municipality's current notice tells you whether this sale is happening, in what form and under which instructions.

Halifax works under its own law. Its tax sales follow the Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, a parallel framework to the tax-sale part of the Municipal Government Act. The sequence is similar; the authority is different. Halifax's administrative rules also make the hidden work in a file unusually visible, because they list the kinds of sale expenses a file can carry: notice, title search, survey, certificate and deed preparation, registration, closing and redemption administration. That list shows what the process involves. Each municipality sets its own charges.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **tender** a sale by sealed written offers · **notice of intent** the formal warning that a property will be sold · **encumbrance** a claim or charge registered against land

Try it

The map shows two current events: an Inverness auction and a Halifax sale. You want to know how the Halifax sale will run. Which source controls: the Inverness packet, the provincial map marker, or Halifax's current notice?

Answer: Halifax's current notice, issued under its Charter. The Inverness packet shows what good municipal information looks like, and the map takes you to the right place; the notice for the event sets the rules for that event.

We can now name the whole process. A **tax sale** is the statutory collection process through which a municipality offers a property once the required steps are complete. Its public face arrives only after a lien, the passage of time, record work and notices to people who may never set foot in the auction room.

Back in the Port Hood hall, the treasurer's list reads differently now. Each row is the far end of a municipal file and a legal clock. When the first parcel is called, the municipality is there to collect. What Harbour Road is worth, whether it suits anyone's plans and what remains uncertain after the hammer falls are questions for the bidder's own research, and that research is what the rest of this book is about.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 133 (tax lien and priority), s. 134 (when proceedings may begin and the three-year sale threshold), ss. 137–140 (preliminary notice, title search, survey and notice before sale), s. 141 (auction or tender), s. 142 (public notice of at least thirty days).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 147–157 (the parallel Halifax tax-sale provisions); Halifax Administrative Order 18, Schedule 1 (tax-sale expense categories), snapshot July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Inverness, tax sale property packet for 11 August 2026 (published 16 July 2026, retrieved 19 July 2026).
- Municipal practice examples as published by Inverness, Chester, Richmond, Pictou and Annapolis, checked 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

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Chapter 2

2 Reading the Notice

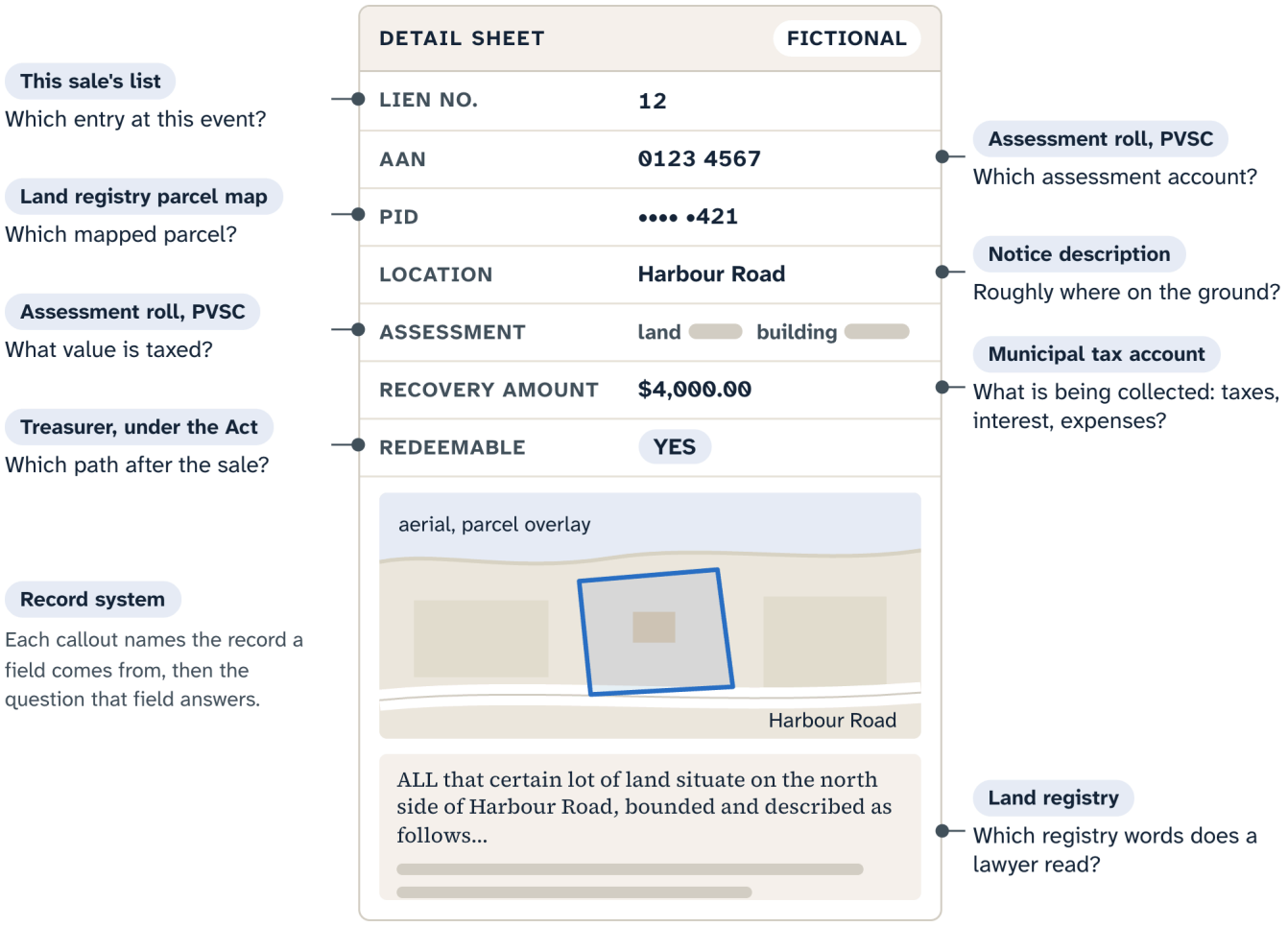
How to read a tax-sale entry field by field: which record system each number comes from, which question it answers, and how to keep a dated file while the sale list changes.

The Inverness packet gives each property a compact row before its detailed sheet. The row looks like a summary of one thing. It is a bundle of references to several record systems.

Return to Harbour Road. Its row might hold a lien number, an assessed-owner field, an assessment account number, a parcel identification number and a location. Separate land and building entries, a recovery amount and a redemption marker may follow. You take it in at a glance and feel that the property has been described. What you have is a set of handles for starting research.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected



Fictional composite modelled on the layout of the Inverness County packet for August 11, 2026. No real owner, account or parcel.

Anatomy of a tax-sale entry (fictional Harbour Road). Each field comes from a different record system and answers a different question.

Six fields, six jobs

The lien number is the municipality's label for the item in this sale. It lets the treasurer call the right entry, a bidder follow an amended list and everyone refer to the same row. Lien 6 in the August packet names a row in that sale only, and Halifax and Pictou number their own lists their own way.

The assessed-owner field belongs to the tax account. A notice may publish a name because the collection process has notice

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

requirements and the account must be identifiable. Here the name is an account label, and the person behind it keeps their privacy. It can help a qualified researcher match the account to authorized land records. Occupancy, beneficial interests, an estate or relationship that complicates title, and the person's plans for the arrears are separate questions. Harbour Road stays owner-free, and the lesson about records loses nothing.

The **Assessment Account Number (AAN)** identifies the account in the property assessment and municipal taxation system. That account can carry assessed value, classification and other taxation information. Boundaries, road access, ownership quality and approved uses live in other records. A file that treats the AAN as a universal property number can stay internally consistent while following the wrong object.

The **Parcel Identification Number (PID)** identifies a mapped land parcel in Nova Scotia's land-information systems. When you ask "Which parcel do these records appear to concern?", the PID is the stronger starting handle. It leads to parcel mapping and registry information. A parcel is a unit in the land-record system. Its drawn shape serves orientation and record lookup, and a surveyor locates each boundary on the ground. Access, permitted use, physical condition and freedom from competing interests have records of their own.

Think of the two numbers as catalogue keys, one for the assessment account and one for the mapped parcel. The wrong key opens the wrong catalogue.

A row carrying one AAN and one PID is evidence that the municipality associated that account and that parcel with the entry it published. Whether each building, driveway, fence, utility line or apparent yard you picture belongs to that parcel is a separate question, with its own source.

The location field helps you orient. It may give a street address, or only a community, a road name or a general location. An address

Words on this page

AAN Assessment Account Number: the number for a property's assessment and tax account.

PID Parcel Identification Number: the eight-digit number for a mapped land parcel in Nova Scotia's land records.

points toward a building or a civic point. The PID identifies the mapped parcel. The two can come apart. A building may sit near a parcel edge. A civic point may have been mapped for emergency response. A rural parcel may have no listing-style address. One entry may cover more than one parcel, or one apparent property may cross record boundaries invisible from the road. The address finds the area; the PID anchors the parcel question.

THE KEY	THE RECORD SYSTEM IT OPENS	THE QUESTIONS IT ANSWERS
AAN Assessment Account Number **0123 4567**	**Assessment roll** Property Valuation Services Corporation (PVSC)	• Assessed value? • Classification? • Which tax account?
PID Parcel Identification Number **•••• •421**	**Parcel map and land registry** Property Online	• Which mapped parcel? • Which documents are registered?
Civic address **Harbour Road**	**Civic addressing** the provincial emergency-location system	• Where on the ground? • Which road to start from?
Lien no. **12**	**This sale's list** one event only	• Which entry at this sale?

Harbour Road values are fictional. PVSC; Nova Scotia Property Online; provincial civic addressing. Checked July 2026.

Three handles, three record systems. Pick the key that matches the question.

The land and building fields come from **assessment**: the valuation and classification record used to support property taxation. The Property Valuation Services Corporation makes assessments searchable by civic address and AAN. The land and building split shows how the system has represented the account, and a zero or blank building entry can be worth investigating. Treat it as a lead, never as proof of vacant land. A structure may have been omitted,

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number

changed, removed, damaged, newly built or linked differently in the records. The assessment's date and purpose matter.

The assessed figure feels authoritative because it is precise, but its precision serves taxation. An inspection answers condition, and an appraisal prepared for a current transaction answers value. A survey answers boundaries, registry research answers rights, and planning confirmation answers permitted use. Auction value and a safe bid come from your own work, later in this book.

Property Online links these handles. It is Nova Scotia's subscription system for ownership, parcel mapping and registry information. Searches by PID, owner, AAN and civic address make it a powerful professional tool. This book keeps its screens, plans, registry documents, names and extracts off the page, even though the author has lawful access. It says instead which identifier to use, which record may answer a question, and when a lawyer or surveyor should read the result.

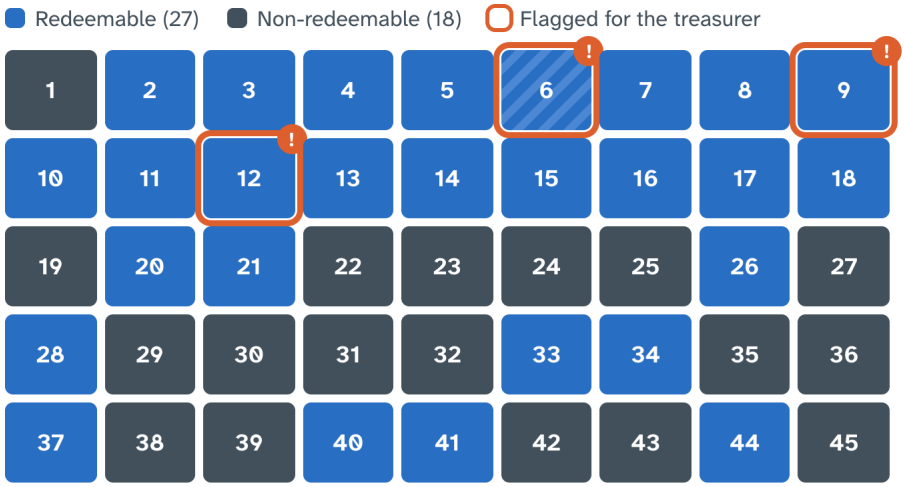
When the packet disagrees with itself

Chapter 1 noted that the real August 2026 Inverness packet disagrees with itself. Its summary lists 45 lien entries, and its detailed portion holds 44 property sheets. Lien 6 has no sheet in the downloaded packet, and two amounts differ between the summary and the detail page.

Keep both versions. For each source, record the lien number, AAN, PID, page and retrieval date it gives, and keep the awkward version beside the tidy one. The municipality owns the live sale process and can say which information controls.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number



45
liens on the summary schedule

44
detail sheets in the packet. Lien 6 has none.

2
amounts that differ between summary and detail sheet:

Lien 9 summary	$9,348.38
detail sheet	$9,384.38
Lien 12 summary	$57,875.01
detail sheet	$57,578.01

Keep both versions. Ask the treasurer which one controls.

Inverness County tax sale property packet for August 11, 2026: summary schedule and detail sheets, published July 16, retrieved July 19, 2026. Lien numbers only; no owners or addresses.

The Inverness County packet for August 11, 2026: 45 liens on the summary, 27 redeemable and 18 non-redeemable. Lien 6 has no detail sheet, and liens 9 and 12 show different amounts on the summary and the detail page.

Harbour Road's file can now hold a short source table:

- sale lien number: the event entry;
- AAN: the assessment account;
- PID: the mapped parcel handle;
- address or location: geographic orientation;
- land and building assessment fields: taxation records;
- municipal detail sheet: the municipality's expanded information for the dated event.

Read it as a routing sheet. Beside each field goes a question: who created it, what date it describes, what it can support, and which conclusion belongs to another source.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **PID** Parcel Identification Number

Routing pays off when fields disagree. Say the address points to one building and the PID map outlines a different shape. Picking the more plausible picture is the trap. Send the address question to civic and municipal sources and the parcel question to land records. Boundaries go to survey evidence; title goes to registry records and legal interpretation.

Harbour Road looks less simple now, and that is progress. The notice reads less like a real-estate listing and more like the first index card in a traceable research file.

The fields that pull hardest

Two small fields tend to take over a notice: the advertised amount and the redemption marker.

The advertised amount looks like a price. Typography does the persuading: a parcel, a dollar figure and a sale date share one line, and the mind supplies an asking price. It may be far below ordinary real-estate numbers.

Its job is narrower. The amount is built around the taxes, interest and sale expenses the municipality seeks to recover through the process. When the packet uses the term, this book calls it the **recovery amount**, a name that states its purpose. Another municipality may say "minimum bid" or use another event-specific term, and its current notice controls.

> **Careful:** Under any label, the recovery amount is a collection figure for one dated event. It is set without inspecting the property or asking what an informed buyer would pay. Condition, title quality, legal access, repair costs, insurability, limits on future use, value and a safe bid all sit outside it.

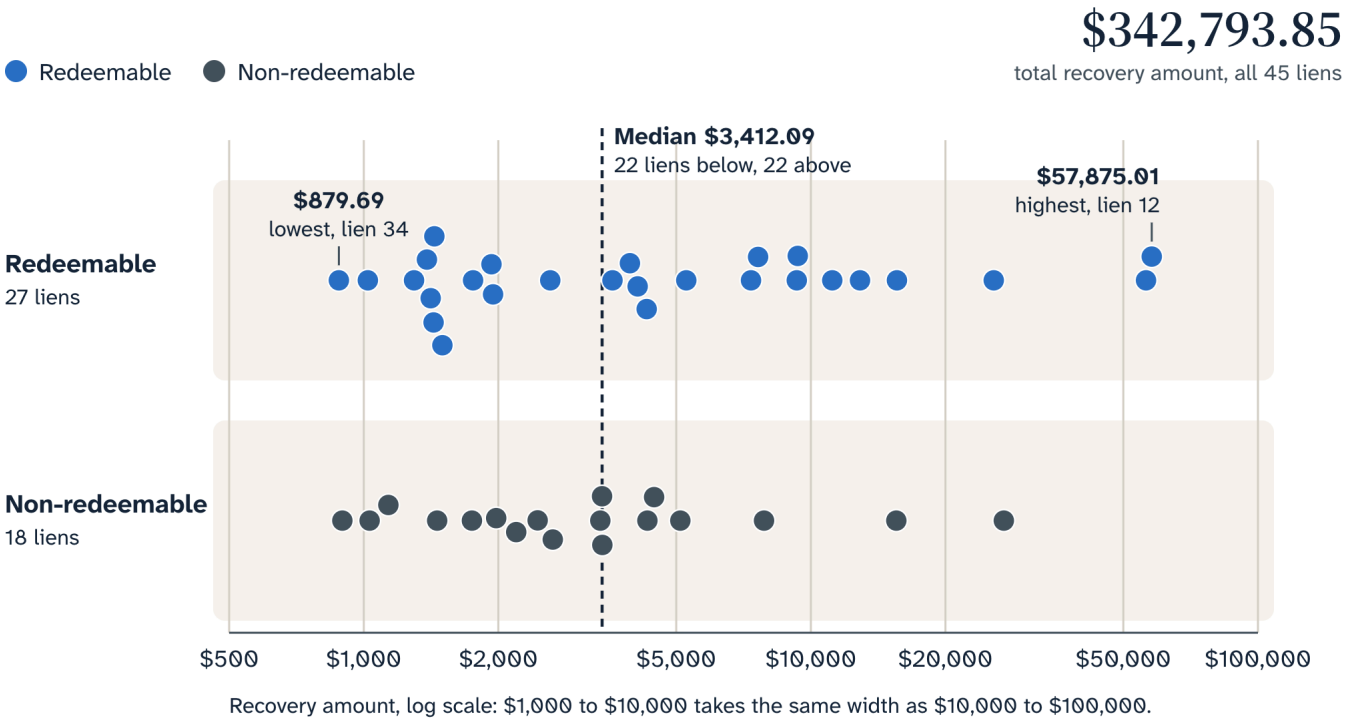
Say Harbour Road's recovery amount is $4,000. That supports one statement: "The municipality published $4,000 for this dated event under its stated terms." Deciding whether Harbour Road is worth more or less takes title, access, planning, condition, occupancy, tax, repair and uncertainty work. Objecting that the number looks

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

small gets you no closer. Setting the assessment beside it only compares two administrative records, one from taxation and one from collection.

The real packet shows how widely these figures range from row to row.



Inverness County tax sale property packet for August 11, 2026: summary schedule amounts, published July 16, retrieved July 19, 2026. Liens 9 and 12 show different amounts on their detail sheets. Lien numbers only.

Recovery amounts on the summary schedule of the August 2026 Inverness packet ranged from $879.69 to $57,875.01; the median was $3,412.09 and the total $342,793.85. Each is the amount the municipality is collecting, set before anyone bids.

The packet also shows why even an administrative number stays tied to its source. Where its summary and a detail page give different recovery amounts, keep both and ask the municipality which governs. Picking the lower one is wishful arithmetic. Picking the higher one because it feels safer is still an unsupported correction.

Words on this page

Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

The redemption marker pulls the other way. “Redeemable” sounds like a feature of the parcel; it describes the legal path after the sale. Nova Scotia’s municipal statutes normally provide a six-month redemption period. Within it, an owner or another person with a qualifying interest may redeem the property by paying the treasurer the amount the statute sets.

Careful: The statutes remove that six-month right when the taxes were already more than six years in arrears at the time of sale. Municipal material may therefore mark such an entry as one that can move toward an immediate deed. Here “immediate deed” means a deed without the six-month redemption period. The marker does not settle possession, insurability, condition, clean title or permission to use the land.

At the notice stage, the marker tells you which branch to prepare for. Chapter 3 follows both branches through the certificate, protective duties, repayment accounting and the deed request.

The August summary marks 27 entries redeemable and 18 non-redeemable. Those counts describe the packet on its publication date. Any entry may still drop out before the sale, or move between categories in a municipal update.

A list that keeps moving

A tax-sale list stays fluid while collection continues. A listed parcel may be paid, redeemed, removed or deferred before or around the event. A municipality may publish a revision, and a sale may hold fewer rows than an earlier advertisement. You can research a parcel carefully and arrive to find its lien off the list.

That is the process working. The municipality’s job is to collect under the statute, and a payment or a lawful removal means the notice helped do it. The hours you spent on the row give you no claim on the auction.

Words on this page

redemption period the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back: lost when taxes were more than six years in arrears at the time of sale.

Here the living map enters the book's method. The checked build of NS Marks The Spot organizes current notices for the July 2026 Cape Breton Regional Municipality event and the August 2026 Inverness event. It filters by municipality, event and redemption category, and it can open a direct link to the official source. It is a dated catalogue that shortens the route back to the authority. The municipality decides whether a lien remains for sale. When a redemption category matters for a live decision, the source row, the current notice and qualified legal advice settle it, whatever the filter shows.

Try it

You saved the Inverness packet when it had 45 summary rows. On auction morning the map shows fewer entries, and you have a screenshot from several days earlier. Which count goes on your working list?

Answer: The municipality's current one. Open the map's direct municipal source, check the current notice or update, and ask the treasurer if the published sources still conflict. Record the retrieval time. The earlier packet stays in the file as accurate evidence of what was published then.

A file that survives a break

Test the file by interrupting it. You come back days later with a printed packet, a bookmark and notes that made sense when you wrote them. With its evidence and dates, the file should answer four plain questions without help from memory:

1. Which number identifies the mapped parcel? The PID.
2. Which number identifies the assessment account? The AAN.
3. Which source says whether the lien remains in the current event? The municipality's current notice, or direct confirmation from the authority running the sale.
4. What does a non-redeemable marker establish? The branch without the normal six-month statutory redemption right, because of the age of the arrears.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NS** Nova Scotia · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

The test also catches a common versioning error. A file labelled "Inverness tax sale" can mix the original packet, a later update, a map snapshot and auction-day notes, all undated. Each source is authentic, and the combined file still misleads, because nobody can tell which rows existed when.

Harbour Road's dated file. "Packet retrieved July 20" describes one snapshot. "Municipal page checked August 10" describes a later state. "Treasurer confirmed withdrawn August 11" would describe an event-day fact, if that confirmation occurred. The dates preserve change: each document keeps its own moment.

The index card carries two dates: when the packet was retrieved and when the event status was last checked. Every amount and marker has a source beside it. A recovery amount without a page and date is a number detached from its authority. "Redeemable" without the current notice is a label detached from its branch.

Read a withdrawal narrowly. It can mean the amount was paid or the row was otherwise removed or deferred under the process. Without an authoritative explanation, the public record may support only the status word and the date. A defect, an owner's win in a dispute or a municipal error stays a guess.

The map's historical-result mode answers a different question. A verified result documents the outcome recorded for a parcel at an earlier event. The current notice says whether a lien is active now. They are different record families, even when the same PID appears in both.

A withdrawn row was always part of a collection list. When it leaves, the collection process has changed before the event, and your file shows when and how the public record changed.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: ss. 141, 143 and 148 (taxes, interest and expenses recovered by a sale); ss. 152(1) and 155 (six-month redemption and the older-arrears exception). Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 167(1) and 170.

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

- Nova Scotia Property Online page and user guide; Land Registration Administration Regulations; Deed Transfer Affidavit information (AAN and PID).
- Property Valuation Services Corporation, Find an Assessment, checked 20 July 2026; GeoNOVA mapping products.
- Municipality of the County of Inverness, tax sale property packet for 11 August 2026 (published 16 July 2026, retrieved 19 July 2026).
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality Tax Sales page, frequently asked questions and map disclaimer; Chester tax-sale process; both checked 20 July 2026.
- NS Marks The Spot production build, source commit d3114b5c, checked 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **NS** Nova Scotia

Chapter 3

3 The Six-Month Door

What a winning bidder holds after paying, what a certificate holder may and must do while the owner can still redeem, and the two ways the file ends: a discharge or a tax deed.

Back in the Port Hood hall, Harbour Road is called. A bidder raises a card, wins and pays what the sale terms require. The public scene feels finished. The legal position has just become more complicated.

For a redeemable property like Harbour Road, full payment produces a **certificate of sale**. The municipal treasurer prepares it, gives it to the purchaser and registers a copy in the land registry. The purchaser is now the **certificate holder**.

The six months

The redemption marker from Chapter 2 now becomes a working mechanism. For most tax-sale properties, the owner or another person with a qualifying interest has six months after the sale to redeem.

Careful: The six-month right has one large exception. When the taxes were already more than six years in arrears at the time of sale, the normal statutory redemption right does not apply. Those older-arrears properties follow the immediate-deed branch.

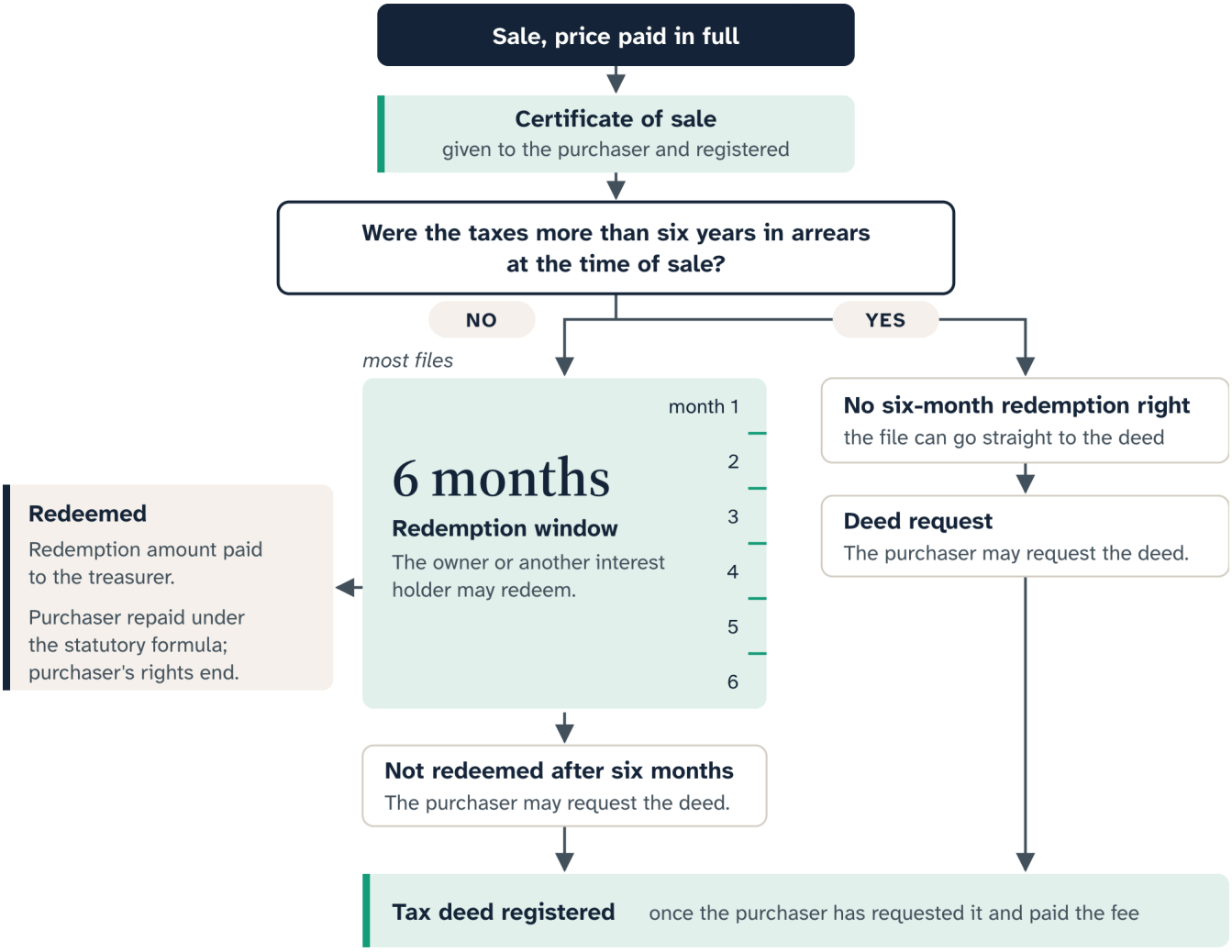
Harbour Road is on the six-month branch, so the owner and other qualifying interest holders still have a live statutory route back to the property. That leaves the certificate holder in a middle state,

Words on this page

tax deed the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period: it vests title free of encumbrances, as the statute specifies; easements and rights-of-way continue.

certificate of sale the document a purchaser receives after paying in full: it is registered at the land registry and gives limited powers to protect the property until the deed.

with more responsibility than a prospective bidder and less finality than an owner with a deed.



Municipal Government Act ss. 150–155 (Halifax: Charter ss. 165–170). Consolidations checked July 2026.

Two paths after the hammer. Most files carry a six-month redemption right; files with taxes more than six years in arrears at the sale can go to deed without it.

What a certificate holder may and must do

A certificate holder may protect the land, use it without diminishing its value, and collect rent. The holder must not injure

Words on this page

Earlier words: **certificate of sale** the document a purchaser receives after paying in full · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **redemption period** the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back

the property or cut trees, and must insure any building that is insurable.

Each power has limits. Protection can support the work needed to keep an insurable building from deteriorating; a general renovation for the holder's preferred future use is another job. Using the land still answers to planning law, tenancy, occupancy, safety and the continuing redemption right. Rent collection raises questions for a lawyer: who occupies the premises, and how communication and accounting must lawfully happen.

Careful: The duty to insure covers insurable buildings, and the statute cannot force an insurer to offer a policy for every vacant, damaged, occupied, remote or otherwise non-standard risk. Get a workable insurance answer before the sale. A bidder who wins without one may inherit the duty with no practical policy ready to meet it.

A leak in month two

In the second month, a storm damages the roof of Harbour Road's modest building, and water is coming in near an exterior wall. The certificate holder has to act. What work will prevent further damage? Who should authorize it? Which insurer must be told? What records will later prove what the work was and what it cost?

Protection is about preserving the property through a conditional period. It stops short of gutting the interior, clearing healthy trees for a view, changing the use or treating the building as vacant without evidence.

Keep a ledger from the first day. New tax bills, insurance premiums, necessary protective work, rent and other income can all matter if the owner redeems. Months later it may have to answer a treasurer or a lawyer, and money and authorizations rebuilt from bank statements and memory are unreliable.

The people outside the auction room are still on this clock. The owner may be arranging funds, and a lender or another interest holder may be weighing its position. An occupant may hear from

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

someone who paid at a tax sale but holds no deed. A contractor may see the leak and wonder who can authorize which work. The treasurer runs the municipal process, and lawyers, insurers and other professionals answer the questions within their authority.

Four questions before acting

Before acting, the certificate holder should be able to answer four stage questions:

- What document do I hold?
- Which power or duty supports the proposed action?
- Which continuing right or legal boundary limits it?
- What record will I need if the property is redeemed or goes to deed?

The leaking roof, run through the four questions:

The document is the registered certificate, and the action is protective work. The redemption right remains, along with any occupancy or tenancy obligations. The file needs insurer communication, professional advice where required, lawfully taken photographs, invoices, proof of payment and the municipality's approval where the statutory accounting calls for it.

The questions are a stage check, with the legal tests left to a lawyer. They stop the broad word "owner" from hiding which document is in hand and which limits apply right now.

When the owner redeems

In month four, with the building insured and protected and the necessary work documented, the owner produces the funds to redeem. The statute controls this branch, and the certificate holder's convenience is beside the point. What looked like an ownership project has become an accounting and discharge file.

The statutes set the redemption payment, and the holder claims within their categories. The payment starts with the purchase price

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

plus interest at ten percent a year from the sale to the redemption. Then come specified costs from the certificate period: the taxes the statute lists, including later taxes and interest; the registry fee for the certificate of discharge; fire-insurance premiums; and necessary repairs the treasurer approved. Rent or other income from the property, and any surplus from the sale, reduce it. In a real redemption, the exact facts, dates, approvals and local administration matter.

REDEMPTION AMOUNT — paid to the treasurer

THE PRICE

Purchase sum — the price on the certificate of sale — $ _____

INTEREST

\+ **Interest at 10% a year** — from the day of sale to the day of redemption — $ _____

COSTS OF THE CERTIFICATE PERIOD

\+ **Taxes the statute specifies** — older and newer — $ _____

\+ **Registry fee** — $ _____

\+ **Fire-insurance premiums** — qualifying premiums — $ _____

\+ **Necessary repairs** — approved by the treasurer — $ _____

ADJUSTMENTS

− **Surplus from the sale** — $ _____

− **Rent or other income** — the purchaser received from the property — $ _____

= **Redemption amount** — $ _____

The interest clock

10% a year

sale day — redemption day

Repairs without approval

are at the purchaser's risk.

Paid in full

The purchaser is repaid under the statutory formula and the purchaser's rights in the land end.

Municipal Government Act s. 152(2)–(4), ss. 153–154 (Halifax: Charter s. 167(2)–(4), ss. 168–169). Consolidations checked July 2026.

What a redemption payment generally includes under the statute: the purchase money plus 10% a year, certain taxes, the registry fee, qualifying insurance premiums and approved repairs, adjusted for surplus and income from the property.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

The ledger matters more than the formula. Every claimed dollar needs a source, every repair a reason and the treasurer's approval, and every offset a record.

The roof shows why. An invoice proves a contractor was paid. Whether the work was necessary, whether it belongs in the calculation and whether it was approved are separate questions. The month-two file answers each one: the insurance file, photographs, a professional assessment, the municipality's correspondence and the proof of payment.

The same discipline runs both ways. Rent collected stays in the file, though it makes the repayment smaller. A cost that served the holder's own future project stays outside the qualifying items, even when it is called a repair. The statute sets the categories, whatever the labels say.

When the qualifying person pays the full redemption amount, the purchaser is repaid under the statutory process and loses rights in the land. A **discharge** of the certificate documents the ending, and the holder's control of Harbour Road ends with it.

That loss is easy to understate after months of protecting a building and picturing its future. The purchaser may receive the repayment the statute requires, but cannot refuse it and keep the land instead. Redemption is one of the outcomes built into the position bought at the sale. The owner and interest holders were in the legal story all along, even while absent from the Port Hood hall.

Try it

During the certificate months, Harbour Road's holder pays for two jobs: a roof repair the treasurer approved, and clearing healthy trees for a sea view. The owner then redeems. Which cost belongs in the redemption calculation?

Answer: The roof repair, because it was necessary, protective and approved. Clearing the trees breaks the rule against cutting trees, and work for the holder's own plans sits outside the statutory categories.

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

The deed branch

Now give Harbour Road a different ending: six months pass without redemption. Or take an older-arrears property, which skips the wait. Either way, the purchaser can move toward a **tax deed**: the municipality's deed, which the purchaser may request and pay a fee for once the applicable waiting period ends.

Under the municipal statutes, the tax deed vests fee-simple title free of encumbrances, subject to the statutes' treatment of continuing easements and rights-of-way. A lawyer reads those words against the actual parcel and its records. Keep them whole in any auction conversation; "clean title" is the shorthand to avoid.

Fee simple names a form of ownership. Every other question about the land keeps its own source. An inspection answers condition and a surveyor the boundary. Access comes from the registry, the plans and a lawyer; development approval comes from the planning authority. A lawyer advises on anyone living there, and an insurer decides cover. A tax deed can also be challenged for a set period after registration, as Chapter 12 explains.

"Immediate deed" describes timing only: the older-arrears category skips the normal six-month period, and the questions above still take their own time.

Words on this page

fee simple full ownership of land

easement a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose: such as a driveway, a utility line or drainage.

right-of-way a legal right to cross someone else's land: usually registered on title; a path in use may or may not have one.

Two parcels, one auction

Two parcels are called at the same auction. Harbour Road is marked redeemable. Quarry Lane, another fictional composite, is in the older-arrears category. Both purchasers pay in full.

Four months later, Harbour Road is redeemed and its certificate discharged. Quarry Lane's purchaser, with no six-month right to wait out, requests the deed and registers it. That deed is the ownership document for this stage. Whether the apparent driveway is a legal right-of-way, and whether someone lives in the building, are still questions for the registry and a lawyer.

That is the redemption marker at work. "Redeemable" points toward a certificate period that may end in a discharge or a deed. "Non-redeemable" points toward the deed route without the six-month door.

The documents run in order: bid, payment, registered certificate, then a discharge or a deed. Each one has its own job and its own hazards, even when one purchaser holds them all.

Harbour Road leaves this chapter through a discharge, and its purchaser's rights have ended. Quarry Lane leaves through a registered deed, and its purchaser's ownership work has begun. Both endings point back to research that belongs before the bid, starting with the parcel biography in Chapter 4.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 150 (certificate of sale), s. 151 (the certificate holder's powers and duties, including insurance), s. 152 (six-month redemption, the six-year arrears exception and the redemption amount), ss. 153–154 (repayment and the end of the purchaser's rights), ss. 155–156 (the tax deed and its effect).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 165–171 (the parallel Halifax provisions).
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and FAQ (redeemable and non-redeemable categories; occupied properties), checked 20 July 2026.
- Intact Insurance, vacant-home and non-standard property pages, retrieved 19 July 2026.

Words on this page

FAQ frequently asked questions

Chapter 4

4 Give the Parcel a Biography

How to build a dated research file for one parcel: credit what the municipality has already gathered, keep each record to its own job, label every observation, and send each open question to the person who can answer it.

Inverness County's August 2026 packet does more than a typical auction advertisement. Each detailed entry gathers account and parcel identifiers, assessment figures, mapped views and a legal description. Copying those fields onto a prettier page improves the look and adds nothing to what anyone knows.

Start with an inventory instead. Which facts came from the packet, and which source did the municipality name? Which details describe the auction event, which the assessment account, and which are offered as a description of the parcel? The inventory credits the municipality and keeps later research from passing as original discovery.

From there, the file follows the book's route: notice, parcel, context, unknowns, handoff.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel



The research route used for every case file in this book. Each entry carries its source and the date checked.

The research route used throughout this book: notice, parcel, context, unknowns, handoff.

The source ledger

Take a fictional composite entry on Birch Point Road. Its packet row supplies a lien number, an Assessment Account Number (AAN), a Parcel Identification Number (PID), a civic location, assessment fields, a recovery amount and a redemption marker. The detailed page adds mapped orientation and descriptive material. Each field already has a job; the biography gives the collection a history.

The first page of the file is a source ledger. Each line records a source, a retrieval date and a limitation:

- event status and recovery amount: the municipality's dated notice;
- assessment fields: the account information reproduced in the packet;
- PID: a pointer to the provincial parcel and registry systems;
- mapped image: orientation;
- legal description: text that needs land-record interpretation.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

FIGURE-09

Build a traceable evidence file



The researcher's product is a traceable evidence file, not a verdict.

A research file is a stack of dated sources, each labelled with what it answers. (Illustration.)

The ledger earns its place when records disagree. In the Inverness packet, one summary lien has no matching detail sheet, and two recovery amounts differ between summary and detail. The biography keeps both versions with their dates and locations, and asks the municipality about the current event.

The biography starts with the PID, the stable parcel handle already in the file, and leaves the owner's name out. Owner-free, it still shows the whole method: exact PID, source, observation, limitation, open question, next authority.

Two routes open a biography on the NS Marks The Spot map. An exact PID selects the parcel returned for that identifier. An authoritative provincial civic-address result opens the parcel polygon that contains its point. Both save time; Chapter 5 works them in detail. Ownership, occupancy, legal access, the surveyed boundary and permission to enter remain questions for the records and professionals later in this chapter.

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **NS** Nova Scotia · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

Property Online and the parcel register

An authorized land-record researcher can use Property Online to connect the PID to provincial ownership, parcel-mapping and registry information. Searches by AAN, civic address or owner solve different matching problems. This book keeps that material off its pages: subscription access is for authorized research and carries no licence to republish subscriber screenshots, plans, registry documents, owner information or structured extracts.

In a lawyer's title review, the **parcel register** is the parcel-specific registry record within that material. It takes the file past the assessed-owner label on an auction notice to the documents and registered interests that need interpretation.

Keep three things apart. The search or register view is a dated snapshot. The source instrument, release, agreement or order holds the terms. The legal effect, including what the tax-deed provisions change and what they leave in place, needs the governing law and a reading specific to the property.

A mortgage, judgment, easement or other interest on the register is a lead, and the reviewing lawyer works out the rest: how it operates, whether another instrument changes it, its present amount, any release, its priority and its treatment after the sale.

Record the retrieval date and refresh the search near the decision. If a recent registration, pending document, court order or conflicting entry could matter, ask the land registration office or the reviewing lawyer what the current search might miss. A fresh result can change the question without answering it on its own.

The legal description

A civic address helps people find a place. A **legal description** identifies land in the language of the conveyancing record. It may refer to bearings, distances, adjoining lands, plans, lots, roads,

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **easement** a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

shorelines or older descriptions. Its job is to state what the instrument describes, for readers of the record more than for drivers.

On Birch Point Road, the civic location may bring you to the area, the PID may open a polygon on a public parcel map, and an aerial view may show a roof, a tree line, a road or a clearing. The legal description may refer to boundaries that are invisible in those pixels and unsafe to rebuild from them. The records support one another without standing in for each other.

A public parcel boundary is a screening exhibit: the shape reported by the current provincial service, good for orientation and for questions about apparent road or water relationships. A surveyor's evidence and the legal record answer where the boundary lies on the ground.

Attribution travels with the image

Public views from NS Aerial and the Nova Scotia Property Records Database (NSPRD) carry a licence obligation. A rendered view from the covered Province services must keep the Province attribution: "Contains information obtained under license from the Province of Nova Scotia which is provided without warranty or liability for errors or omissions." The application must link to the licence. The attribution sits in the image, because a screenshot may travel beyond the app that made it.

The licence permits the checked public display, and this book makes no assumption that it covers redistributing raw geometry or a tile cache. Three questions stay separate: may the view be shown, where did it come from, and what does it prove? The licence and the attribution answer the first two.

Words on this page

NSPRD Nova Scotia Property Records Database: the Province's mapped parcel boundaries.

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **NS** Nova Scotia

Title search

The last land-record term is **title search**: an examination of the chain of ownership and interests, well beyond a look at the latest name. Before a tax sale, the municipality does title work as part of the statutory notice process, to help identify the people entitled to notice.

Careful: The municipality's title work moves a tax-enforcement process through its required stages. A bidder decides something else: whether the legal position, the uncertainty, the project and the price belong together. For that decision, a bidder may need a lawyer to examine the records. The questions overlap; the professional duty and the conclusion differ.

Words that report

Each record in Birch Point Road's ledger becomes an observation that stays within what its source did:

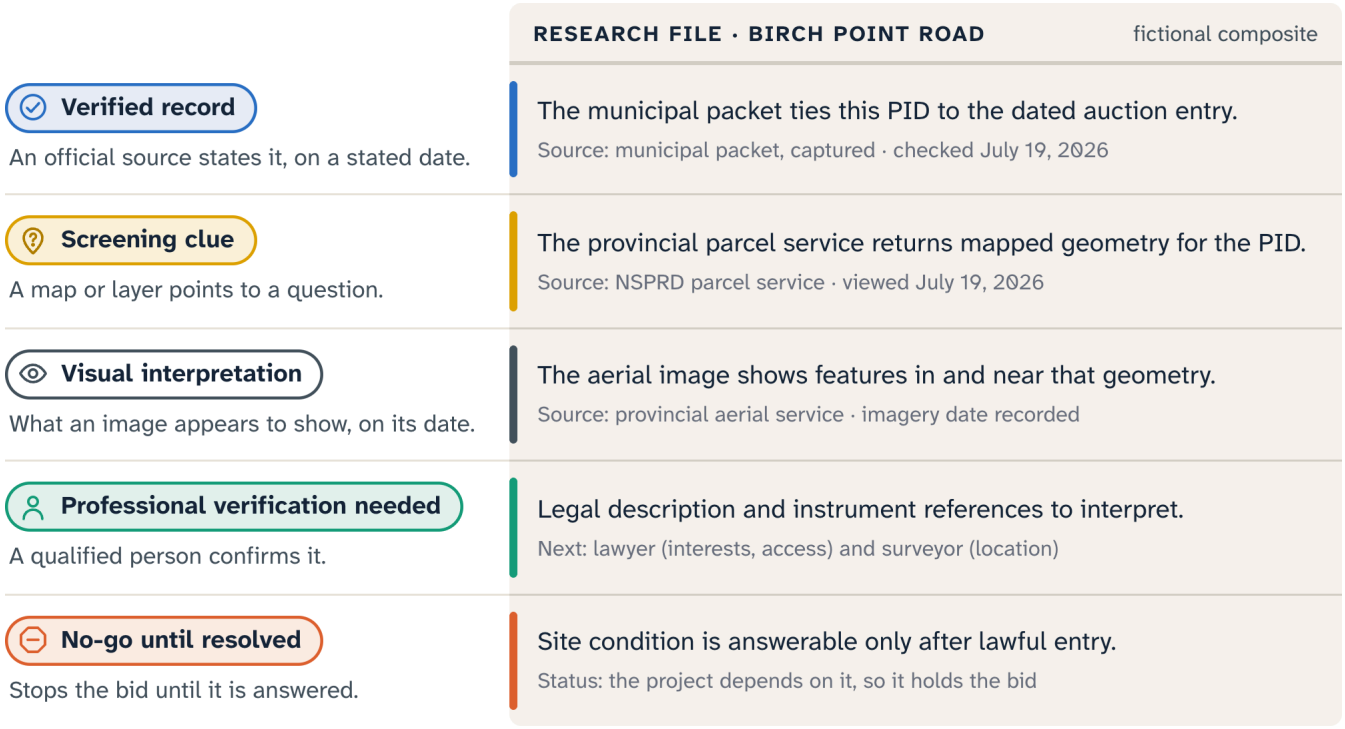
- The municipal packet associates this exact PID with this dated auction entry.
- The current provincial parcel service returns mapped geometry for the PID.
- The aerial service shows visible features within and near that reported geometry on its captured imagery.
- The land record contains a legal description and instrument references that need professional interpretation.

"Associates," "returns," "shows" and "contains" report what a source did. "Owns," "bounds," "permits" and "guarantees" are conclusions that wait for a qualified person.

Each observation also gets a label. In order, those four lines are a verified record, a screening clue, a visual interpretation and an entry that needs professional verification. The fifth label, no-go until resolved, marks a question that stops the bid.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel



Labels used for every entry in this book's research files. Example entries follow Birch Point Road, chapter 4's fictional composite.

Five labels that keep a research file honest. Every entry gets one.

Four places an unknown can go

Labels grade each observation; sorting decides what happens next. Every entry goes to one of four places, gaps included, because a report that allows only confident sentences turns its gaps into assumptions.

The first place is verified. The dated notice associates an exact PID with an auction entry, and the file holds the source, the date and the captured record. “Verified” describes that match. Assessed value and classification are verified the same way, as account information matched to its source and date. Boundary, condition, title, legal access, market value and a maximum bid each go through the sort on their own.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

The second is professionally verifiable. The parcel service shows geometry that appears to meet a road corridor, and the legal description refers to a plan. Whether that gives the frontage or right-of-way the intended use requires is a question for a surveyor, a lawyer and a planner. The label names a question, an evidence source and a competent route to an answer. That answer may remove the concern, define a manageable condition or end the project.

The third is priceable uncertainty. Suppose an insurer confirms that a vacant building can be covered only under specified terms and at a higher, known premium. That uncertainty can now enter a budget, as a quoted survey, a defined legal review or a known municipal application fee can. Priceable means a documented amount or a bounded range, with no invented number. A known cost can still make the parcel unworkable.

The fourth is no-go: a fact essential to the intended project that the researcher is unable to confirm before the sale. The answer may need entry, which the municipality has no power to authorize, or a study that needs more time than the sale allows. The evidence may stay contradictory, or the legal position may be too consequential to carry unresolved. The right label can then be “do not proceed under these conditions.” It describes the fit between the evidence, the deadline, the researcher’s tolerance and the proposed use. Another person with different expertise, authority, time or capacity for risk may decide differently.

Try it

You return to the Birch Point Road file after a week away. Which four questions put it back in order?

Answer: What does the file establish? Which named professional or source owns the next gap? Can a documented answer enter the budget? Is an essential gap still open and too large to carry? If so, stop before attachment rewrites the evidence.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Handing off the questions

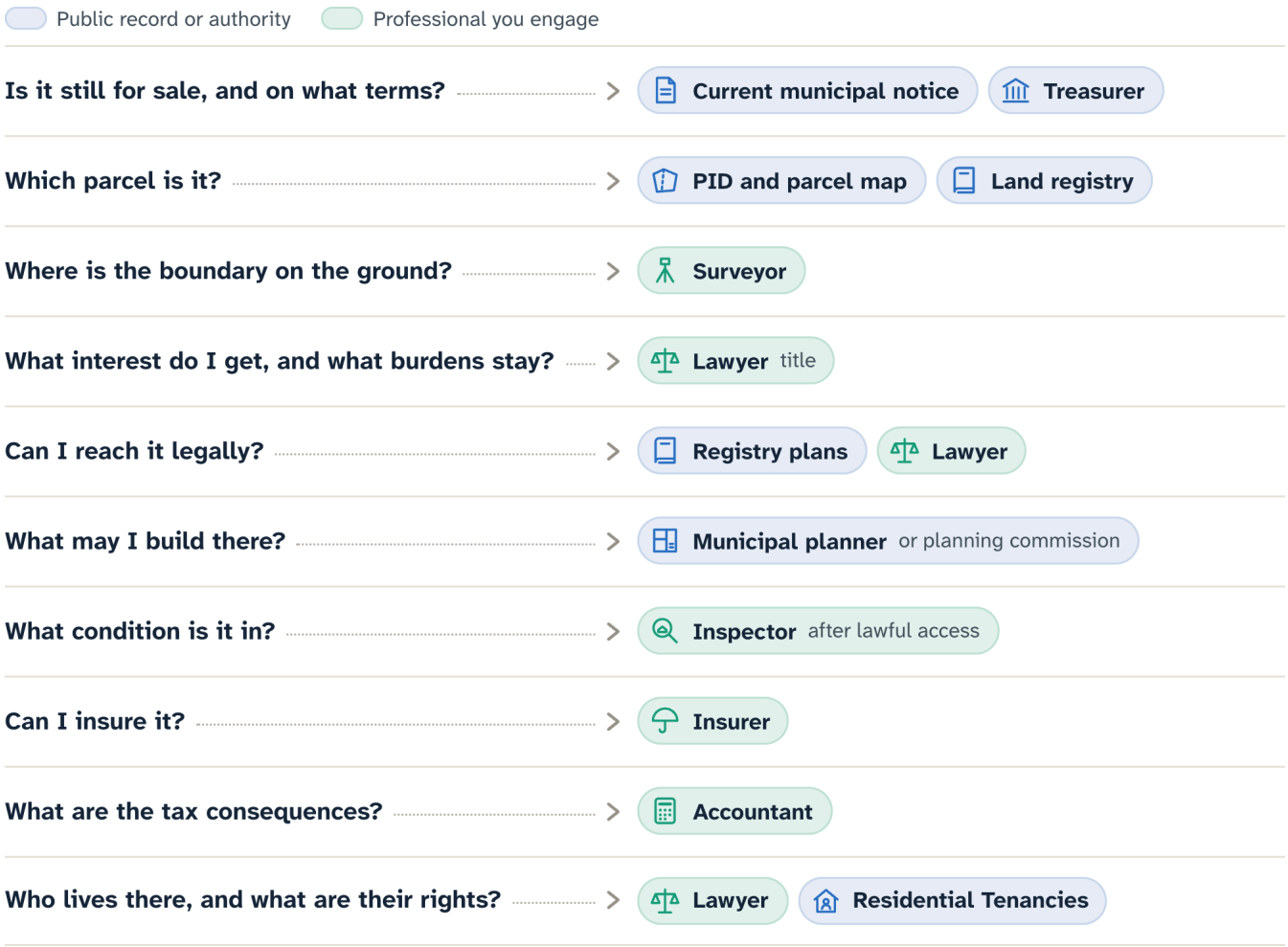
The legal question can now be specific. “Is this property okay?” becomes four questions. Which registered interests affect the parcel? How should the legal description and the referenced plan be read? What would the tax deed do to those interests? What will still be open on sale day?

Take Birch Point Road’s apparent road relationship. The lawyer gets more than a screenshot with “Looks accessible?” in the subject line: the file supplies the exact PID, the dated municipal record, the relevant instrument references, the legal description, the captured public view with its attribution, and the intended use. The question asks which registered rights provide legal access, and which interests or documents need review.

The surveyor gets a different question from the same file: what evidence would locate the relevant boundary or plan relationship, and can the work be done before the decision deadline? The tax-sale statute stays with the lawyer. The planner gets the proposed use, the current municipal source and the parcel identifiers, and names the planning, lot, frontage, servicing or permit questions that need confirmation. Title and physical condition stay with the lawyer and an inspector.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period



Municipal Government Act ss. 137–142 (notice and treasurer); CBRM tax-sale guidance on maps, access and occupancy; Nova Scotia Residential Tenancies resources. Checked July 2026.

Who answers what. Match each question to the authority or professional that can settle it.

Each professional fee now buys a particular reduction in uncertainty, tied to a question whose answer can change the decision. That allows triage: a bidder may pay first for the question most likely to end the project, before ordering lower-priority work.

When a court order is involved

Some legal routes sit outside an ordinary bidder's file. Nova Scotia's municipal statutes let a treasurer seek a court order on matters such as arrears, the interests conveyed, notice and the manner of

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

sale. A sale under such an order has the protected effect described by the order and the statute. That mechanism belongs to the municipality, the court and the legal process.

Careful: A bidder cannot assume a court order will repair an unclear current listing. If a notice or a legal professional points to a court-directed process, get the order itself, record what it says and take its effect to a lawyer. “Court ordered” and “risk free” are different statements.

A biography before a future

By the end of first review, Birch Point Road may sit in all four places.

Birch Point Road after first review. The exact PID-to-notice match is verified. A survey quote is priceable. The access question is professionally verifiable by the lawyer and the surveyor. An essential site-condition question has no lawful route to an answer before the sale, so it is labelled no-go for the proposed project.

The no-go entry governs, however attractive the aerial image. Evidence is not a vote in which three comfortable facts outnumber one unresolved essential fact. How much an unknown matters depends on the project it can defeat.

That is the point of giving the parcel a biography before giving it a future. The file remembers where each statement came from, who can strengthen it, what it would cost to resolve and where the evidence has to stop. Emotional attachment arrives later, if it arrives at all.

Chapter 5 sets the biography in motion on the map: from a dated notice to an exact parcel, then one context question at a time, with every unknown and handoff kept in the file.

Where this comes from

- Municipality of the County of Inverness, tax sale property packet for 11 August 2026 (published 16 July 2026, retrieved 19 July 2026).
- Nova Scotia Property Online page and user guide; Land Registration Administration Regulations.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: ss. 137–140 (title search and notice), s. 139A (court-directed sale), ss. 155–156 (tax deed); Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 151–155 and 170–171.
- Province of Nova Scotia Restricted Geographic Services License, version 1.0.
- Property Valuation Services Corporation, Find an Assessment; Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and FAQ; both checked July 2026.
- NS Marks The Spot, build d3114b5c, checked July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **NS** Nova Scotia · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period

Chapter 5

5 The Map Is a Question Machine

How to research a tax-sale parcel on a public map: choose the right kind of record, pin down the parcel, then turn on one layer at a time and note the question each layer raises and who answers it.

NS Marks The Spot can show a tax-sale record, a parcel outline, a civic address, a road, a river and a geology symbol on one screen. That is its power and its main risk. The eye joins nearby marks faster than the mind checks their sources. Records made by different authorities, for different purposes, at different times start to feel like one property story.

The map works best when it slows that joining down and turns each mark into a question with a source, a date and someone who can answer it.

Start with the record family

Choose the kind of record before you look at any parcel. The map keeps two catalogues, and they hold different kinds of evidence.

The current catalogue shows what a municipality presently says it intends to sell. In the production build checked on July 22, 2026, it listed Inverness County's August 11 event: 40 advertised records, 5 marked withdrawn and 40 active Parcel Identification Numbers (PIDs). That count is a snapshot dated that day.

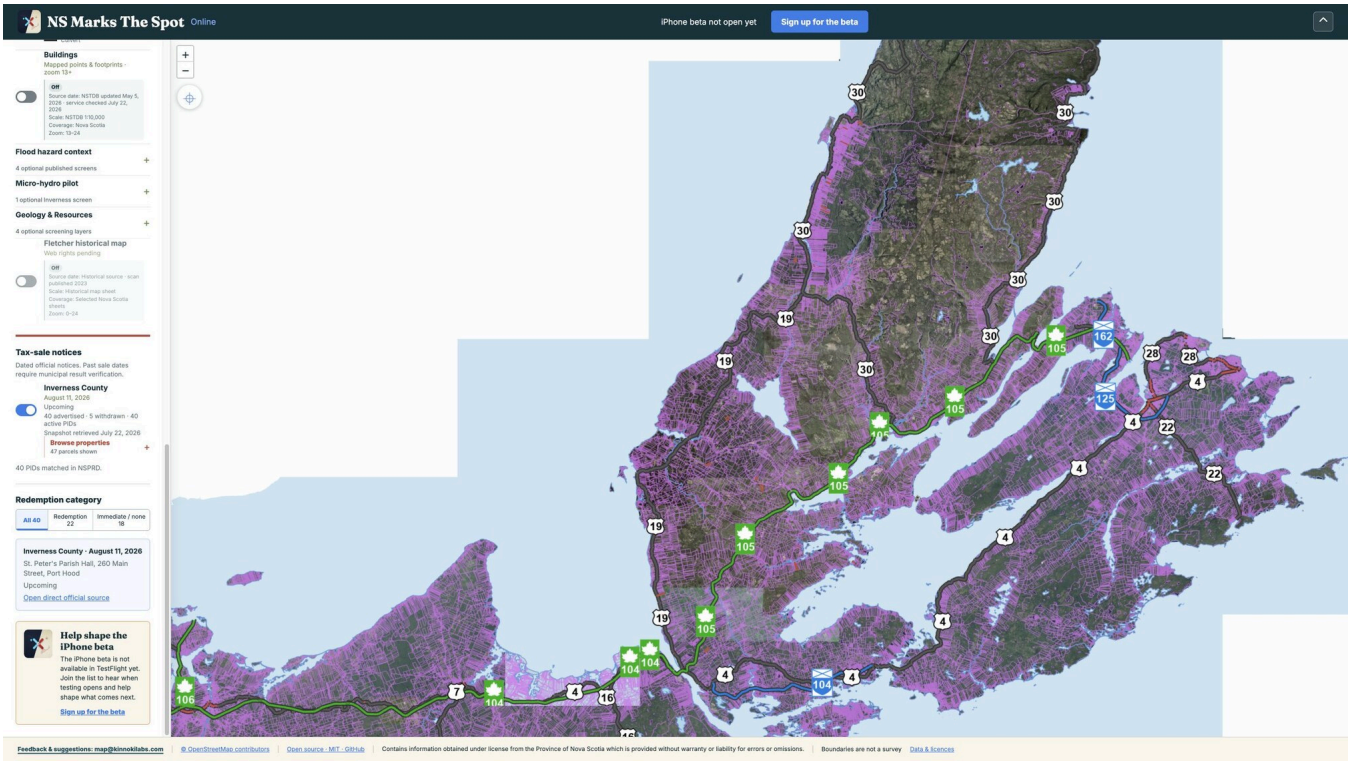
The historical catalogue is off by default. It reports what checked sources established after earlier events, and it can hold a recent event whose outcome stays marked unknown while official results are pending.

In current mode, choose Inverness. The app shows the event date, the municipal source, the snapshot wording, the parcel list and

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NS** Nova Scotia · **PID** Parcel Identification Number

each entry's published redemption category. The most important control is the direct source link back to the municipality that owns the record.



NS Marks The Spot: browsing the current tax-sale parcels for a dated municipal notice.

The app is a research index. The municipality's current notice, or its staff, says whether the sale is on, a parcel is still listed, the event is postponed or a term has changed. PDFs, screenshots, browser tabs and the map's own catalogue go stale, so open the link every time.

Suppose Birch Point Road, from Chapter 4, appears in the Inverness list. Confirm in the notice that the event, the exact lien, the PID and the status still match your file. If the notice and the app disagree, record the disagreement. The notice controls.

This book follows the same rule. Its production record names the map build, capture date and interface checks behind each figure. The site, the municipal pages and the provincial services can change or go offline later, and that record makes the change detectable.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NS** Nova Scotia · **PDF** Portable Document Format · **PID** Parcel Identification Number

Pin down the parcel

If the notice gives an exact PID, search it. The map selects the parcel the provincial service returns and opens its evidence sheet: the PID, an approximate mapped area, the matching current notice, mapped civic addresses and context from other services.

The approximate area is calculated from the current parcel geometry and is good for orientation and comparison. Surveyed area comes from a surveyor and deeded acreage from the legal description; the interests involved come from the notice and a lawyer's title review. Keep the word "mapped" with the number.

The sheet may also count mapped buildings and show a dated assessment from the Property Valuation Services Corporation (PVSC). For PID 50292390, a demonstration parcel, the building query returned two Nova Scotia Topographic Database features, points or polygons, intersecting the mapped parcel. That count describes the map; a site visit, an inspection and municipal records describe the structures, with their occupancy, condition, use and permits. A zero would mean only that the query found no mapped feature, which is different from an empty parcel.

The same parcel matched PVSC Assessment Account Number (AAN) 00616672, with 2026 assessed and taxable values of $35,000. The sheet gives the valuation and physical-state dates and links the source. That is a dated taxation record; sale price, appraisal, repair cost and bid ceiling need their own evidence. The parcel appears in none of the map's current notices and is here only to show two fields with different limits.

A search can also start from a civic address. The map queries the provincial civic-address service, takes the authoritative **civic point** it returns (the mapped location of that address) and opens the parcel polygon that contains it. Nearest-parcel guesses and

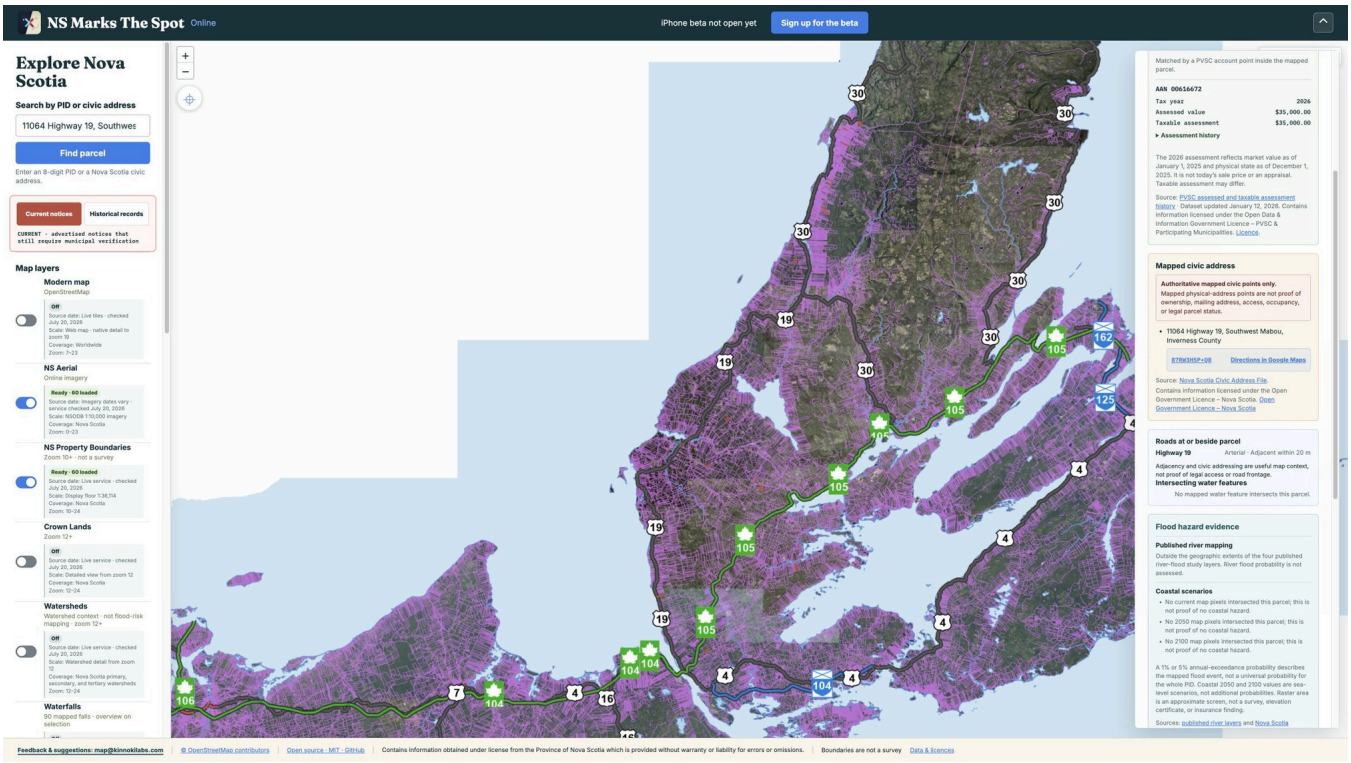
Words on this page

PVSC Property Valuation Services Corporation: the body that assesses property in Nova Scotia for municipal taxation.

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number

estimated addresses play no part. Containment tells you which parcel to investigate. Ownership, occupancy, mailing addresses, buildings, public entry and legal access stay separate questions, however obvious a nearby roof or road symbol makes them look.

The sheet also gives a **Plus Code** for each civic point: a short code for sharing or recovering a location without a street address. It is handy in rural areas where addresses are awkward or absent. When you send one to a surveyor or inspector, say what the point represents and how you got it.



A parcel's evidence panel after a civic-address search: the assessment account, the mapped civic point and its Plus Code, and road and flood context.

If you come back to the file hours later, recover four answers before turning imagery and context back on:

- Current or historical mode?
- Which municipality and dated event?
- Did the direct source still confirm the entry?
- Exact PID, or authoritative civic-point containment?

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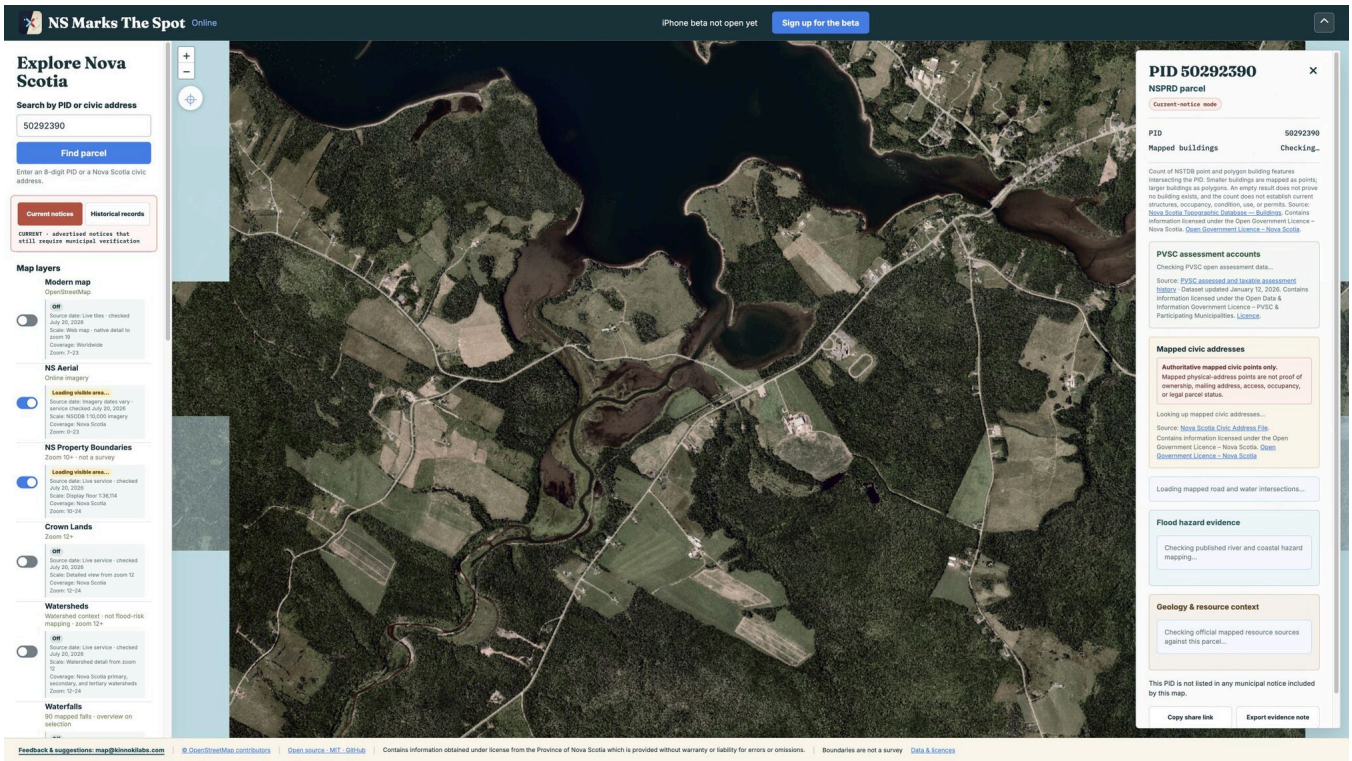
Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number

Identity comes from the records; the pictures come second.

The line and the picture

The parcel boundary and the aerial image together make a parcel feel physically known. Both are dated services. The line is graphical boundary information, and a surveyor locates the boundary on the ground.

Read them source by source. The current Nova Scotia Property Records Database (NSPRD) service returned this polygon for this PID. The aerial service showed these features on its imagery date. The Province's attribution and licence link stay on the view. Together they raise questions about how the parcel appears to sit among roads, buildings and water. Current condition calls for a look from public land and later a lawful inspection, and entry needs permission from someone entitled to give it.



Aerial imagery with provincial property boundaries: useful for orientation, then checked against the legal description and, when it matters, a survey.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

With the parcel pinned down and its unknowns in view, the context questions can start.

One layer, one question

A **layer** shows one category of mapped information. Roads, water, bedrock geology, mineral occurrences, mineral tenure and abandoned mine openings each come from a different service, with its own date, coverage, geometry and purpose. Several layers at once blur which source made which mark, so ask one question at a time and name the source first. Does the current road service report a line crossing the parcel? Does the mine-opening service return a point inside or near it?

Words on this page

Earlier words: **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database · **FAQ** frequently asked questions

MAP LAYER	WHAT IT SHOWS	CONFIRM WITH
Parcel outline	The mapped shape for this PID	**Legal description** · **Surveyor**
Aerial photo	What was visible on the image date	**Look from public land** · **Inspector** after lawful access
Roads	Where public roads run near the parcel	**Registry plans** · **Lawyer** legal access
Water	Where a mapped watercourse or the coast meets the parcel	**Municipal planner** setbacks · **Surveyor**
Flood and coast	River-flood studies where mapped; coastal: today, 2050, 2100	**Municipal planner** · **Insurer**
Geology and mines	Recorded mineral occurrences and mine openings **private-land points: up to ~50 m off**	**Provincial mine records** · **Professional review**
Buildings and assessment	Mapped building features and a dated PVSC assessment	**Municipal records** · **Inspector**
Historical results	What happened at a past sale	**Current municipal notice**

Public record or authority · Professional you engage · Your own check

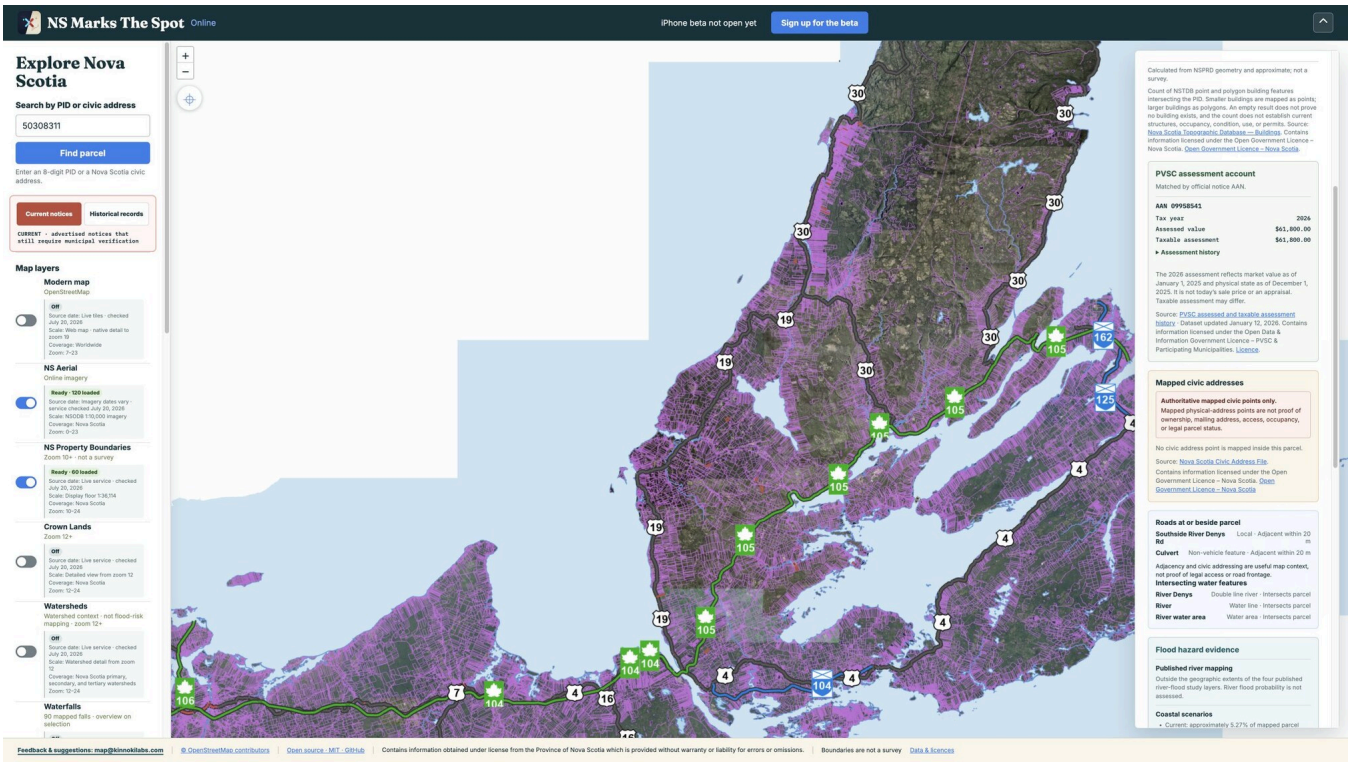
Layers as used in chapter 5 (NS Marks The Spot build d3114b5c, July 20, 2026), including NS Topographic Database buildings, PVSC assessment and the provincial Coastal Hazard Map. Mine-opening accuracy: Abandoned Mine Openings Database, Version 9 (2024).

One layer, one question. Each map layer is a prompt for a specific record or professional.

The July 20, 2026 production capture for PID 50308311 shows the rhythm. It is a real current-notice PID, used only to test the interface, with no recommendation or evaluation attached. The location is Southside River Denys Road, Valley Mills, with about 5.12 mapped acres. Transportation is visible nearby, and the road query reports no mapped road or trail intersection. The water query returns River Denys features intersecting the parcel.

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number



Roads and water layers turn on one at a time. Each one raises a question for the registry, the planner or a surveyor.

The water result is a **mapped intersection**: according to the query, the service's geometry for a named feature crosses or overlaps the parcel polygon. That is stronger than a line that looks close, and narrower than a finding that the real river crosses the legal parcel exactly as drawn. Wetlands, flood risk, the surveyed watercourse boundary, setbacks and ground condition are the next questions, for the flood screen, a surveyor, the planner and environmental sources.

Careful: "No mapped intersection" with a road does not mean no access, and a road nearby does not mean legal access. A right-of-way can exist outside the road dataset, and a visible route can be private, unmapped, misaligned or legally irrelevant. Legal access, a recognized right to the passage you need, comes from the deed, the plans, a survey, the municipal road records and a lawyer. Chapter 6 tests it under pressure.

Words on this page

Also on this page: right-of-way a legal right to cross someone else's land

A six-part note keeps the result in proportion. Leave out the limitation and the result sounds too strong. Leave out the observation and the note becomes a generic disclaimer. Leave out the unknown and the handoff, and you have caution without progress.

River Denys: six-part map note.

- Source: current provincial road and water services, checked production build.
- Date: July 20, 2026 capture.
- Observation: River Denys water intersections; no mapped road or trail intersection; transportation visible nearby.
- Limitation: source and parcel geometry are both screening data.
- Unknown: legal access, ground conditions, water constraints, service completeness.
- Next authority: land records and a lawyer for access; a survey and current municipal or environmental sources for physical and regulatory questions.

Flood studies and coastal scenarios

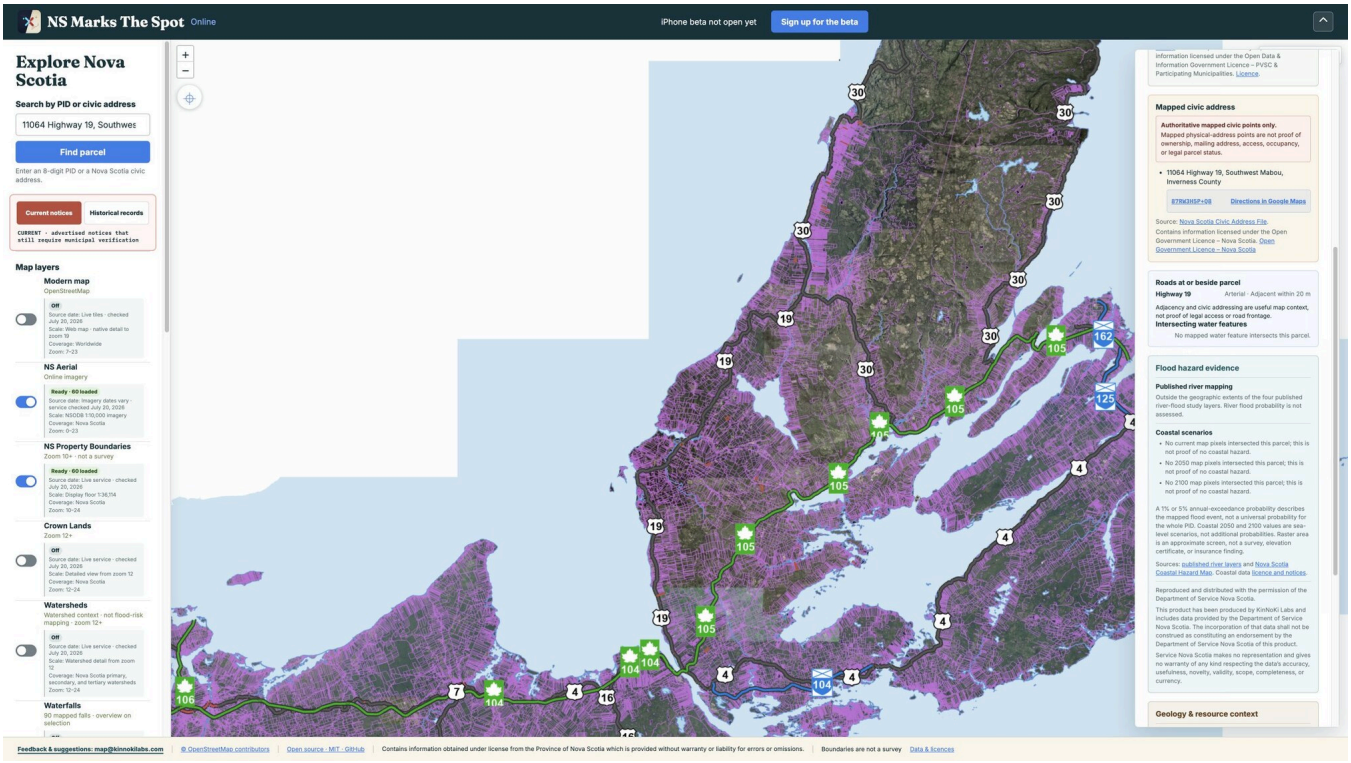
Flood evidence starts with coverage. The evidence sheet keeps published river-flood studies apart from the current, 2050 and 2100 coastal scenarios. A one-percent or five-percent annual-exceedance probability describes the event a particular study mapped, not a flood probability for every point in the PID. The coastal years are sea-level scenarios, separate from those probabilities.

For PID 50292390, the checked screen placed the parcel outside the geographic extents of all four published river-study layers and found no intersecting pixels in the three coastal scenarios. Neither result proves there is no flood hazard: outside study coverage means the river question was not assessed, and an empty raster intersection is an approximate screen. A survey, an elevation certificate, a site-specific analysis and an insurer answer the flood

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

question for a parcel; a planner says what the mapping means for building there.



Flood-study coverage shown where a study exists, with its source and date.

Geology and resources

The same rhythm applies to bedrock geology, mineral occurrences, mineral tenure and abandoned mine openings, layers that can reveal a history an aerial photo keeps hidden. Set aside “Is this mineral land?” and ask about the service. Does it return an occurrence or opening within the parcel or a defined screening distance? What does the dataset represent, as of what date and with what coverage? Which provincial record explains the feature?

An occurrence marks where something was recorded. Reserves, mineral rights, economic potential, contamination and danger are separate questions. The mine-opening inventory calls itself incomplete: it leaves out surface signs of subsidence, and its 2024 metadata says private-land positions can be off by up to

Words on this page

Earlier words: **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database · **FAQ** frequently asked questions

approximately 50 metres. Underground workings and site condition need other records. Tenure geometry shows where tenure is mapped; what can happen on the surface depends on the governing records and the law.

An empty view means the current query returned no displayed feature under the current settings and service response. It does not prove that nothing is there, that the site is clean or that the service is complete. That is why the map shows loading, empty and error as separate states.

The handoff follows the result. A geology record goes to a geoscience source or qualified professional, and a tenure question to the authoritative registry and legal interpretation. A mine opening or site-condition question needs current records, a lawful inspection and an environmental or engineering professional. The map gives the question an address.

A small find, and a larger property question

Around 2015, I used a provincial mineral-occurrence record to choose a brook for recreational gold panning. The record made no promise of gold; it gave me a reason to look. I bought a pan, tried the brook and found a little colour. It was a long way from paying the bills, but it showed what a public geological record can do. The brook stays unnamed, because its location is beside the point.

On a property file, the same observation goes in the questions column, as neither a bonus nor a reason to reject the parcel. Gold nearby may interest a recreational panner and still raise questions about mineral tenure, surface access and future land use. Who may explore? Could mining pay? What could happen on a particular surface parcel?

Nova Scotia law makes the point concrete. The Crown owns the minerals. A mineral-right holder or prospector who cannot obtain the owner's or occupier's consent may apply to the Minister for surface-access rights. A mineral lessee who cannot acquire land, or

Words on this page

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an interest, needed for a mine or for a purpose connected with or incidental to one may apply for a vesting order. Once the order is filed, the vested land or interest is deemed expropriated.

The power has been used. In 2012 the Province granted DDV Gold vesting orders for fourteen parcels needed for the proposed Touquoy mine, after acquisition agreements could not be reached. The Supreme Court of Canada later refused leave in Forrest Higgins's challenge involving part of his family's tree farm. Touquoy did go on to produce gold. The wider lesson: the Act can reach land needed for purposes connected with a mine, beyond the spot where the ore comes out.

So ask which occurrence was returned, what tenure exists, which surface rights may be involved and what the current law permits, and file the answers under unknowns and handoff. The map still does what the pan did years ago: it shows where a worthwhile question begins.

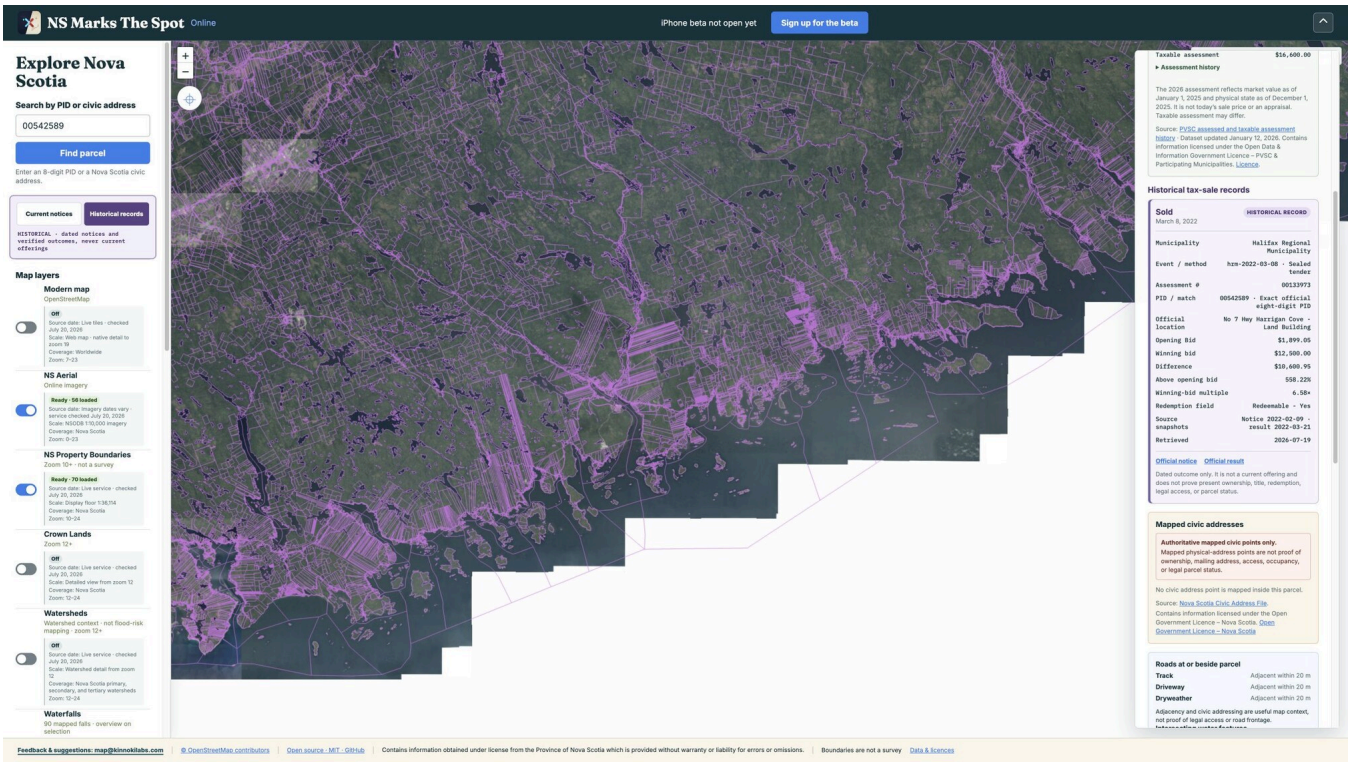
Historical mode

Historical mode asks for a different restraint. Its dated catalogue filters by municipality, year and recorded outcome, labels each record historical, and links to the official notice and, where one exists, the official result.

A captured Halifax example, PID 00542589 from the March 8, 2022 event, shows the recorded opening and winning amounts with derived difference and ratio fields. They answer one bounded question: what did the checked official records report for that PID at that event?

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number



A historical result sheet: what an earlier event recorded for a parcel, kept separate from the current notice.

Careful: A historical result is not a present value, a comparable sale, a forecast of competition at another auction or a bidding ratio. Each outcome happened under its own legal, physical, market, information and participation conditions. The official sources stay attached so the record can be audited.

A newer Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM) record shows the opposite case. PID 15234636 appears in the July 21, 2026 event with its minimum bid and notice fields, and its winning-bid field reads “Awaiting official results.” The event page says results will be posted after payment is confirmed. So the record is a notice waiting for its result: the outcome, the purchaser and the parcel’s present ownership and status stay unknown until the municipality publishes. Moving into historical mode after the event date changes the label, and the result still comes from the municipality.

Words on this page

CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number

Results still teach that advertised properties may be removed, that opening and winning amounts can differ and that outcomes vary. That is a lesson about process and evidence.

When you return to a session that showed both a current parcel and a historical result, name the record family before you repeat any amount: “a historical Halifax result from March 8, 2022,” or “a current Inverness notice snapshot for August 11, 2026.”

Try it

A parcel sheet shows an opening amount and a winning amount. What do you confirm before those numbers go into your file?

Answer: Whether the record is current or historical, and its municipality and event date. A historical amount describes that event; the current notice and your own evidence describe the parcel today.

The method in five words

Each step above is one of the book’s five words at work: notice, parcel, context, unknowns, handoff.

Birch Point Road’s file now ends in questions, each with an owner, and no score.

Birch Point Road: map entry. Current-mode Inverness entry confirmed with the municipality on the recorded date. Exact PID selected; mapped geometry and approximate mapped area returned. One contained civic point, with a Plus Code. Boundary, aerial, road, water and resource context from named public services on the stated date: attributed screening observations. Questions raised: access (road), source and ground condition (water), records (resources). Open: survey, title, access, occupancy, entry, environment, resource value, condition, development. Next: land records, legal review and survey for registered access; current authoritative sources and qualified professionals for water, geology and site condition, before deciding whether the project can proceed.

A note that said “found it” would have hidden which thing was found. The event record, the parcel geometry, the civic point and the visible site are four separate findings. The screen has

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

become more useful as the list of explicit unknowns has grown. That is success: a research tool earns trust by showing where knowledge ends.

The map has shortened the route from public notice to precise questions. It has left each authority and professional in charge of its own answers, and made one parcel easier to investigate and harder to romanticize. That is the job of a question machine.

Where this comes from

- NS Marks The Spot production map, source commit d3114b5c: deployment receipt retrieved 20 July 2026; captures of 20 July 2026; Inverness catalogue snapshot of 22 July 2026.
- Province of Nova Scotia Restricted Geographic Services License, version 1.0, for the NS Aerial and NSPRD services shown. Required attribution: “Contains information obtained under license from the Province of Nova Scotia which is provided without warranty or liability for errors or omissions.”
- GeoNOVA parcel mapping; Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026, s. 139 (survey before sale).
- Provincial civic-address service; Nova Scotia Topographic Database buildings; PVSC assessment history.
- Published river-flood study layers; Nova Scotia Coastal Hazard Map and user guide, refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Abandoned Mine Openings Database, DP ME 10, Version 9 metadata (2024).
- Mineral Resources Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 5, ss. 25–26 and s. 27.
- Touquoy: Government of Nova Scotia release, 15 June 2012; Supreme Court of Canada Bulletin of Proceedings, 28 February 2014, file 35540; Information Circular ME 84 (2024).
- Inverness County notice for 11 August 2026; CBRM event of 21 July 2026; Halifax notice and result for 8 March 2022.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NS** Nova Scotia · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality

Chapter 6

6 Access and Use

How to tell a route you can see from a right to use it, and how to test whether a parcel can carry the use you have in mind.

Maple Ridge is a fictional composite, and from a kitchen table it looks easy.

The Maple Ridge file. A long, narrow sliver just behind two roadside lots. On the aerial image, a pale track leaves the public road, crosses one of those lots and seems to continue into the sliver: a beginning, a middle and an apparent destination. The auction recovery amount is modest. The bidder's goal is a small year-round house.

That image can carry a researcher farther than the evidence goes.

Chapter 5 kept an empty road search from turning into "landlocked", and a nearby line from turning into "accessible". Maple Ridge is a harder test. Tire marks appear to join the road, and the parcel polygon seems to meet the track at its far end. You could point at the screen and give directions.

The question that matters is a legal one: does whoever acquires an interest in the sliver have a legally supportable right to use that route for the intended purpose?

The route you can see

At the road edge, the track is a physical opening. A neighbour, a former owner or a forestry crew may have used it, or no one for years. The mapped parcel line may sit slightly off the feature on the ground, and the route may cross someone else's land. A gate, washout, seasonal condition or disagreement may be newer than the image or too small for it to show.

Words on this page

Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

A tax-sale listing gives no right of entry, so before the sale you research from the public road or from land where you have permission. The Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM), this book's operational comparison, says it does not provide access to listed properties. Other events set their own current terms.

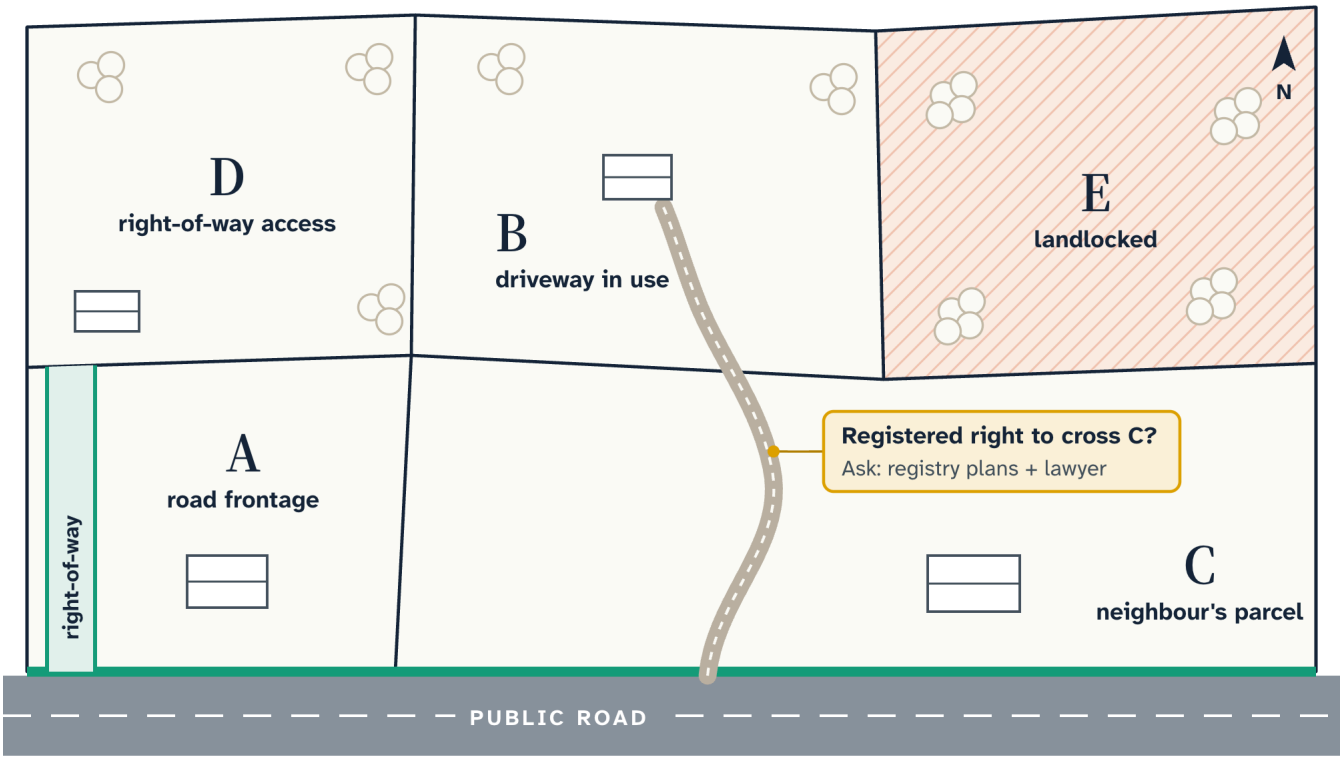
The title and plan research asks whether the sliver benefits from a registered interest or other legally supportable route over the land in between: where that route lies, what it permits, and what conditions or obligations come with it. A lawyer reads the records for their legal effect. A surveyor relates the described boundaries and routes to the ground. The municipality or road authority answers its own road-status and development questions.

A **right-of-way** is a right of passage over land, and its terms decide what it does. Its source matters, and so do the land it benefits and the land it burdens. Its description, route, permitted users, purposes, width, maintenance terms and conditions may matter too. A route good enough for occasional foot traffic may fall short for vehicles, construction traffic, utilities, emergency response or year-round residential use.

Think of the visible track as a door. Evidence of a sufficient right-of-way or public-road relationship is the key that may authorize passage. A door can be obvious while the key is missing, and even a real right-of-way opens only what its terms describe.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land



Schematic plan of fictional parcels. Legal access is read from title, registered plans and municipal requirements (CBRM land-locked parcel guidance). Rights-of-way continue after a tax deed (MGA ss. 155–156).

Physical access and legal access can differ. One parcel fronts the road; another is reached by a registered right-of-way; a driveway in use may cross a neighbour's land with no registered right; a parcel behind the others may have no way in at all.

The sale notice holds no key. It identifies the sale entry and points you to the exact parcel, and the public map orients you. A tax deed may later change the purchaser's registered interest, according to the governing process. It does not create a missing route across a neighbour's land.

Suppose the authorized record search finds an old plan showing the pale track. That helps, and it raises new questions. Was the line

Words on this page

Also on this page: **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period

surveyed as a boundary, drawn as an existing road, proposed as a route, or tied to a registered interest? Does the current parcel benefit? Can the description be located? Has later work moved the route? The plan, related instruments, current survey evidence and legal interpretation have to be reconciled together, however convincing one picture looks.

Now change one fact: the owner of the front lot maintains the track, has it snowplowed and uses it every day.

Careful: Steady use of the track does not establish that Maple Ridge has the right it needs. That right, if it exists, is a legal question, answered by a lawyer from the title instruments, the plans and the law. The people using the route may have permission, rights tied to different land, or a dispute the aerial image can't show. Long use can raise legal questions, and a lawyer answers them; local habit offers only a guess.

The access note can stay short:

Access note. Current parcel and aerial services show a driveway-like route from the public road toward the selected graphical parcel, apparently crossing an intervening parcel. Still to establish: the legal boundary, road status, right to pass, physical condition and permission to enter. Next evidence: title instruments and plans interpreted for the exact parcel, survey advice where location is material, and confirmation from the responsible road and planning authorities for the intended use.

The note is actionable without calling the route good or bad, and it sets a stop condition. If the project depends on vehicle, construction, utility or emergency access, the required right has to be supported before the bid decision. Otherwise the gap is a no-go uncertainty, however low the recovery amount.

Three findings now stand apart. Getting near the land is a physical observation. A right to reach it is a legal conclusion that needs support. A route that can serve the project is a further physical and regulatory question.

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Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

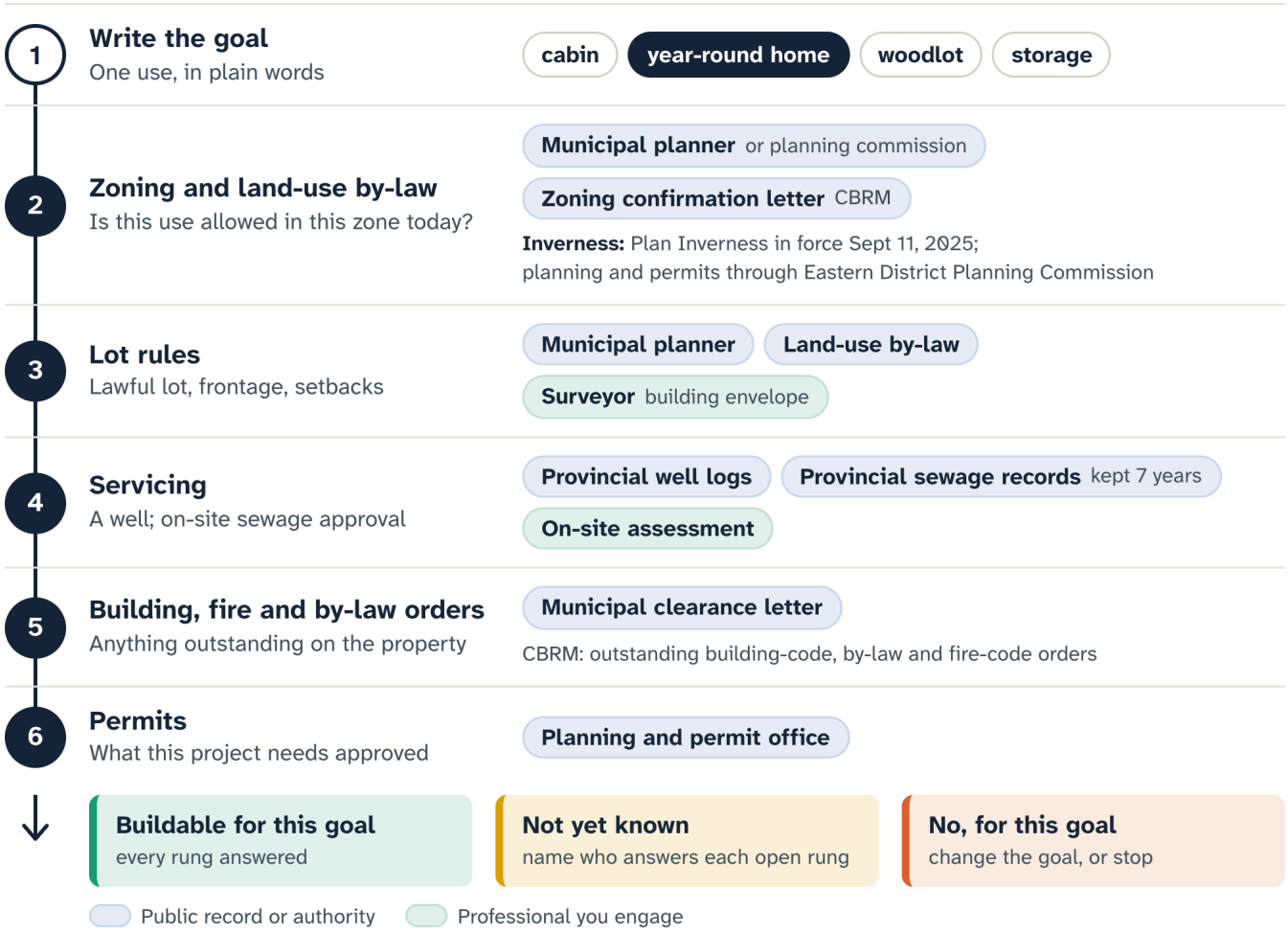
The use the land must support

Now assume a lawyer finds a registered passage right that appears to benefit Maple Ridge, and a surveyor can relate its description to the ground. One threshold is crossed. Several remain.

The planning conversation starts from the intended use: a planner can test a named project, and a vague hope gives them nothing to test. The useful question names the exact Parcel Identification Number (PID), the proposed use, the access evidence so far and the confirmation needed before a bid.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number



Inverness planning by-law notice and Eastern District Planning Commission, checked July 2026. CBRM zoning confirmation and municipal clearance letters, July 20, 2026. Nova Scotia well logs and Environmental Records Management System, July 2026.

Can the land do the job? Write the intended use first, then test it against each layer of municipal and provincial rules.

Zoning is the system that assigns land-use categories and rules to places. A zone can list uses that are permitted, prohibited or subject to conditions, and point to standards that shape a project. The coloured zone or short code on a map opens the planning inquiry.

In Inverness County, the municipality-wide Plan Inverness Municipal Planning Strategy and Land Use By-law took effect on September 11, 2025, so the older assumption that rural land there is unzoned is out of date. The Eastern District Planning Commission

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

administers planning and permitting services. Check the current rules and get parcel-specific guidance at the time of your decision.

A residential label is tempting to read as permission to build a house. It folds several questions into one word:

- Is the parcel a lawful lot for the proposed development?
- Does it meet frontage and access requirements?
- Which setbacks apply?
- Will the building and its supporting works fit?
- Which water, sewage, driveway, fire, building or other approvals are needed?
- Do site-specific constraints or other laws govern the same land?
- Which facts can the authority confirm now, and which need an application, a design or a professional submission?

CBRM sells two records checks that touch this list: a Zoning Confirmation Letter, which identifies current zoning and the applicable land-use by-law provisions, and a Municipal Clearance Letter, which reports outstanding building-code orders, by-law orders and fire-code violations. Inspection and project approval are separate steps.

Road frontage is the parcel's relationship to a road, as the applicable rules define and require it. Suppose Maple Ridge's polygon also appears to touch the public road at one corner. That sliver of on-screen contact is a lead for both questions: proving legal access there would take the description, survey and road evidence, and the frontage determination comes from the rules. A right to pass over a neighbour's land may solve one legal access problem and leave a separate frontage or development-standard problem.

Maple Ridge shows the difference. The registered passage may let vehicles reach the land while the rules still require the lot itself, or a proposed alteration to it, to meet a particular road relationship. The public road's status may matter too, and so may the route's width and physical capacity for emergency access or construction.

The planning authority answers that rule question for the proposed project.

The bidder's call can therefore be specific:

> I am researching this PID for a small year-round dwelling. The parcel appears to lie behind roadside lots, and its access is still under legal and survey review. Which current zone and lot-status rules apply? What frontage, access, setback, service and permit questions must this use resolve? Which can your office confirm before purchase, and which require a later application or professional plan?

The call asks for confirmations the office can give, and it discloses the access gap.

Suppose the planner confirms that a dwelling is a permitted use in the zone. That supported fact removes one possible prohibition.

> **Careful:** A permitted use and an approved project belong to different stages. Whether this parcel is a buildable lot, whether a compliant building envelope exists, whether the route can serve a dwelling and whether water and sewage approvals will be available are all still open.

Setbacks raise a similar problem. A narrow parcel may have enough mapped area in total and too little usable shape once road, side-yard, water, access or other requirements apply. A survey and the rules settle the boundary and the building envelope, and a sketch on uncertain lines stays preliminary.

With no municipal sewer or water at the site, a rural project may depend on a well, an on-site sewage system and the land to support them. Feasibility may turn on lawful site investigation, design, records, approvals and qualified advice. Parcel area and an empty-looking field say little about it. Chapter 7 covers the records that can help before lawful inspection is possible.

Each favourable answer builds momentum. A recorded passage, a residential zone and a large mapped area stay three separate facts, each with its own source, date, limits and dependencies, and a

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

permit comes only from the permitting authority. The municipality, collecting taxes through a statutory process, gives no warranty about the property's condition, access, zoning, suitability or development potential. Its staff can route municipal questions and explain procedure.

When the file says stop

Maple Ridge's file now has two columns.

What the bidder can support: the exact parcel under research; a passage right still requiring final legal and survey confirmation; the current planning authority; a zone in which the proposed use may be contemplated.

What the project still requires: parcel-specific frontage and lot-status answers; a supportable building envelope; suitable physical access; service feasibility; the approvals a year-round dwelling needs.

The second column holds an essential dependency that stays open past the auction. Perhaps the access instrument is ambiguous, or the planning authority needs later technical work before it can confirm that the lot and route can support the stated use. Either can be enough to stop.

A stop is a conclusion about this bidder's evidence, deadline and intended use, and no prediction that the parcel is worthless. The parcel may suit someone whose land already supplies the connection, someone with a different purpose, or someone with information and rights this bidder lacks. Suitability belongs to a named use and a named evidence file.

This is what a rational no sounds like:

> I can see how someone might reach Maple Ridge, and I can identify a zone in which a dwelling may be permitted. The access, frontage, lot, service and approval chain my project requires is still unsupported, and the auction deadline leaves every link in place. So I am passing: a bid now would assume it all works out later.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

Try it

Who answers each question: whether the old plan's track is tied to a registered interest that benefits Maple Ridge, where the described route sits on the ground, and whether the lot meets the frontage rules for a house?

Answer: A lawyer, a surveyor and the planning authority, in that order.

The chapter began with a driveway and ended with a project. The map does its job when it helps you name each gate between them. The bidder's harder job is keeping one attractive line from answering five different questions.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: ss. 155–156 (the tax deed; easements and rights-of-way).
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and FAQ (land-locked parcels; no access to listed properties), checked 19 July 2026; Zoning Confirmation and Municipal Clearance pages, checked 20 July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Inverness, Plan Inverness Municipal Planning Strategy and Land Use By-law (in effect 11 September 2025), and the Eastern District Planning Commission service statement, checked 19 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Property Online; provincial municipal planning guide; checked 19 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **easement** a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Chapter 7

7 On, In and Under the Land

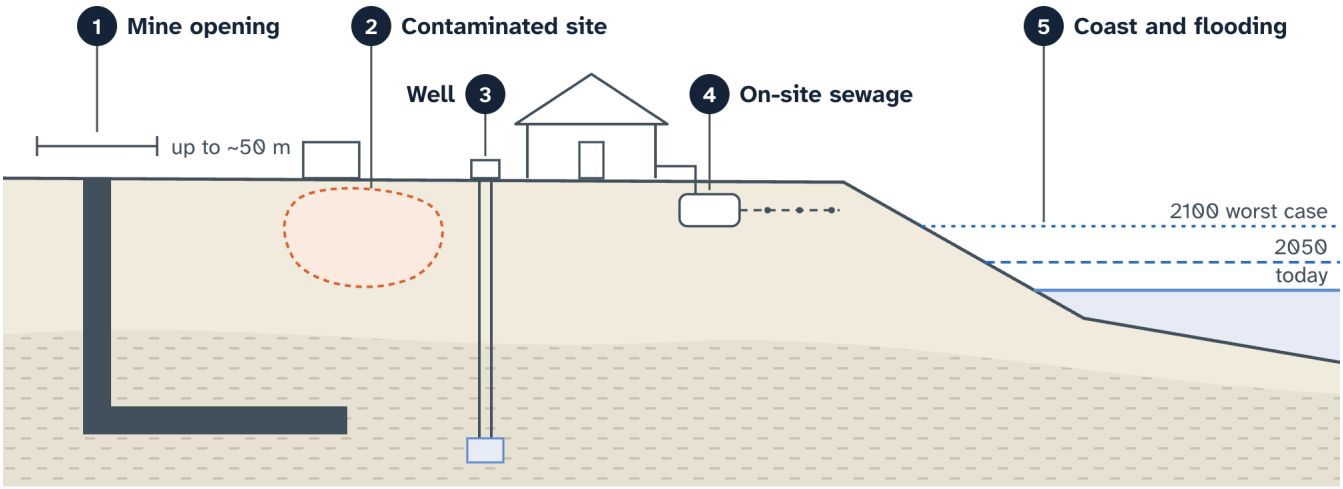
What public records can show about contamination, wells, sewage, coastal flooding and old mine openings, and how to record each result with the search that produced it and the question it leads to.

Breakwater Lane, another fictional composite, faces a sheltered Nova Scotia cove. A low wooden building sits back from the road. Faded lettering in an old photograph suggests it once housed a small engine-repair workshop. A newer roadside image shows fresh siding, and grass where a fuel tank may once have stood. The map supplies an exact parcel, a coastal setting and a few resource layers.

Sampling, testing and inspection on the ground answer the physical questions: heating oil in the soil, the water in a well, a buried pipe, whether an old system still works. Public records come first and sharpen those questions. This chapter works through them in turn: contaminated-site records, well logs, on-site sewage files, coastal hazard mapping and the abandoned-mine inventory. Each comes from its own record system, shows one kind of evidence and points to the next person to ask.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database



	RECORD AND KEEPER	WHAT IT SHOWS	READ IT WITH
1	**Abandoned mine openings** Abandoned Mine Openings Database, Nova Scotia Natural Resources (Version 9, 2024)	Known mine openings, mapped as points	Incomplete; private-land points can be up to ~50 m off
2	**Contaminated sites** Environmental Registry, Nova Scotia Environment and Climate Change	Contaminated-site notices and closure records	Covers this search's terms and date only
3	**Well logs** Well Logs Database, Province of Nova Scotia	Location, geology, construction, depth and yield	Some positions estimated; check the original log
4	**On-site sewage records** Environmental Records Management System, Province of Nova Scotia	Records of on-site sewage systems	Kept seven years, then destroyed
5	**Coastal flooding** Coastal Hazard Map, Province of Nova Scotia; search by address or PID	Flooding scenarios for today, 2050 and 2100	2100 worst case: highest high tide + 1-in-100-year surge + sea-level rise

Schematic cross-section of a fictional parcel. Each record as named, refreshed July 20, 2026; mine-opening positional accuracy from the Version 9 metadata (2024).

Records worth checking for what may be on, in or under the land, and who keeps each one.

Clues from the road

The workshop raises questions about fuel, solvents, waste handling, fill and old spills. A pipe or concrete pad visible from a public place may sharpen one of them. Note each image's date and source, and keep the observation literal: a feature is visible, or a

Words on this page

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historical record describes a use. Contamination is a finding that takes sampling.

A **contaminated site** is land or water affected by a contaminant in a way that raises environmental assessment, management or remediation questions. Its precise legal and technical meaning comes from the governing framework and qualified professionals. For a researcher before a sale, the term names a condition that records and history may flag and an on-site assessment diagnoses.

The contaminated-sites search

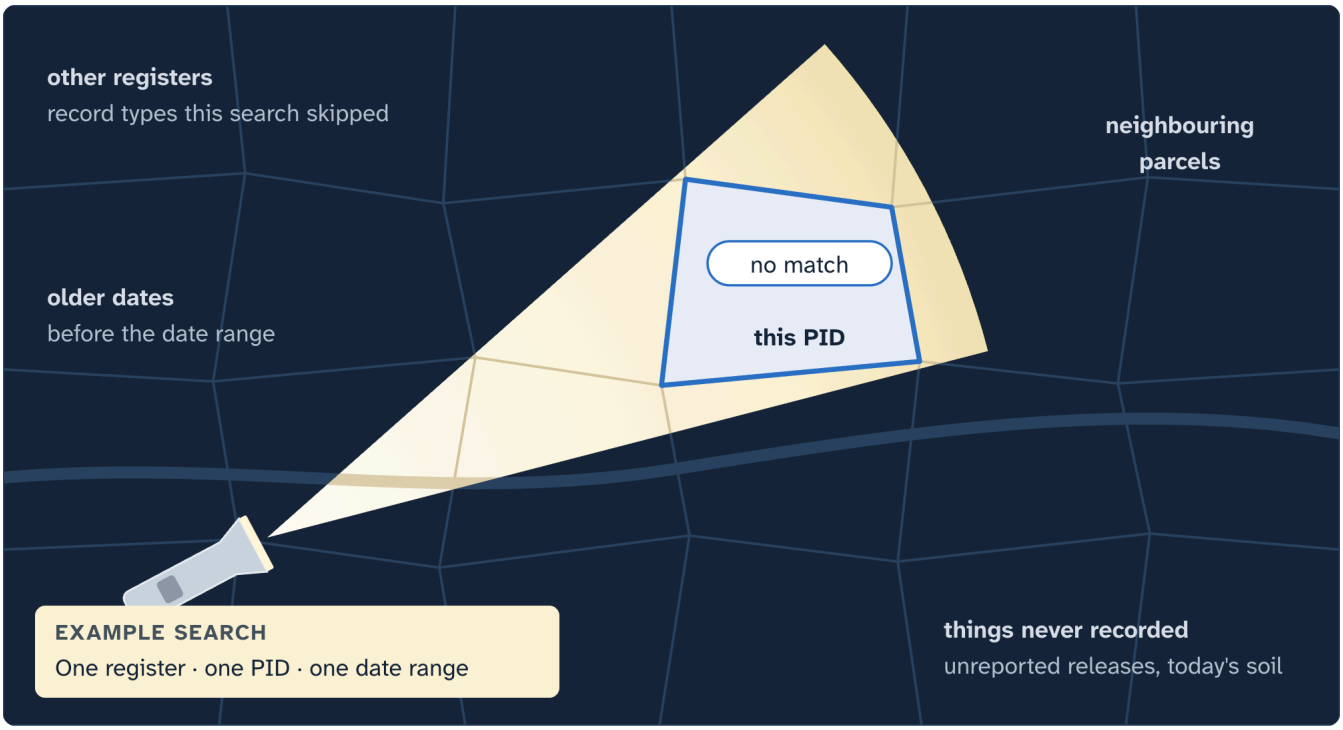
Nova Scotia's Environmental Registry can include contaminated-site notices and closure records, and the contaminated-sites program warns that spills and historic uses can contaminate soil, water and air. A returned approval, report, spill file or site record may identify an activity, date, location, responsible process or document worth reviewing. Match each one carefully to the parcel and the question: similar civic descriptions, estimated positions, changed parcel boundaries and activity next door can all matter.

An empty search has a smaller job. It shows that this search, of this source, with these terms and method, on this date, found no matching record, and that is all it covers. An unreported release, a use older than the records and today's soil all lie outside it. The registry holds documents made under its own rules and history; sampling describes the ground.

Picture a flashlight in a dark barn. Where the beam shines, it can show a post, a stair or clear floor; the rest of the barn stays dark. A database's beam is systematic, set by its scope, methods and evidence, and some sources light far more than others. Learn what this beam covers before saying anything about what it missed.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database



No match = no match in this search.

Nova Scotia Environmental Registry (Environment and Climate Change): contaminated-site notices and closure records, refreshed July 20, 2026. The search shown is an example.

A records search lights up one record type, one place and one date range. Everything outside the beam is still unknown.

Breakwater Lane: the first two entries

Former use and exterior context. A dated photograph appears to show an engine-repair use; public imagery shows a small building and a possible former tank area. Open: any spill or contaminant, where a tank sat, the site's condition today.

Registry search. No parcel-specific contaminated-site record located under the recorded search method and date. Next: widen the search to the address, parcel history, neighbouring sites and prior uses, then ask an environmental professional what lawful pre-purchase assessment is warranted.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

Wells

A **well log** is the recorded account of a well's construction and drilling. It may describe how deep the driller went, the materials met, the casing and a reported yield. The provincial well database gathers many decades of drilling history in one system. Its entries can include location, geology, construction, depth and yield, and together they can reveal patterns and individual records that would otherwise be hard to find. A qualified professional can use them to read regional conditions or to investigate whether a record may relate to the property.

The map point shows where the record places the well, from the location information available when it was made. Some positions are estimates, and the Province warns that the database may be incomplete or inaccurate. A point near the building, or even inside the parcel line, stays an estimate until someone finds the well on the ground; containment only compares two mapped objects. The log itself records a drilling event, and today's well is a question for testing and inspection.

Breakwater Lane returns one well point near the mapped parcel. The record's address resembles an older one linked to the workshop, but the location is estimated and the parcel has since been reconfigured. The log gives a depth and a reported yield. A weak file says, "The property has a well." A careful one says this:

Breakwater Lane: the well entry

One estimated well-log point near the selected parcel, returned under the recorded search, with drilling and construction details. Next: check the original log and confirm on the ground where the well is, whether it belongs to this parcel and who owns it. Testing and inspection then answer its equipment, condition, yield, water quality, legal compliance and ability to serve the property.

Words on this page

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Sewage

A provincial search returns no older on-site sewage record for Breakwater Lane. That can read as a warning that no approved system exists, or as reassurance that all is well. Nova Scotia's environmental records service warns that a record is unlikely for a property more than seven years old. Its process information says these files are kept for seven years and then destroyed. For an older property, an empty search is the expected result either way.

Behind an empty result may be an older system whose records were destroyed, or a system changed, abandoned, shared or missing from that source. The address or parcel may have changed, or a file held elsewhere may answer part of the question. The file keeps all of these open and picks none for convenience.

Breakwater Lane: the sewage entry

No older on-site sewage record returned through the checked provincial request; the source's retention limit explains that result for an older property. Open: whether a system exists, was approved, and is suitable and working now. Next: current municipal and provincial requirements, available property history and a qualified on-site assessment.

A future shore

The coast and the old mines take the file forward and back in time: to changing water levels and storms, and to mining that may be poorly documented or imprecisely located.

A **hazard map** is a screening map that shows a defined hazard or scenario using stated data and methods. Colour marks where that scenario reaches. Whether damage will occur at a particular coloured place, and whether an uncoloured place is safe from every related hazard, are questions for site work.

Nova Scotia's Coastal Hazard Map can be searched by community, address or Parcel Identification Number (PID), with current, 2050

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number

and 2100 scenarios. Its 2100 worst-case coastal flooding scenario combines the highest high tide, a one-in-one-hundred-year storm surge and projected sea-level rise. That makes it a powerful planning view: it shows that future combination across a large area.

The colour belongs to the selected scenario and the map's current data, model, resolution and guidance. A building's floor elevation comes from a survey; the state of a shoreline protection structure, or floodwater's route through a culvert, from engineering work. Insurers make insurance decisions, and the municipality grants development approval.

Suppose the 2100 scenario shades part of Breakwater Lane's mapped parcel. "The property will flood" overstates it. The file can say this:

Breakwater Lane: the coastal entry

The checked Coastal Hazard Map shows scenario coverage overlapping part of the current mapped parcel under the selected 2100 setting: a long-range screening observation. Next: the exact scenario definition, current topographic and site evidence, the intended building location, the access route, and advice from the appropriate planning and technical professionals.

If the colour stops just outside the parcel line, the nearness still justifies questions about the road, drainage, neighbouring ground, the emergency route and the uncertainty in the screening geometry. The file records it as near. The parcel line is graphical and the scenario is a screen, so "affected" and "safe" wait for site evidence.

An incomplete past

Nova Scotia's Abandoned Mine Openings inventory is a valuable record of known openings and related information. By its own description it is incomplete: undocumented openings exist, the inventory leaves out surface signs of subsidence, and site conditions may change. Its 2024 metadata adds that positions on private land can carry lower confidence and can be off by up to

Words on this page

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about 50 metres. On a rural map, that distance can cross a road, a parcel line, a building site or a shoreline. A coordinate therefore goes into the file with its positional quality attached. On its own, it sounds more exact than the record is.

If the mine layer returns a known opening just outside Breakwater Lane, the file holds an inventory entry with a stated approximate position and attributes. It raises questions about the documented working, the positional uncertainty, the surrounding geology and any surface evidence. A qualified site assessment answers where the opening lies, how far workings run and whether the property is safe.

An empty query needs more care. “No abandoned mine opening shown” means the checked source returned no displayed opening for the recorded query and map state. The inventory is incomplete and leaves out some signs of hazard, so “no mining hazard” is a bigger claim than that result can carry. It does narrow one specific concern: that search returned no known inventory point. Recorded with its limit, that is useful evidence.

Found, empty or failed

Every search ends in one of three states, and the file keeps them apart:

- Found: a feature or scenario returned under the recorded conditions. Keep the source, date, geometry, attributes, coverage limits, positional quality and next question.
- Empty: the query finished and returned nothing. Keep the source, date, settings, completeness limits and the one narrow concern it checked.
- Failed: a service error, loading timeout, hidden layer or wrong selection left no completed result. Record the failure, retry or go straight to the authoritative source, and draw no conclusion from it.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

Try it

You come back to Breakwater Lane's file after a week away. What you remember is blue coastal shading near an old workshop. What do you recover before using either result?

Answer: The smaller details. Which scenario was selected, and what did its guidance say the colour represents? Did the mine query return a feature, return none, or fail? What limitation travels with each result? Which property-specific question comes next?

What the file can carry

A quick read of the three record searches gives "no", "yes" and "no", a false symmetry. Classified, the whole file says much more:

Breakwater Lane: environmental summary

- Former workshop use: a positive clue that widens the environmental inquiry.
- Contaminated-site search: a bounded negative, limited by reporting and by the recorded search.
- Well log: a positive record whose parcel link, mapped position and present condition need confirming.
- Sewage search: a negative whose meaning rests on the source's retention limit.
- Coastal map: the selected 2100 scenario overlaps part of the mapped parcel.
- Mine inventory: the query result, recorded with the inventory's completeness and positional limits.

Each open item goes to the lawful inspection, sampling, surveying, engineering, planning, insurance or legal advice that answers it.

That is what environmental research before a sale can responsibly do: light part of the yard, and say which part. Whether to buy stays with the bidder.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

Careful: A tax-sale listing gives no right to enter the land. Before the sale, research stays on public land or where you have permission, and the file stays an exterior file. Whatever physical uncertainty remains goes into the bid decision as uncertainty. It may govern that decision when the intended use can't carry the remaining risk, when lawful investigation is unavailable before bidding, or when the professional answers would come after the deadline.

Each source earns its place inside its limit, and the mistake is asking any one beam to light the whole parcel. Breakwater Lane remains unseen in important ways, and careful research has made those parts specific enough to route, investigate, price where appropriate, or refuse. The map becomes safer the moment its silence stops being read as reassurance.

Where this comes from

- Nova Scotia Environment and Climate Change: Environmental Registry and Contaminated Sites pages, refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Well Logs Database, user manual and georeferencing notes, refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Environmental Records Management System page and Environmental Registry process information sheet (on-site sewage record retention), refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Coastal Hazard Map User Guide, refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Natural Resources, Abandoned Mine Openings Database description and DP ME 10, Version 9 metadata, 2024, refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and its frequently asked questions (entry to listed properties), refreshed 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **NSPRD** Nova Scotia Property Records Database

Chapter 8

8 Title, Burdens and the People on the Land

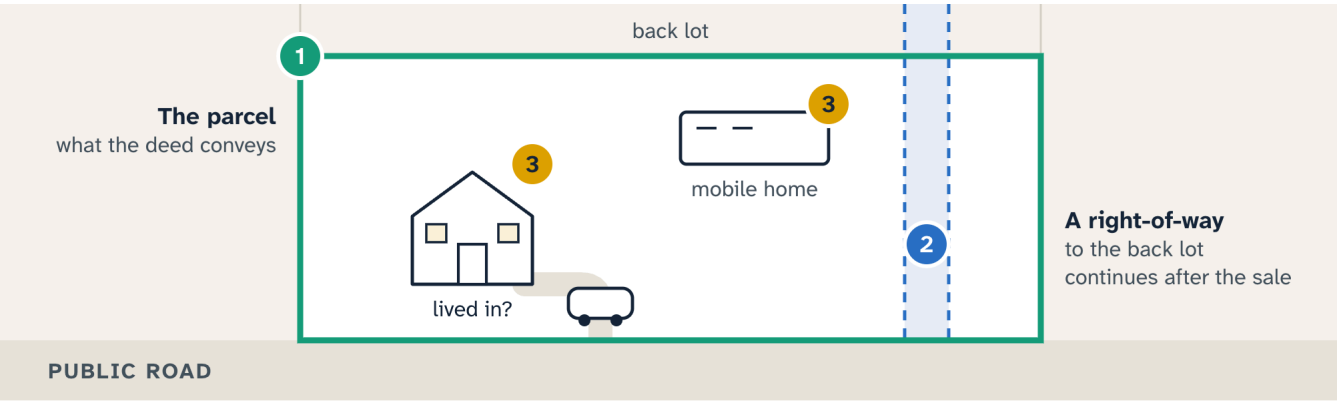
What a tax deed gives the purchaser, which rights and burdens stay with the land, and why the people living there are a separate question with its own lawful process.

Before Chapter 9 returns to setting a bid, this chapter jumps ahead to a finished case to show what a deed would change and what it would leave for later.

Meet Foundry Street, a fictional composite: a small apartment building at the last stage of its tax sale. The redemption question has been resolved, the municipal fee has been paid and a tax deed has been registered. A search of the correct Parcel Identification Number (PID) now has a new document at its centre. The deed changes the legal relationship to the land. Three questions still need separate answers: what interest the deed gives, which burdens and benefits continue, and who is in possession.

Words on this page

Also on this page: PID Parcel Identification Number · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period



	THE QUESTION	WHERE THE ANSWER IS WRITTEN	WHO CONFIRMS IT
1 TITLE	**What interest does the tax deed give?**	Fee simple, free of encumbrances, as the statute specifies Tax deed; MGA ss. 155–156	**Lawyer: title opinion**
2 BURDENS	**What stays attached to the land?**	Easements and rights-of-way continue; other statutory burdens vary MGA ss. 155–156; registry documents	**Lawyer** **Land registry**
3 POSSESSION	**Who lives on or uses the land?**	An occupied property can still be sold A mobile home: also search the Personal Property Registry Municipal tax-sale FAQ; mobile-home regulations	**Lawyer** **Tenancy advice**

Municipal Government Act ss. 155–156 (consolidated to April 9, 2026); CBRM tax-sale FAQ; Nova Scotia mobile-home tax-sale regulations and Personal Property Registry guidance, checked July 2026. Drawn parcel is fictional.

Three separate questions about the same land: what interest the deed gives, what burdens continue, and who is in possession.

What the deed gives

Under the Municipal Government Act, the tax deed is evidence that the statutory sale provisions were followed. The Act says the deed vests the land in the grantee in **fee simple**, the broad form of private ownership people ordinarily mean when they speak of owning land. The phrase names the legal interest conveyed. The building's condition, the people inside, development plans and the

Words on this page

Also on this page: tax deed the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **fee simple** full ownership of land

surveyed boundary are questions for an inspector, the possession process, a planner and a surveyor.

The Act adds that the deed vests the land free and discharged from all **encumbrances**: claims, interests, charges or burdens that can affect title to land. That powerful language has a specific title job. Read it with the rest of the statute, any court order, the deed itself and the property record.

Burdens and benefits that stay with the land

Foundry Street's older parcel register shows a mortgage, a judgment and a registered right-of-way serving the house behind it. A hurried summary would say the deed erased everything. The statute says otherwise. An easement or right-of-way that benefits the land being sold passes with the land. One that burdens the land being sold continues: the Act provides that the sale leaves that relationship unaffected.

This is Chapter 6's access lesson from the other side. There, you asked whether a route gave the tax-sale parcel a legal way out. Here, Foundry Street may be the route another parcel relies on, and the statute carries both sides of that relationship through the sale.

So the title file needs more than the reassuring phrase "free of encumbrances." It needs the exact deed, the current parcel register, the instruments behind the relevant entries, the legal description, and a lawyer's reading of how the governing provisions apply to this parcel. For a continuing right-of-way, add its route, purpose, width, parties, maintenance language and any other terms in the source instruments. A driveway line in an aerial photo is a prompt to go and find those terms.

Court orders and surplus money

A municipal treasurer may also apply to a court for findings about tax arrears and for an order addressing the interests the deed will

Words on this page

Also on this page: **encumbrance** a claim or charge registered against land · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land · **easement** a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

convey, the interests it will remain subject to, notice, and the manner of sale. A sale on that route takes its legal effect from the statute and the order itself, including any exceptions, exclusions or partial interests the order sets out.

Foundry Street file: court order. Confirm whether the sale proceeded under a court order. If it did, obtain the order and have counsel identify the conveyed interest, every stated exception or exclusion, the redemption treatment, and how the order, deed, parcel register and source instruments relate.

Money is a separate question. A prior interest holder may have a statutory route to claim a share of the tax-sale surplus proceeds. That possible claim follows the money and is not automatically a continuing burden on the land. Chapter 12 traces it.

Why “clear title” is the wrong shorthand

A municipality may describe the statutory deed process, while current municipal guidance also warns bidders that clear title is not guaranteed. The two fit together: the statute gives a qualifying deed its legal effect, and the warning keeps an auction page from promising more. The bidder and the bidder’s lawyer handle the rest: a title opinion on this property, a search for every factual problem, possession, and whether the interest is readily insurable or marketable for a particular transaction.

A Nova Scotia property lawyer working from the file states what “fee simple” and “free of encumbrances” mean for this property. Beyond the court order and the rights-of-way, that review asks:

- Which statute governs this municipality: the Municipal Government Act or, in Halifax, its Charter?
- Does the legal description match the land you researched?
- Do the documents show an exception, exclusion, partial interest, boundary issue or other qualification?

Words on this page

surplus money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid: it is held in the tax-sale surplus account for people with prior interests to claim.

- Is another statute or property-specific record relevant?

Try it

After the tax deed, which Foundry Street register entry does the statute itself keep in place? Where might a former interest holder look for money?

Answer: The right-of-way serving the house behind, which continues as the Act specifies. A former interest holder may have a route to surplus money (Chapter 12) in place of a surviving claim against the parcel. For the mortgage and the judgment, ask the lawyer reading the deed, the register and any court order.

The people on the land

Foundry Street is occupied. Lights are on in two windows, a vehicle moves between parking spaces and mail keeps arriving. The deed has changed; the people inside are still there.

From the street, who is inside stays open: a former owner, a tenant, a family member, a guest, or someone whose situation fits no quick label. A parked vehicle and a curtained window are observations. Tenancy, trespass and abandonment are legal conclusions, and even a conversation at the door would give an untrained purchaser only part of the facts behind them.

Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM) gives the working example. Its current guidance says occupied properties can be sold, and that the municipality does not remove residents or provide access. Other municipalities set their own terms in their current materials. Everywhere, possession follows its own lawful process, separate from the deed.

The outcome most buyers picture is **vacant possession**: the buyer can lawfully take possession, and no other person remains entitled to occupy the property. Whether and how that can happen depends on the facts and the applicable law. “Immediate deed” describes redemption timing. A paid balance, and a sale advertisement with no tenant named, leave the possession question open.

Words on this page

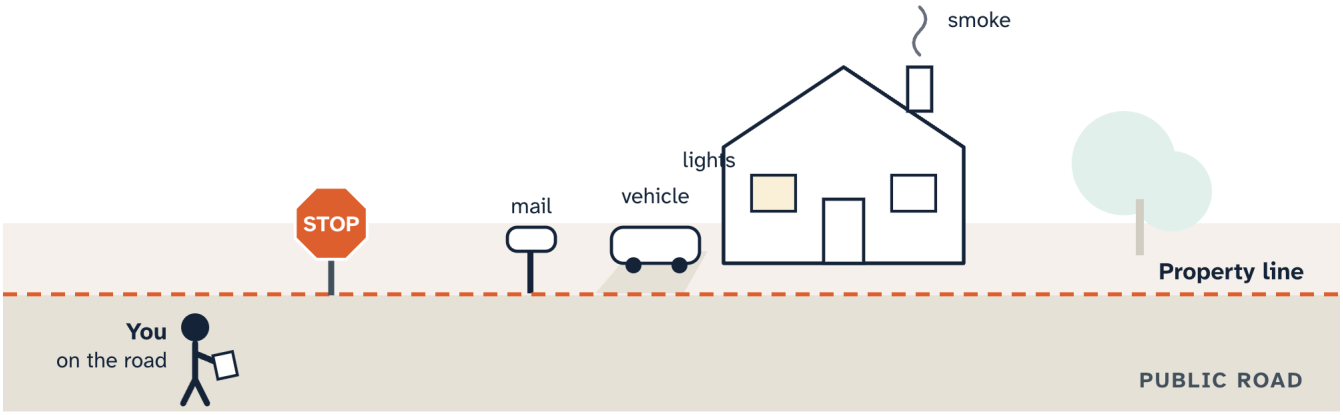
Also on this page: CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Title and possession are like a coat-check ticket and the coat in your hand. The ticket is evidence of entitlement; the coat is control, and a strong ticket still leaves the coat on the rack until it is lawfully handed over. The comparison ends there, because a home brings tenancies, court remedies and human safety into play.

Careful: Before the sale, observe a property that looks occupied only from a public road or other public land, and note the date and what you saw. At every stage, use no self-help. Changing locks, interrupting utilities, moving belongings or demanding rent or departure at the door can harm people's rights and safety, destroy evidence about the occupancy arrangement and make a hard legal problem worse. Take possession questions to a lawyer, with tenancy advice where it applies, before anyone makes contact with the occupants.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation



1 Observe from public land

vehicles · smoke · mail · lights

Write down the date, the time and where you stood.

2 Stop at the property line

Stay on public land. Leave doors and mailbox untouched.

Any contact goes through your lawyer.

3 Hand off the question

A lawyer or tenancy advice: who is in possession, and what notice the law requires.

BEFORE THE SALE

The land is still the owner's. The municipality runs the sale; permission to enter is the owner's to give.

AFTER THE SALE

A certificate holder may protect the land (MGA s. 151). Possession of an occupied home follows tenancy and property law.

CBRM tax-sale page and FAQ; Municipal Government Act s. 151; Nova Scotia Residential Tenancies resources; checked July 2026. Scene is illustrative.

If the property looks occupied: observe from public land, record what you saw, and take the question to a lawyer before any contact or action.

Behind that handoff, counsel may need to determine who is present, what documents or agreements exist, whether residential-tenancy law applies, what notices or proceedings are legally required, and how access can be obtained. The facts may point to different processes for an owner who remains, a tenant, an apparently empty unit that still holds goods, or an active dispute. Choosing among them is counsel's work.

The same care applies during redemption. Chapter 3 described the certificate holder's limited statutory powers and duties, including protecting the property, avoiding injury and collecting rent in the circumstances the statute describes. Those duties make the holder

Words on this page

Earlier words: **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation

responsible for the property, and the current document and legal stage still set the holder's job.

Goods are their own branch. A room that looks unused may still hold someone's furniture, records, medicine, tools or personal effects. Nova Scotia's residential-tenancy system has specific resources and forms for tenant property left behind, because "looks abandoned" is not a disposal standard. Establish the facts and the lawful process before anyone treats goods as abandoned.

Before a bid, possession is an input to the decision. The cost and time of the legal work may be unknown, and the interior unverified. Insurance, repairs, security and your intended use may all depend on lawful access, which sits outside the auction materials. A bidder who needs those answers before committing has learned something decisive without going near the door.

When the home and the land are separate

Now change one fact: the listing involves a manufactured home. The familiar PID appears in the notice, and the map shows a land parcel beneath the symbol. Which asset is being sold is still an open question.

Nova Scotia has specific tax-sale regulations and prescribed forms for mobile homes. The legal file first identifies whether the sale concerns the land, a mobile home, or a combination described by the controlling documents. An unaffixed home can also raise personal-property questions. Security interests in personal property, including mobile and manufactured homes, are searched in Nova Scotia's Personal Property Registry, a separate system from the land registry. A clean PID search leaves that search still to do.

Location adds a third record family. A manufactured home may sit on land someone else owns, in a land-lease community. Nova Scotia's Residential Tenancies framework applies to those communities, with rules about the space, the tenancy relationship and the sale of a home that stays there. Ownership of the home, ownership of the ground, the right to keep the home on the

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

space and any registered personal-property security are four distinct questions.

Harbour Park, a fictional composite. The municipal notice uses a mobile home identifier and a civic location. The map selects the underlying land PID. A roadside view shows a manufactured home on a serviced pad. Still open: whether home and land share an owner, whether the home is affixed to the land, whether the pad agreement transfers, whether a personal-property lien exists, and whether the home can stay where it sits after a sale.

File note: Asset identity unresolved. Confirm from the current municipal notice, the prescribed sale documents, land and mobile-home records, and counsel whether the sale concerns the home, the land or both. Search the personal-property system for the home and determine whether a land-lease relationship applies. A PID-only conclusion is unsupported.

That note feels slower than selecting the parcel and reading the aerial. It is faster than discovering after payment that the mapped ground and the visible home belong to different legal files.

Four questions before a bid

Foundry Street and Harbour Park now share one set of questions. What do you own? What burdens or benefits it? Who is there, and with what status? If a mobile home is involved, what exactly is the asset, and which registry or tenancy system governs each part?

Each question needs a supportable answer or an explicit stop condition before a bid, and an unfavourable answer still counts. Title counsel interprets the deed and the land interests, property and tenancy counsel identifies the lawful possession route, and the municipality clarifies its current sale documents and event terms.

Keeping these questions apart protects the accuracy of the file and the people whose lives carry on when the paperwork changes. Chapter 9 now goes back to the bid itself, where these open questions become costs and stop conditions. Foundry Street returns in Chapter 12, when the story reaches the deed in order.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 139A (court-directed sale), ss. 146–147 (surplus proceeds), s. 151 (certificate holder's powers and duties), ss. 155–156 (tax deed and its effect, including continuing easements and rights-of-way).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 154, 161–162, 166 and 170–171 (parallel provisions).
- Selling Mobile Homes at Tax Sale Definitions Regulations and Forms (Nova Scotia), refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Personal Property Registry; Residential Tenancies guidance for tenants and landlords, on ending a tenancy, and on land-lease communities; all refreshed 20 July 2026.
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and FAQ (occupied properties, residents, access and entry before the sale), refreshed 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **easement** a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Chapter 9

9 The Number You Decide Before the Room

What a tax-sale result sheet shows, and how to build a written maximum bid backward from your goal, your costs and a reserve for what is still unknown.

A tax-sale result sheet can look like a list of answers. It sets a recovery amount beside a winning bid, sometimes beside an assessment, and invites you to measure the gap. A small first number and a large second one can feel like proof that bidders found hidden value.

The sheet records competition at one event. What the bidders knew, what the property needed, whether the land was later redeemed and how things turned out for the winner all live in other records.

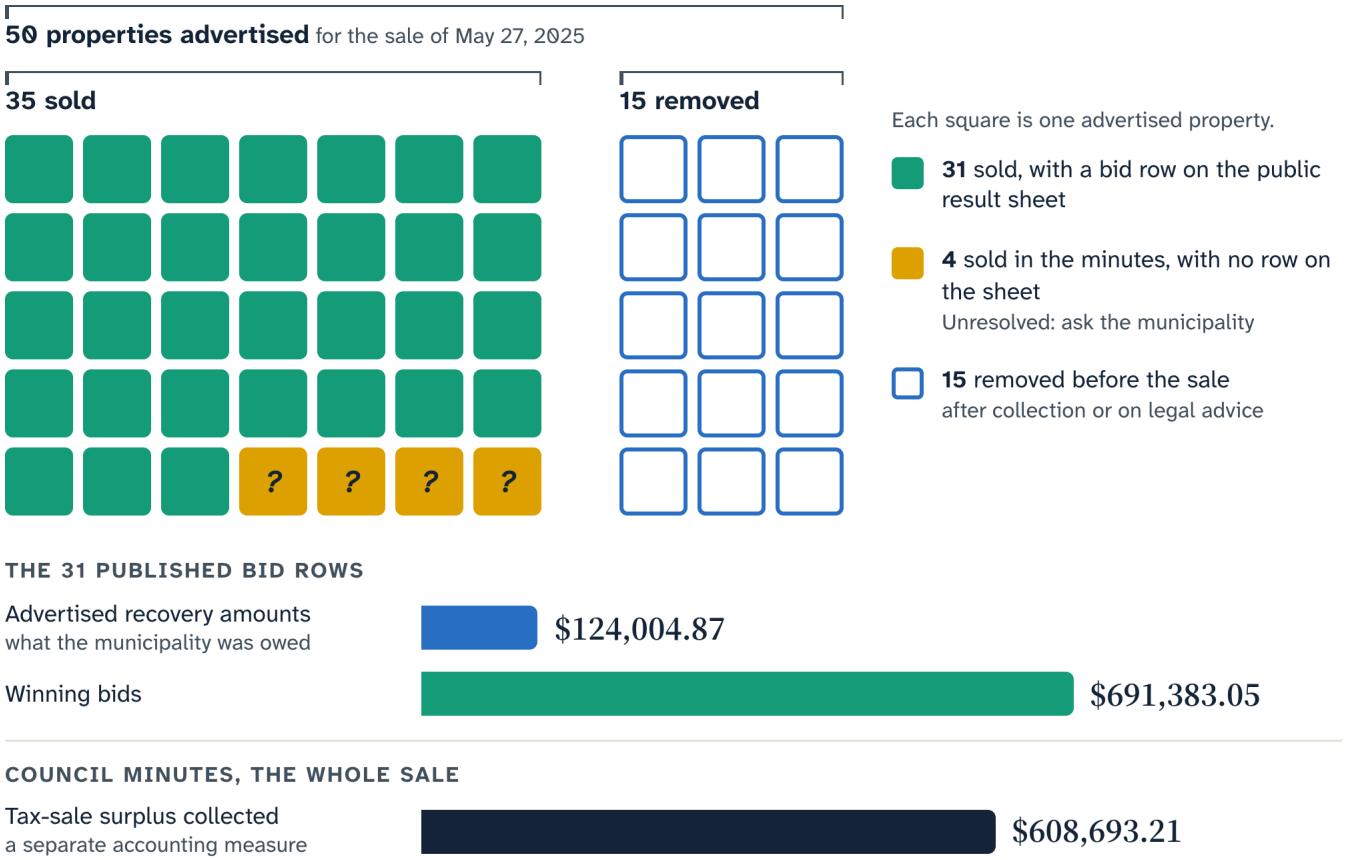
What a result sheet shows

The numbers in this section are past results. They describe past events and are not a forecast or a valuation.

Inverness County's May 2025 sale shows why you count before you calculate. The municipality advertised 50 properties. Council minutes from June 2025 report that 35 sold and 15 were removed before the sale after collection or legal advice. The public result sheet has 31 bid rows. The four-sale gap is unresolved, so keep all three counts: calling the 31-row sheet "all sales" changes the source.

Words on this page

Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected



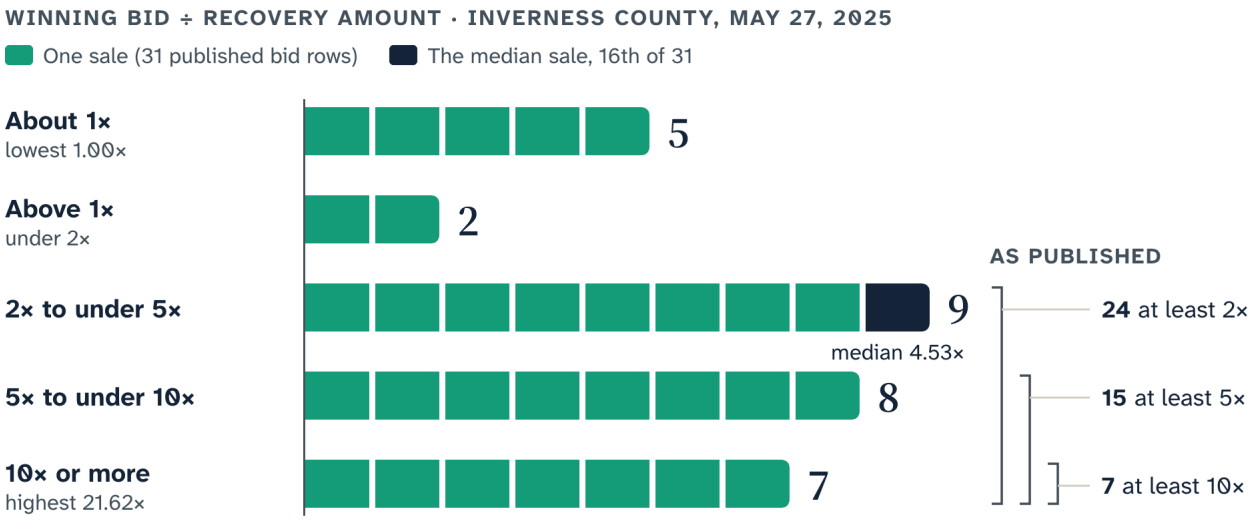
Inverness County: May 2025 property packet (50 advertised); 2025 tax-sale result sheet (31 bid rows); Committee of the Whole minutes, June 19, 2025 (35 sold, 15 removed, surplus).

Inverness County, May 2025: 50 properties advertised, 35 sold and 15 removed before the sale (council minutes). The public result sheet lists 31 bids; the four-row gap is unresolved.

Across those 31 rows, the median winning bid was 4.53 times the advertised recovery amount, and bids ranged from about the recovery amount to more than 21 times it. In that dated sample, competition often went well past the municipal recovery number.

Words on this page

Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected



Inverness County 2025 tax-sale result sheet (31 bid rows) and May 2025 property packet. The five buckets are derived from the published counts: 5 at about 1×, 24 at least 2×, 15 at least 5×, 7 at least 10×.

How far winning bids landed above the recovery amount in the 31 published Inverness rows (May 2025). Median: 4.53 times.

The minutes also report $608,693.21 in tax-sale surplus. Subtracting the recovery amounts from the bids in the 31 public rows gives a different total, because it covers a different set of rows and surplus is the municipality's own accounting measure. Keep both, each with its source.

The Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM) result sheet for March 2026 makes a useful contrast. Twenty-four recorded sales show both a minimum and a winning bid. Their median ratio was 3.17, and they ranged from exactly the minimum to more than 42 times it. Eight sold at the minimum; nine reached at least five times it.

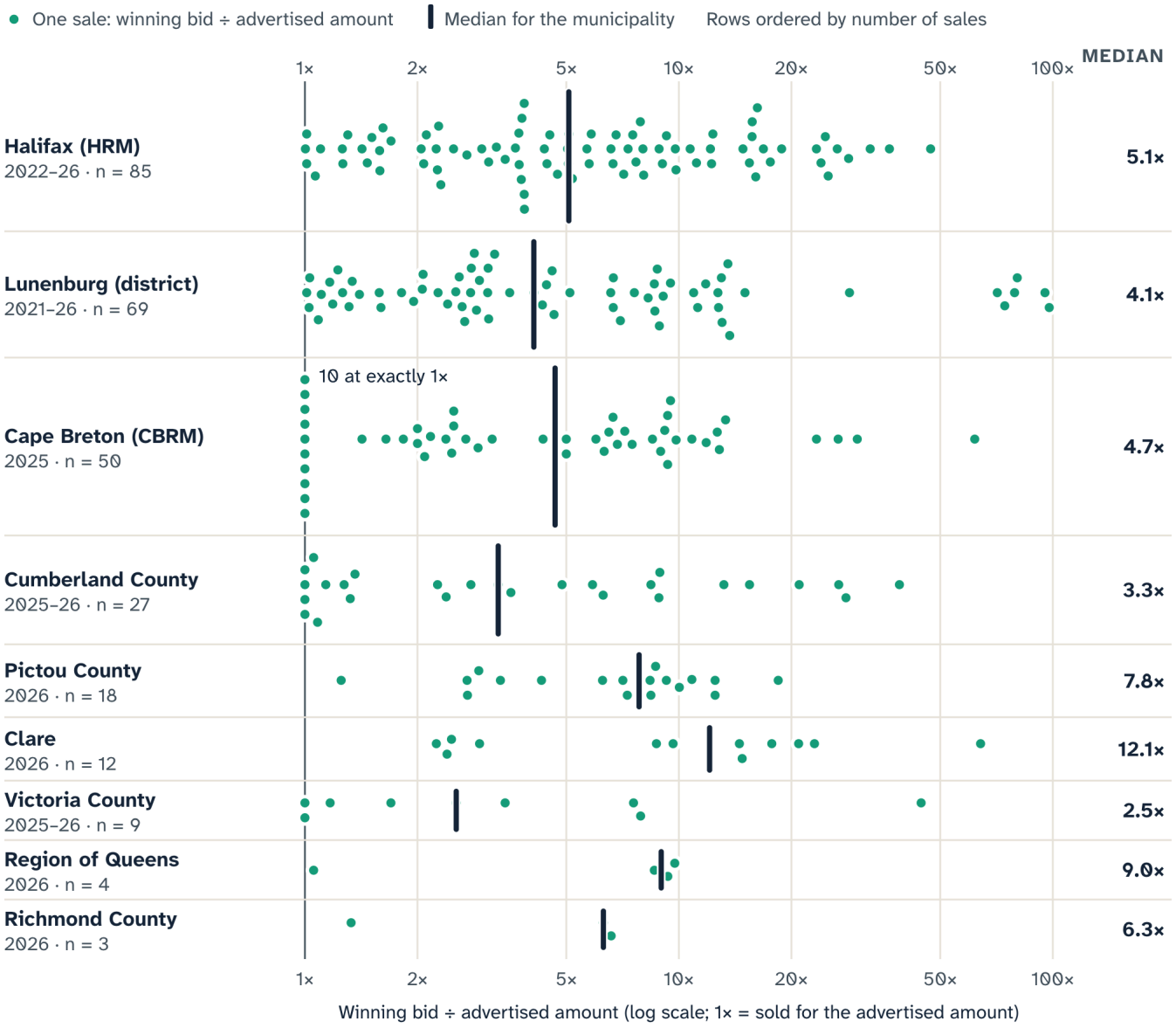
That mix matters more than any spectacular row. Some rows stopped at the starting amount and others climbed far past it. The cause could be the parcels, the bidders' research, mistaken identity, appetite for risk, intended use or the people who happened to attend, and the sheet gives no way to tell which.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

Richmond County's June 2026 table has three sold rows, at about 1.33, 6.59 and 6.28 times the listed taxes, interest and charges. Three rows are enough to show variation within one event and far too few to support a municipal price rule.

For the wider picture, the chart below plots every sold row showing both an advertised amount and a winning bid in NS Marks The Spot's catalogue of official municipal results, 2021 to 2026: 277 sales at 25 events in nine municipalities. Each advertised amount is a debt figure, and the winning bids spread across a wide range above it.



Official municipal result documents from 25 sales events, March 2021 to September 2026, compiled in NS Marks The Spot (historicalTaxSales.json, commit 43e40b0b8; retrieved July–October 2026). Sold rows with both amounts. The advertised amount is each event's published minimum or opening bid, total owing, or taxes, interest and charges.

Winning bid divided by the advertised amount for 277 sales at 25 events, 2021 to 2026: every sold row with both figures in NS Marks The Spot's catalogue of official municipal results. Each dot is one sale. The advertised amount is a debt figure, and bids land across a wide range above it.

Comparisons like this need labels: each sample's municipality, event date, sale format, number of published rows, denominator and known completeness limit. A minimum bid at one event

and listed charges at another can play similar roles and still be different fields.

The historical layer in NS Marks The Spot shortens the route to a dated official outcome and keeps its municipality, event, Parcel Identification Number (PID), result label, amount and source link together. A historical parcel you select is a record of that event. An appraisal, comparable sales and your maximum for the next parcel come from other evidence.

The assessment, as Chapter 2 explained, supports the property-tax system. It helps identify the account, its classification and the scale of the municipal record. Calling the gap between a winning bid and an assessment "equity" takes title, condition, access and market evidence that neither number holds.

Cedar Street and the all-in cost

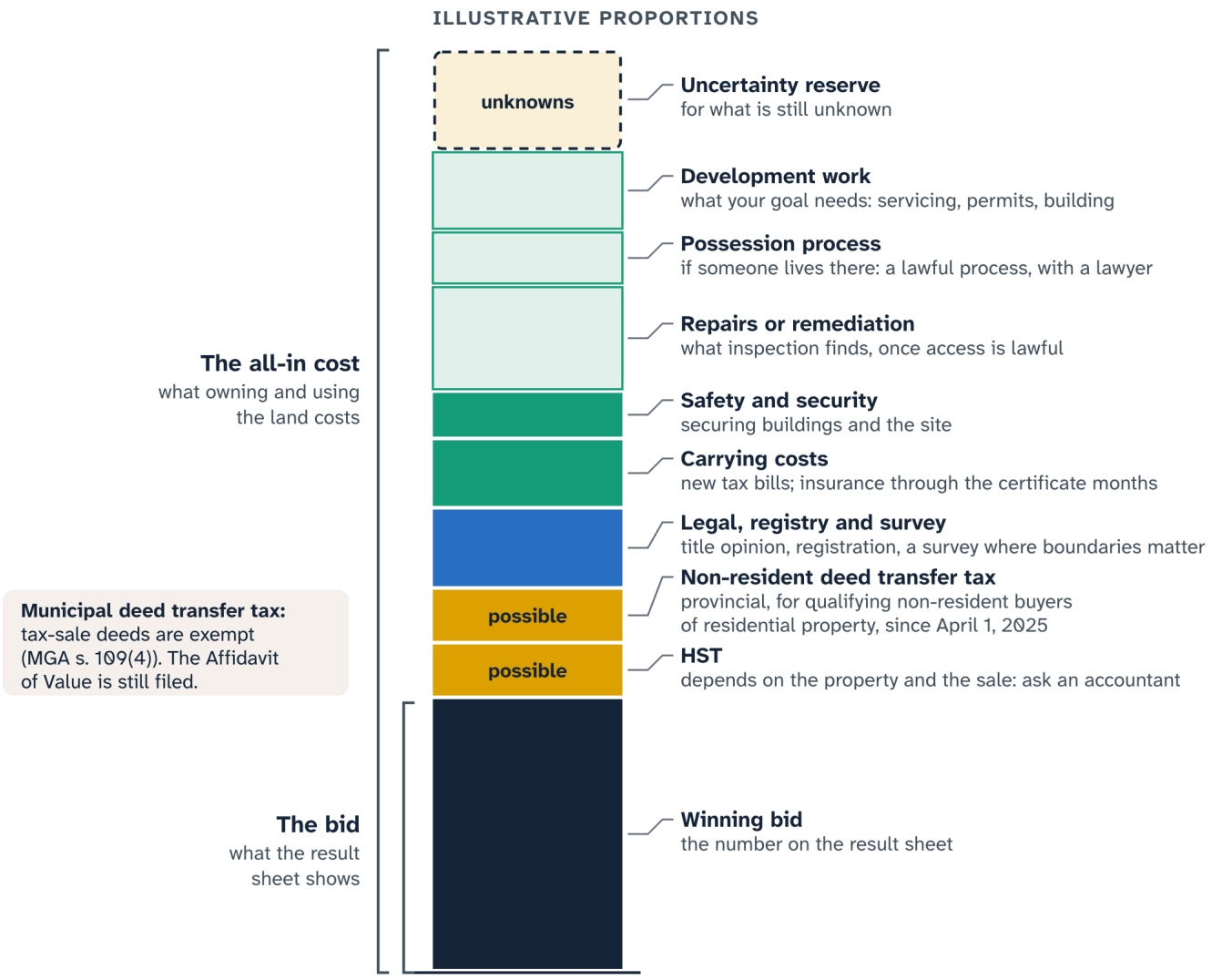
Take a fictional composite we will call Cedar Street: a building with a four-figure recovery amount and a six-figure assessment. The apparent discount arrives before the file knows whether the building is occupied, insurable, structurally usable or lawfully reachable for the intended work. The questions from Chapters 6 to 8 (access and use, environment, possession) are still there when the price looks small, and now the money depends on them.

That is why **all-in cost** is useful. It is the total you must be ready to spend to reach a defined use: the bid, applicable taxes, professional work, carrying costs, condition work, possession and a reserve for unresolved uncertainty. It starts with a use because "own the parcel" leaves the destination open. A year-round home, a serviced building lot, a woodlot and a long-term hold each need different evidence and different work.

Think of the bid as the tip of an iceberg. The rest of the cost can sit below the waterline. The hidden share varies from parcel to parcel, and each known part gets researched and estimated like any other line.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **NS** Nova Scotia · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected



Municipal Government Act s. 109(4); Nova Scotia non-resident deed transfer tax page; CRA GST/HST guidance and event terms (checked July 2026). Proportions are illustrative; every file differs.

The bid is the first layer of the cost. An all-in budget adds taxes, professional fees, carrying costs, repairs, possession and a reserve for what is still unknown.

Try it

A file holds a recovery amount, an assessment and a winning bid from a past result sheet. Which describes debt recovery, which serves taxation and which records a dated competition? What would any of them need to support a present value?

Answer: The recovery amount, the assessment and the old bid, in that order. A present value needs evidence about this property for a

Words on this page

Also on this page: recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

stated use (title, access, condition, possession and planning) plus valuation evidence, such as a qualified appraisal when the stakes call for it.

Competition measures how a room behaved. Cedar Street's number is built backward, from a defined use and a supported value, through known costs and open dependencies, to the uncertainty the bidder can safely carry. It is never a multiple of the recovery amount.

Three groups of cost

Cedar Street's intended use is a modest rehabilitation. Writing it down gives the cost file a destination. The file then tests whether the project is feasible by asking which costs stand between the bid and a building that lawfully and safely serves that use. They fall into three groups.

The first, acquisition and legal work, covers the bid, registration charges, title and deed review, searches, advice about continuing interests and any work needed to understand possession. A survey or boundary opinion belongs here when the project depends on a fact the existing records leave unsettled. Chapter 8's occupied-building question becomes a cost and timing line, priced from advice on the lawful process and left open until that advice arrives. A guessed eviction budget has no place in it.

The second carries the property through time. Insurance may be available only on particular terms, or may stay unresolved until an insurer understands the building and the legal stage. Taxes continue. Security, heat, utilities, weather protection, financing, travel and professional coordination add up while title, redemption, possession, design or approvals are unfinished. The calendar has a price even when no repair crew is working.

The third is the physical work the use requires: building work, water and sewage, access, servicing, environmental assessment, remediation, demolition and permit-dependent work, each entered where evidence supports it. An exterior photograph starts a list of

Words on this page

Also on this page: **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected

questions; a reliable rehabilitation estimate needs much more. A missing environmental record is a blank, which is different from zero. A visible road leaves the survey and access questions open.

Each group mixes evidence states. Some items can be quoted before the auction. Some can be bounded by a defensible range or allowance. Others resist responsible pricing with the access, time or evidence available. An essential item of that last kind needs a stop condition, and a bigger miscellaneous line only hides it.

An **uncertainty reserve** is money held back for risks real enough to affect the decision and still too open to quote exactly. It works when the bidder can describe the uncertainty, explain why a range is tolerable and survive the bad outcome without giving up the intended use or required obligations.

An unknown foundation repair might support a reserve when exterior and professional evidence give a meaningful range. Unverified legal access for a project that needs road access may remain a no-go. Unknown occupancy costs may resist pricing while the lawful process and its timing are unknown.

Careful: A reserve covers variation you can bound. It cannot supply a missing legal right or a permission.

Cedar Street's arithmetic, kept small. A $30,000 bid, $40,000 of known non-bid costs and a $20,000 uncertainty reserve make an all-in exposure of $90,000. The structure is the lesson: bid, known costs, reserve.

Real numbers for Cedar Street need property-specific evidence. A new intended use changes the file. So does a lawyer's title finding, an insurer's refusal, a survey result, an environmental opinion or a lawful inspection. The cost stack moves when the evidence moves.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation

Taxes and eligibility

Tax questions branch off before the maximum is written. The Municipal Government Act exempts a deed given pursuant to a tax sale from municipal deed transfer tax. That exemption is specific: registration charges, harmonized sales tax (HST), the provincial non-resident deed transfer tax, income-tax consequences and the cost of advice stay in the file as separate lines.

The provincial non-resident deed transfer tax can apply to qualifying non-residents acquiring residential property. For qualifying transfers after March 2025, the Province states a ten percent rate based on the non-resident interest and the higher of the purchase price or the assessed value, subject to the governing definitions and exemptions. A high assessment can therefore set the tax on a low bid. One exemption route covers qualifying individuals who move to Nova Scotia within six months and provide the required proof. Confirm your status and the tax treatment with current provincial guidance and professional advice before the auction.

HST is a separate branch. CBRM's event instructions, checked in July 2026, say HST applies to vacant land and commercially assessed property. A CBRM bidder needs to clarify and fund that rule. Other events need their own answer, and Canada Revenue Agency guidance shows that the treatment of real property can depend on the seller, prior use, the property, the transaction and the purchaser's registration status. Record the event's terms, get tax advice for the specific case, and resist the reading that happens to make the numbers work.

Eligibility comes before price. As of July 2026, the federal prohibition on certain direct or indirect purchases of residential property by non-Canadians is scheduled to run through January 1, 2027. The Act and regulations contain definitions and exceptions,

Words on this page

HST Harmonized Sales Tax

Also on this page: CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality

and current guidance discusses geography, vacant land and genuine development. Each needs exact, current review.

Careful: A bid the auction accepts can still be a purchase the law forbids. Settle eligibility, for the bidder and for the transaction, before the sale.

Four questions now sit in the file:

- Does the municipal tax-sale deed exemption apply to this deed?
- Could the provincial non-resident tax apply to this buyer and this property?
- What is the HST treatment of this particular transaction?
- Is the buyer eligible under current federal, provincial and municipal law?

An open branch puts the file on hold until its effect is confirmed, bounded or made a stop condition. A tax large enough to change the project gets settled before the sale; the three-business-day payment window is too late.

The written maximum

The maximum starts from a **supported value boundary**: the highest all-in amount the bidder can defend for the stated use, under title, condition and market assumptions written into the file. In plain terms, it is what the land is worth to you for your goal, with the evidence attached. It comes from property-specific valuation evidence, with a qualified appraisal or valuation advice when the stakes or the uncertainty call for it. Without that evidence by the decision deadline, there is no defensible maximum to calculate.

From there, the number is built backward. Known non-bid costs and the uncertainty reserve use up part of the boundary. What remains can become the maximum bid if every essential legal, eligibility, payment and no-go condition is met. If nothing remains, the research has produced a no-bid result.

A **maximum bid** is the written highest amount the bidder is authorized to offer after accounting for the intended use, the supported value boundary, known costs, reserves, taxes and no-go conditions. It is a stopping rule for one bidder's plan, and it predicts nothing about what the property is worth to anyone else.

It also has to be fundable. Under the statutory payment rules, the purchaser makes the required immediate payment and completes any balance within three business days. The current municipal terms set the accepted methods and event details. A written maximum needs ready funds behind it to be a decision you can carry out.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality

ONE SHEET PER LIEN — complete and sign before the sale

Municipality _____ Sale date _____ Lien no. _____

My written goal for this property _____

(A) Value to me, for that goal — $ _____
From evidence for this use; the advertised amount is a debt figure
Evidence used _____

(B) All-in costs other than the bid — − $ _____
Possible taxes, legal, registry and survey, carrying costs, repairs, possession, development

(C) Reserve for unresolved items — − $ _____
One line per open question, each with an amount
Items _____

A − B − C the most this land is worth bidding, to me — = $ _____

(D) Payment I can make on the sale's clock
In a form the sale's terms accept

Today: the price, or at least the recovery amount — $ _____
Within 3 business days: the balance — + $ _____ = $ _____

WRITTEN MAXIMUM
the lower of (A – B – C) and D — $ _____

Signed _____ Date _____

Payment clock: Municipal Government Act s. 148 (Halifax: Charter s. 163), as amended in 2025; each sale's current terms set the accepted forms of payment.

A written maximum, worked out before the sale: what the land is worth to you for your goal, minus every cost and a reserve for what is still unknown.

Cedar Street's worksheet is finished before anyone enters the room. It records the intended use, source dates, professional findings, known costs, the reserve, the tax and eligibility branches, payment readiness, the maximum bid and the facts that would cancel the bidder's authority to take part. It has no line for "one more increment because the room is excited."

Words on this page

Earlier words: **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality

Now the live auction reaches the written maximum, and another card goes up. The title file holds the same documents. The building is no easier to insure, the occupancy question is still open, and the environmental and access questions stand where they were. The one new fact is that someone else will pay more.

The bidder lowers the card, carrying out the decision the research supported. The winning number in this chapter is the one that still protects you after the room has moved past it.

Where this comes from

- Municipality of the County of Inverness: May 27, 2025 tax-sale property packet; 2025 property-tax results; Committee of the Whole minutes, 19 June 2025 (counts, removals and reported surplus). Checked 20 July 2026.
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality: sold-property results, 10 March 2026 tax sale; Tax Sales page and event instructions (HST). Checked 20 July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Richmond: Tax Sales page and 12 June 2026 results, checked 20 July 2026.
- NS Marks The Spot: historical layer and catalogue of official municipal tax-sale results, 2021–2026.
- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 109(4) (municipal deed transfer tax exemption for tax-sale deeds), ss. 141 and 143 (the amount a sale must recover), s. 148 (immediate payment and balance within three business days).
- Province of Nova Scotia, Non-resident Provincial Deed Transfer Tax, checked 20 July 2026.
- Canada Revenue Agency, *Sales of Vacant Land by Individuals* and *Real Property and the GST/HST*, checked 20 July 2026.
- Prohibition on the Purchase of Residential Property by Non-Canadians Act and Regulations; Department of Finance extension notice; Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation guidance. Checked 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

GST Goods and Services Tax

Also on this page: HST Harmonized Sales Tax · **NS** Nova Scotia

10 Chapter 10 When the Card Goes Up

How a Nova Scotia tax sale runs as an open auction or a sealed tender, and what being ready to pay means on the day. It also follows the branches the law provides when a sale goes off script.

The Cedar Street file from Chapter 9 has reached the door of the auction room. Its intended use, open conditions, payment route and maximum bid are all written down, and so is the bidder's authority. A faster heartbeat adds nothing to any of them.

The bidder is a fictional composite we will call Maya.

Two formats, one decision

Inverness County's terms for its August 2026 sale, checked for this edition, describe a public auction in St. Peter's Parish Hall in Port Hood. Bidders appear in person, follow the event's registration rules and compete while the treasurer calls each property. That is an **open-outcry auction**: a live public process in which participants answer the bids called in the room until no higher acceptable bid is offered. The format puts pressure on display: the next increment, another card rising, the silence that follows.

Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM) shows the mechanics in more detail. For its July 21, 2026 sale, bidders registered with government-issued photo identification and received numbered bidding cards. Other municipalities can publish their own operational details within the same law, so the current notice and terms travel with the bidder.

Outside Halifax, the Municipal Government Act makes public auction the usual route, and the treasurer may, with council's consent, call tenders instead. In a public tender, bidders submit

Words on this page

Also on this page: CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **tender** a sale by sealed written offers · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

offers by a stated deadline, and the municipality opens and evaluates them under the event's terms. Each offer goes in once, with no live calls to answer. Pictou County's April 2026 sale was a dated sealed-tender example: each bidder chose one amount before the tender left their control, under that event's submission rules.

Annapolis County's records make the case for dating every format label. Its site keeps results from a March 2026 tax sale and later results from a June sale by tender, which shows that a municipality may use more than one statutory route over time. The June tender is closed, and the next Annapolis event will bring its own notice and rules.

Words on this page

Also on this page: tender a sale by sealed written offers

Open auction The default under the Act		Sealed tender With council's consent
Register in person Photo ID at the door; you get a numbered bidding card. **CBRM, July 21, 2026**	1 GET IN	**Deliver one sealed offer** In writing, in an envelope, before the stated deadline.
Bid out loud, in the open Every card in the room sees every bid and can answer it. 	2 MAKE THE OFFER	**Choose one amount, once** Each bidder writes a single figure without seeing the others. 
Highest bid when the calling stops Decided in the room, on the day.	3 WINNER	**Highest acceptable tender** Envelopes are opened after the deadline. Kings County livestreams its openings where it can. **Kings County agenda, Feb 4, 2025**
Pay at once, then the balance At once: the price, or at least the recovery amount. The balance within 3 business days. Inverness adds a $200 registration amount. **Inverness, Aug 11, 2026**	4 PAY	**Pay as the tender terms set out** The tender notice sets the amount due and the deadline. **Pictou, 2026 tender**

One statute **MGA s. 141** (Halifax: Charter s. 156): auction by default, tender with council's consent. Council may set an acceptable minimum. **The current notice names the format and its terms.**

Municipal Government Act ss. 141, 148, consolidated to April 9, 2026. CBRM, Inverness, Kings and Pictou sale records, checked July 20, 2026.

Auction and tender: two ways the same statute lets a municipality sell. The current notice says which one, and on what terms.

Each format has its own temptation. In the room, a bidder may chase a visible rival. At a desk, a bidder may raise a sealed offer to avoid losing by some imagined small margin. Either way, the parcel evidence is the same, and Cedar Street's maximum enters both formats unchanged.

At an auction, Maya knows who is authorized to bid, which card carries that authority and the exact amount at which the card stays

Words on this page

Also on this page: tender a sale by sealed written offers

down. At a tender, she checks the same ceiling against the submission rules and deadline before the offer goes in. There is no second private number called “what I would have bid if I knew.”

Three questions before the room

Authority takes more than identification or a signed letter.

Careful: The Municipal Government Act bars these people from buying land at the selling municipality’s tax sale, directly or through an agent:

- a council member or employee of that municipality;
- specified village commission members or employees;
- the spouses of those people;
- a company in which one of those people owns or beneficially owns a majority of the outstanding shares.

The statute attaches a penalty and possible loss of office or employment.

That rule covers one statutory group. The federal, tax, corporate-authority and representation questions from Chapter 9 have their own answers, and registering for the event is a separate step again. Maya’s pre-event sheet keeps three questions apart:

- Is she legally eligible to acquire this kind of property?
- Does she, or her agent, have documented authority to make this particular bid?
- Has she complied with the event’s registration or tender-submission instructions?

Each needs its own yes. Maya and her advisers establish her eligibility and authority, and the municipality administers its event. The researcher’s file supplies sources, dates, boundaries and open professional questions; the purchase decision stays with Maya.

Try it

The registration desk checks Maya’s identification and signs her in. Which of her three questions has that answered?

Words on this page

Also on this page: **tender** a sale by sealed written offers

Answer: Only the third. The first two need their own evidence on her sheet.

Auction morning

Auction morning begins with a source refresh. The August Inverness packet lists 45 liens, and its summary and detail pages still need reconciling. More important on the day, any listed account may have been paid, removed or otherwise changed before its turn comes.

The live municipal status controls. A saved PDF, an NS Marks The Spot screenshot and a research worksheet each record what was known at a stated time. If Cedar Street is withdrawn, Maya's authority to bid ends with the announcement, and research about the parcel opens no private route to buy it. Her file keeps its dated records, which show what was known and why she was prepared, and changes its status field. The reason, whether an owner's payment, a municipal deferral or another legal event, goes in only when the authoritative source establishes it.

If the property is called, the worksheet changes jobs. It stops helping Maya find a price and tells her what she already authorized: any bid below the maximum is open to her, and a bid above it is ruled out by her own file. In open outcry that plays out in seconds. The called amount is below Maya's ceiling. Her card rises. Another card raises the price. She answers while the amount stays within her authority. The next call crosses the line. Her card stays down.

This is the Chapter 9 retrieval under noise. Did the higher call create a right of access, improve title, empty the building, shrink the tax costs or put money in the bank? It changed one fact: another participant offered more. Maya's research is the same, so her authority is the same.

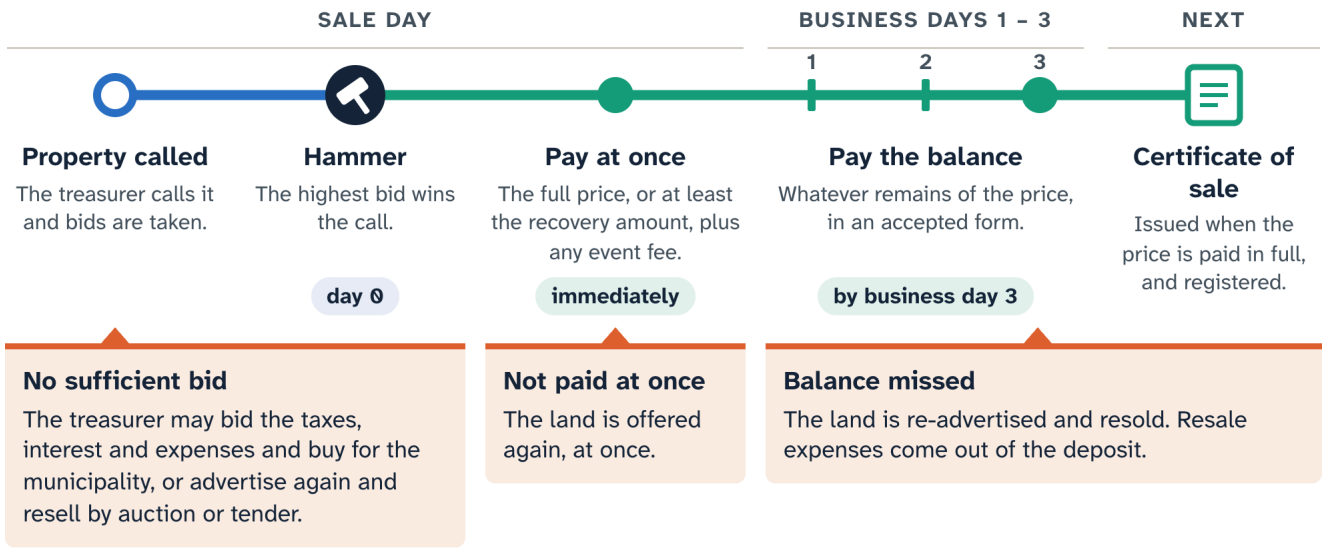
Ready to pay

Payment needs the same rehearsal. Under the Municipal Government Act, the statutory payment forms are cash, certified cheque, money order, bank draft, irrevocable letter of credit and a lawyer's trust cheque. Council may authorize another legal-tender delivery method. Each event's current terms decide which methods the municipality will take and how they must be delivered.

Inverness's August 2026 terms list cash, certified cheque, money order, debit, bank draft and lawyer's trust cheque. Its FAQ says the successful bidder must immediately pay the taxes, interest and expenses for which the property was sold, plus the stated $200 registration amount. Any remaining purchase price is due within three business days.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **tender** a sale by sealed written offers



TWO DATED SALES ON THIS CLOCK

CBRM, July 21, 2026 Register in person with photo ID; bid with a numbered card.	The minimum plus its administrative fee	The balance within 3 business days
Inverness County, August 11, 2026 In-person public auction in Port Hood.	Taxes, interest and expenses + the $200 registration amount	The rest of the price within 3 business days

PAYMENT FORMS NAMED IN THE ACT

Cash · Certified cheque · Money order · Bank draft · Irrevocable letter of credit · Lawyer's trust cheque

Council may authorize another method. Each sale's current terms list the forms it takes.

Municipal Government Act ss. 143, 148–150 (Halifax: Charter ss. 158–159, 163–165), consolidated to April 9, 2026. CBRM and Inverness County sale terms, checked July 20, 2026.

The payment clock at a Nova Scotia tax sale, and what happens when a step is missed.

The **deposit** is the amount paid at once toward the purchase, before the remaining balance is completed. Under the statute's auction rules, the buyer must immediately pay the whole purchase price or a smaller amount equal to the taxes, interest and expenses for which the land was sold. Event charges can sit beside it, like Inverness's $200 amount or the administrative fee CBRM's July 2026 sale added to the minimum. CBRM's sale gave the same three business days for the balance. Use each municipality's current term and amount.

Words on this page

Also on this page: CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality

Careful: Maya has two readiness tests to pass before she bids: the immediate amount on hand in a form the event accepts, and a verified path to the balance within three business days. A plan to ask a lender after the sale is not ready money.

A bank draft is drawn for one fixed amount. A debit card works only if the municipality accepts debit and Maya's bank permits the transaction.

Maya's payment sheet for Cedar Street

- The current event, confirmed on the municipal page.
- The amount required immediately.
- The accepted payment method she holds for it.
- The account or instrument that will complete the balance.
- The three-business-day deadline.
- The person authorized to act.

If any field is still unverified, Maya does not bid on Cedar Street, however affordable the maximum looks.

Tendering moves the moment and keeps the test. Pictou's April 2026 notice required the successful tenderer to pay the bid price in full within three days after notification, with no live hammer and no immediate auction deposit. The format changed what starts the clock and added no room for financing conditions after acceptance, so the payment route had to be ready before the tender went in.

Suppose Maya wins a different fictional parcel within her maximum, and the bank draft she expected falls through that day. Her file may be sound and her price authorized; her payment has still failed. Raising the maximum would solve nothing, and asking the sale to wait would try to change the process after the bid.

Ready means eligible authority, current event status, an intact ceiling, an accepted immediate payment and a verified balance path. When any one fails, keeping the card down is the completed decision.

Words on this page

Also on this page: tender a sale by sealed written offers

When the sale leaves the straight line

The ordinary event runs in a straight line: the property is called, a highest acceptable bid emerges, payment is made and the treasurer moves toward a certificate of sale. The statute also provides for the times that line breaks.

The first break comes before there is a purchaser. If the recovery amount is called and nobody offers enough, the treasurer may bid the taxes, interest and expenses and buy the land for the municipality. The Act also lets a municipality bid and buy through an official or agent for a municipal purpose.

“May” matters: the municipality decides whether to buy. If it declines, it may advertise the property again and later sell it at auction for the best obtainable price, or by highest tender, subject to any acceptable minimum directed by council. The unsold parcel stays inside that municipal, advertised process. CBRM’s result legend, as checked in July 2026, says so directly: an unsold property may be purchased only at a future tax sale. Elsewhere, the municipality’s own current record names the next step.

The second break comes right after a high bid. If the purchaser fails to make the immediate payment, the treasurer must put the land up for sale again forthwith.

CBRM’s July 2026 instructions put that branch in room language: a bid without immediate payment is void, and the property is auctioned again. The next bidder has no automatic claim to the first winning amount; the treasurer reopens the process under the event’s rules. Maya, if she is still eligible and prepared, returns to her original ceiling.

The third break comes after the deposit is paid, when the balance misses the three-business-day deadline. The Act sends the land back to advertisement and sale. Resale expenses are deducted from the deposit, and the remaining balance of the deposit is refunded

Words on this page

Also on this page: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **certificate of sale** the document a purchaser receives after paying in full · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected · **tender** a sale by sealed written offers

after the resale is held. The amount and timing depend on the actual municipal process, and until then the bidder's money stays tied to a future event.

Tenders follow their own statutory route. The person whose tender is accepted has three business days after notification to pay the tender price. Failure sends the land back toward advertisement and sale, with the statute's treatment of resale expenses and any deposit. A municipal tender notice may also describe how it handles acceptance, rejection or moving to another bid. Read the Act, the council's authority and the exact event terms together, all from the same municipality.

A schedule change calls for the same discipline. The statutory notice states the advertised date, time and place, and the tax-sale provisions reviewed for this book give bidders no general script for a postponement, cancellation or rescheduling dispute. Whether a changed event is proceeding, cancelled or validly rescheduled is a question for the municipality's current notice.

If heavy weather closes the hall or a revised date is posted, Maya goes back to the municipal page and current notice. She confirms the affected properties, time, place, registration and payment terms, and gets legal advice if the change itself is disputed. A social-media post, an old advertisement or another bidder's memory can point her to the source; the current notice is the source.

A completed payment starts a new clock. Cedar Street is in the redeemable branch. If Maya stays within her authority, satisfies the event terms and pays the purchase money, the treasurer gives a certificate of sale. That opens the certificate-holder months of Chapter 11, while redemption is still possible and the deed is further off.

To someone who studied a parcel and missed the first call, the other outcomes can sound like opportunities. Each is a state change with a name: withdrawn, no sufficient bidder, municipal purchase, immediate re-offer, later re-advertisement or verified event change.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **tender** a sale by sealed written offers · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **certificate of sale** the document a purchaser receives after paying in full

Each sends Maya back to the current municipal source, the limits of her evidence file and the maximum she wrote down before she came.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 141 (auction or tender, council consent and acceptable minimum), s. 142(2A) (notice states the date, time and place), s. 143 (no sufficient bid, municipal purchase and resale), s. 144 (people prohibited from buying), ss. 148–149 (payment forms, immediate payment, three-business-day balance, failed payment and resale).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 156–159 and 163–164 (the parallel Halifax provisions).
- Municipality of the County of Inverness, Property Tax Sales page and December 2025 FAQ, refreshed 20 July 2026; tax sale property packet for 11 August 2026 (published 16 July 2026, retrieved 19 July 2026).
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page: instructions for the 21 July 2026 sale, FAQ and result legend, checked 20 July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Pictou, 2026-01 sealed-tender advertisement (revised 10 April 2026), checked 20 July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Annapolis, Tax Sale page with the 5 March 2026 sale results and 8 June 2026 tender results, checked 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **tender** a sale by sealed written offers

11 Chapter 11 The Certificate-Holder Months

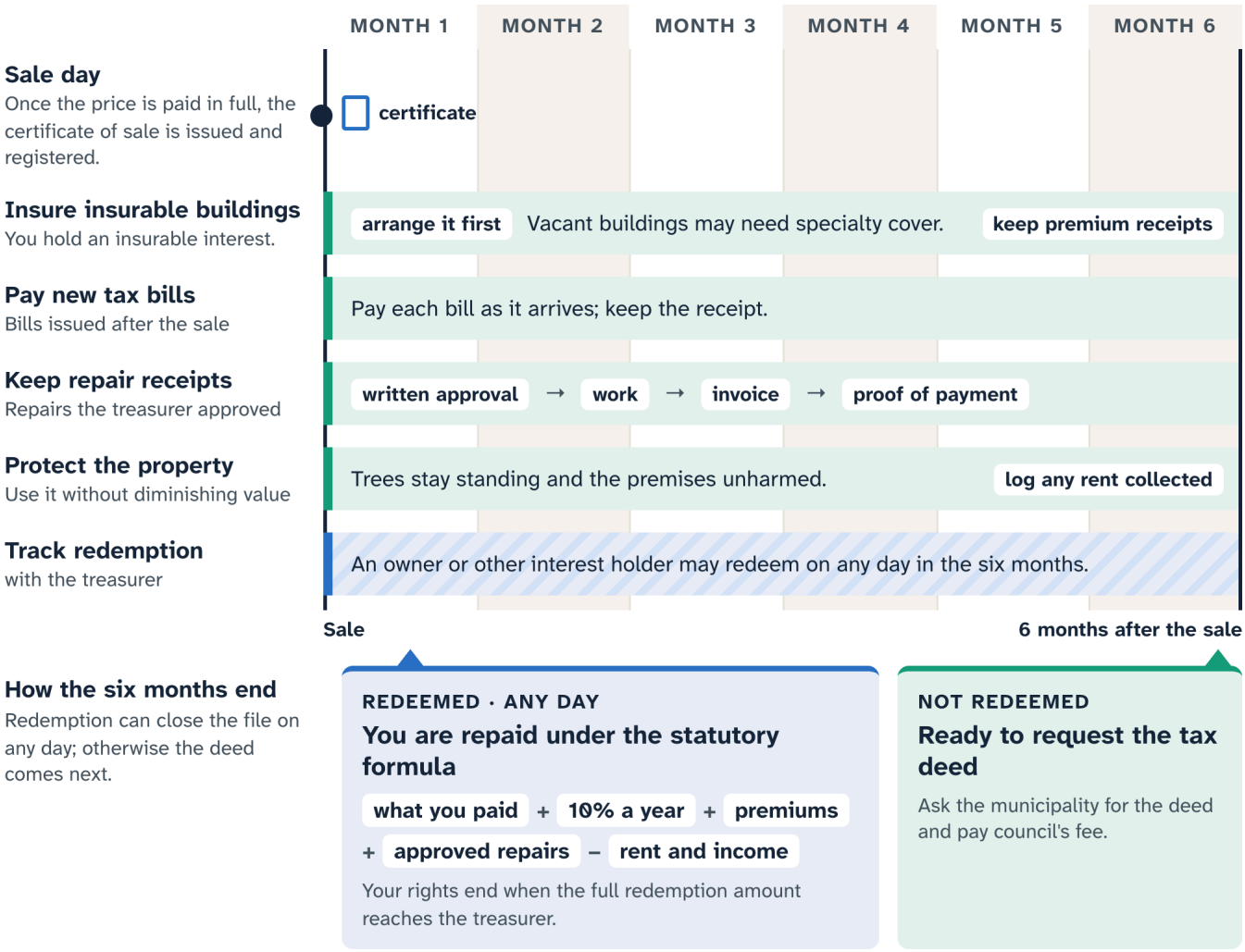
What a certificate holder may do, must do and should record during the six-month redemption period, and how the file closes when someone redeems.

Maya, the bidder from Chapter 10, leaves the Cedar Street sale with the purchase money paid in full. The treasurer gives her a certificate of sale describing the land and the price, and registers a copy. The treasurer also sends out the copies and redemption notice the statute requires. The auction room is finished. A calendar has begun.

Cedar Street is redeemable. For six months after the sale, the owner or another person with a qualifying interest may redeem it. If nobody does, a tax deed may follow. Until then Maya holds a middle stage, with real responsibilities, conditional rights and an ending that may return the property to someone else.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **redemption period** the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **certificate of sale** the document a purchaser receives after paying in full · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period



Municipal Government Act ss. 150–155 (Halifax: Charter ss. 165–170), consolidated to April 9, 2026; insurer vacancy guidance checked July 2026.

The six certificate-holder months: protect the property, insure what can be insured, keep receipts, and stay ready for either redemption or a deed request.

What the certificate asks of you

Nova Scotia's Municipal Government Act gives a certificate holder the owner-like powers needed to protect the land. The holder may collect rents due or becoming due, and may use the land without diminishing its value.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **GST** Goods and Services Tax · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

Day to day, the months come down to five jobs:

- protect the property against immediate loss;
- insure the buildings, if they are insurable;
- pay the new tax bills when due;
- document every approval, invoice, receipt and payment;
- track income from the land, and the redemption status with the treasurer.

The Act also forbids cutting trees, injuring the premises, or knowingly allowing anyone else to do so.

Protection or development?

Those powers mark out a narrow lane. A leaking opening may need protection before the next rain; a full redesign for Maya's planned rehabilitation can wait. Cutting mature trees for a future view falls outside the lane, and so does damage passed off as cleanup. The certificate months carry the property through uncertainty, and the construction season comes later, if at all.

Purpose and scale tell protection from development. Work that stops an immediate loss is protective; work that changes the property for a future use is development. Even protective work depends on entry, occupancy, tenancy, safety, permits, contractor authority and the building's exact condition. When any of those is unsettled, the next call goes to the municipality, a lawyer, the insurer or the right professional.

People, possession and safety

Cedar Street appears vacant from the public road, and "appears" stays in the file. Curtains, vehicles, utilities, stored goods and a quiet building are clues. Lawful vacancy is a legal question.

Careful: Paying the purchase money does not bring vacant possession, and the municipality does not remove residents or provide access. Maya forces no entry, changes no locks, confronts no one and has no one remove

Words on this page

Also on this page: **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

belongings. She asks her lawyer how the certificate's powers fit the possession facts, and records the answer before any physical step.

Safety runs beside legal authority. A damaged roof, an unstable porch, exposed wiring, mould, fuel, animals or an unknown occupant can turn a minor check into an emergency. The certificate gives Maya none of the authority of a building inspector, electrician, environmental professional or peace officer. Urgent threats go to the emergency or municipal authority, and qualified people, using lawful access, scope any non-urgent condition work.

The operating file

Maya's file opens on sale day.

Maya's operating file. The registered certificate and the sale date. The redemption deadline. The municipal contact and the property-tax account instructions. Possession advice. Insurer communications. Photographs or reports obtained lawfully. Approvals, invoices and receipts. Rent and other income records.

Every item carries a date and a source. Together they explain what Maya knew, which authority she relied on, what she did and what money moved.

New tax bills

New tax bills matter from the first month. The redemption formula can include taxes levied after the sale and related interest, which is no reason to leave the bills for someone else. Maya confirms where notices will go, how the account is tracked during the certificate period and what must be paid when due. A missed notice can cause a practical problem even when the formula would later count that tax.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **GST** Goods and Services Tax · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

Insurance

The Act deems Maya to have an **insurable interest** in the land: a legally recognized stake that lets her seek insurance against a loss during this conditional stage. The Act also requires her to insure buildings that are insurable, but it cannot make an insurer say yes. Acceptance, coverage and premium are the insurer's decisions.

Vacancy changes the conversation. Canadian insurer materials describe vacant buildings as a risk that ordinary home coverage may stop handling, and one that may need special vacancy or non-standard underwriting. That is market practice; a specific insurer decides whether this building and Maya's interest qualify.

Maya's inquiry states the awkward facts plainly: the certificate stage, the redemption period, the possession information, the known condition, her planned protective measures and any access limits. She asks:

- Will you cover my exact interest?
- Which risks are included, and which are excluded?
- What inspections or safeguards do you require?
- When would coverage begin, and how would a redemption or a later deed affect it?

The first underwriter declines. Maya dates the refusal and files it with her questions in her cost and risk file. One company's decision leaves open whether the building is insurable under the Act, so she keeps looking, and takes advice before treating the duty as impossible.

A specialty broker then finds possible coverage, subject to conditions. Maya gets the actual terms and professional advice before counting it as coverage. Her file records each stage by name, from the product webpage and the quote to the bound policy, its effective date, and the perils and activities it covers.

Words on this page

Also on this page: redemption period the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back

A repair, start to finish

A qualified exterior assessment finds a loose roof covering that could let water in during the next storm. Here "protect the land" can stretch too far, into a replacement roof billed in the hope of adding it to redemption. Maya sends the treasurer a defined scope, the assessment and the cost, and asks for written approval. Before work begins, she also checks the legal, safety, insurance and possession conditions.

The redemption amount may include amounts the purchaser paid for **necessary repairs** to buildings, made with the treasurer's written approval. In this book a necessary repair is protective work, supported by the building's actual condition and approved through that statutory path. Improvements, preferred materials, a faster project and work approved after the invoice arrived all fall outside it.

Careful: Get the treasurer's written approval before the work starts. Treat any repair made without it as your own cost, however necessary it looked.

The treasurer approves a temporary weatherproofing scope in writing. The contractor does only that scope, through a lawful and safe access arrangement. Maya keeps the approval, assessment report, invoice, proof of payment and dated completion record together. Those papers are the centre of the file: they link an observed risk, a professional scope, a written approval, a lawful way of doing the work and an amount paid. Remove any link and the claim becomes a different question. If the contractor finds a larger defect, the new work goes back through the treasurer, the professional and the insurer.

Rent and other income

The certificate holder may collect rent, and a payment raises questions of its own: who occupies the building, which tenancy or

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

contract applies, whom to contact and which lawful possession steps exist. Maya takes those to her lawyer and the records. She logs any income by date and amount, because it can reduce what she is repaid on redemption.

When someone redeems

In month four the treasurer tells Maya that a person with a qualifying interest intends to redeem. The message starts the statutory close-out. The work done so far stays on the record, and there is nothing for Maya to negotiate privately with the person redeeming.

Redemption is built into a redeemable sale. The owner, a mortgage or lien holder, a person with another charge, or anyone else with an interest in the land may redeem within the six months. Maya bought with that possibility in the process, so a redemption says nothing about the quality of her research.

The human side needs the same discipline as the money. A former owner may be trying to keep a home, family land or a business, and an occupant may be someone other than the person paying. Maya can close her file without their private story. Communication stays lawful, necessary and respectful, process questions go through the treasurer and her lawyer, and nobody is threatened with entry, removal or construction work while the legal stage changes.

The redemption amount

The treasurer determines the redemption amount under the statute. Maya supplies records for the items that depend on her conduct. The amount starts with the sum the purchaser paid. Interest at ten percent a year runs on that total from the sale date to the redemption date.

The amount can also include:

- certain older taxes that the purchase money left unpaid;
- taxes levied after the sale, and related interest;

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

- the fee to record the discharge;
- qualifying fire-insurance premiums;
- necessary-repair amounts paid with the treasurer's written approval.

Two items come off: any balance left in the tax-sale surplus account for the property, and rent or other income the purchaser earned from the land.

The ten percent sounds like a return. Its legal job is narrower: one part of the formula, for the period between sale and redemption, owed only if someone redeems. The statute makes no promise that anyone will, that the property stays free of loss or that every expense qualifies. Taxes, financing costs, professional fees, uninsured damage and time belong in Chapter 9's all-in cost.

The purchaser's statement

When a redemption is to take place, the purchaser may be asked for a statement of amounts spent on fire-insurance premiums and on repairs made with the treasurer's written approval. A complete file makes that request routine. Rebuilding months of receipts, emails and income afterwards makes it needlessly hard.

Maya's statement lists amounts spent in those two categories, with the evidence: the weatherproofing approval, scope, invoice and proof of payment, and the policy and premium records. A declined quote, an unpaid estimate, a verbal approval and any broader future roof project stay out. New tax bills stay in the municipal account trail. Rent and other income stay in the offset column, even if already spent. Keeping the categories apart gives the treasurer what the redemption needs. A disputed payment or category goes to the treasurer's official process and to legal advice.

The redemption amount and the purchaser's repayment come from separate sections of the Act, and they can differ line by line. The redemption amount includes municipal tax and recording items.

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

The repayment covers the purchase sum, interest, fire-insurance premiums and approved repairs, less rent or other income from the property. The treasurer administers the whole transaction, and Maya checks what she receives against the official statement.

Try it

Maya's folder holds a declined insurance quote, a fire-insurance premium receipt, an estimate for a new roof, the approved weatherproofing invoice with proof of payment, and her income log. Which go into the statement the treasurer asks for?

Answer: The premium receipt and the approved weatherproofing invoice, each with its evidence. The income log belongs in the offset column. The quote and the estimate stay in her file as history.

Sale expenses: the Halifax example

Halifax shows how many real administrative and professional steps "sale expenses" can cover. It works under its own parallel Charter, and the July 2026 snapshot of its Administrative Order 18 schedule names local categories for notice, title searches, survey, deed work, registration, closing and redemption administration. That list is Halifax's and can change after this edition; an Inverness redemption follows Inverness's rules. Cedar Street's municipality may use different council-approved fees, forms and procedures, so Maya asks it for the official calculation and its current authority, and keeps Halifax's categories and amounts out of her worksheet.

The moment rights end

The close-out has a precise legal moment. Maya's interest survives a message that someone plans to redeem, and it survives a part payment. From the time the full redemption amount is paid to the treasurer, the Act says the purchaser ceases to have a right to the land. Maya obtains the municipality's official close-out record as proof, and any planned protective work stops.

Everyone who relied on her certificate authority needs prompt, accurate notice. Her insurer may have its own cancellation or

Words on this page

Also on this page: treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale

change terms. An approved contractor may need a stop instruction. Any keys, documents or site arrangements lawfully made are handled on legal advice. After her rights end, Maya has no authority to hold the property, demand extra money or enter the premises.

Closing the file

Maya's final ledger holds the whole trail, from the purchase record and the insurer's refusal to the official redemption calculation, her repayment and the municipality's close-out record. It keeps the human side straight too: no private confrontation, and no story of redemption as defeat.

The outcome is financially finite and legally meaningful. Maya receives the repayment the statute and her evidence support, and the person redeeming keeps the land. Her rehabilitation plan stays on paper, yet her work is complete. She protected what she was authorized to protect, documented what the formula could recognize and stopped when the registered stage ended.

If nobody had redeemed, the file would have moved, after the statutory wait, to a request for the deed. That reopens title, possession, condition and intended-use questions under a new document, as Chapter 12 shows. Here the discharge closes the branch. A lawful ending is the process working.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 150 (certificate of sale), s. 151 (certificate holder's powers and duties), s. 152 (redemption and the redemption amount), ss. 153–154 (repayment and end of the purchaser's rights), s. 155 (deed).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: ss. 165–170 (parallel provisions); Halifax Administrative Order 18, Schedule 1 (tax-sale expenses), snapshot July 2026.
- Intact Insurance, vacant-home and non-standard-property pages, checked 20 July 2026.
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page, and Nova Scotia Residential Tenancies resources, checked 20 July 2026 (occupied properties).

Words on this page

Also on this page: certificate of sale the document a purchaser receives after paying in full

12 Chapter 12 The Deed Is a Beginning

How a certificate holder asks for the tax deed and registers it, which clock registration starts, and how the new owner reopens the research with better evidence. Surplus money and any challenge to the sale follow their own routes.

Chapter 8 jumped ahead to Foundry Street after its tax deed was registered, to separate title from possession before the book turned to bidding money. Now we reach that point in order. Nobody redeemed the property, the applicable wait has ended, and the certificate holder asks the municipality for the deed.

The Municipal Government Act gives two routes to that request. When the taxes were more than six years in arrears at the time of the sale, the purchaser may request the deed after the sale. For a redeemable property that stays unredeemed, the request comes after six months. Either way, the purchaser pays the fee set by council, and the municipality delivers the prescribed deed to the purchaser or as the purchaser directs.

The deed comes on request. Passing the six-month mark makes the request possible, and the purchaser still has to make it. Foundry Street's file confirms that the redemption period expired unredeemed, gets the municipality's current instructions and pays the fee. When the deed arrives, the file checks the land description, grantee, signatures, municipal seal, related sale record and any direction the purchaser gave.

Chapter 8 covered what the deed does to title. The questions now are what the owner does with it and which systems start to rely on it.

Words on this page

Also on this page: tax deed the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period · **redemption period** the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back

Registering the deed

Deed registration is the entry of the deed into Nova Scotia's land-record system. It gives the file a recorded instrument and a registration date that can be searched and tied to the correct parcel. That work sits with the purchaser and their lawyer under the current Land Registry requirements. The file confirms each downstream filing, including any the municipality says it made.

A deed given through a tax sale is exempt from municipal deed-transfer tax under the Municipal Government Act. The provincial deed-transfer service currently says an Affidavit of Value is still required when real property is transferred, even when no municipal deed-transfer tax is payable. The exemption covers that one tax. Harmonized sales tax and the provincial non-resident deed-transfer tax, from Chapter 9, depend on the property and the purchaser. The lawyer and tax adviser apply the current rules, and "tax-free" stays out of the file.

Land Registry guidance lists the fees due when a document is registered, recorded or filed, and those amounts change. The file keeps the current official fee, the receipt, the documents submitted, the registration particulars and the lawyer's confirmation.

The six-year clock

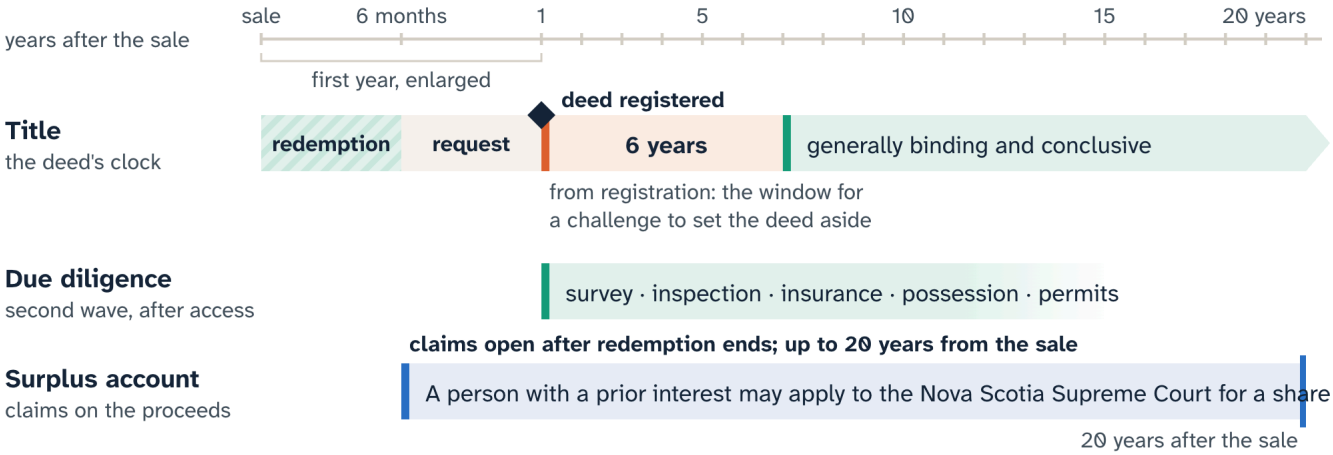
Registration also starts a legal clock. Under the Marketable Titles Act, a tax deed generally may be set aside only during the six years following its registration. After that, the deed is generally binding and conclusive, subject to the section's own qualifications:

- a land-exclusion rule, which applies when its conditions about the assessment, the interest and the arrears are met;
- an exception where the current owner participated in fraud or breach of trust;
- any cause of action a person may have for damages for a wrongful tax sale, which the section preserves.

Words on this page

Also on this page: tax deed the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period

The six-month redemption period and this six-year period answer different legal questions.



Drawn with the deed registered one year after the sale; the first year is enlarged. The six years run from registration, so the window moves with that date.

THE REGISTERED DEED

Vests fee-simple title, free of encumbrances

Easements and rights-of-way continue, as the statute specifies. The deed is also statutory evidence that the sale steps were followed.

Requested after the six months, or right after the sale when taxes were more than six years in arrears. The purchaser pays council's fee.

AFTER THE SIX YEARS

The deed is generally binding and conclusive, with three carve-outs

1. Land caught by the section's exclusion rule, where its assessment, interest and arrears conditions are met
2. A current owner who took part in fraud or breach of trust
3. A claim for damages for a wrongful tax sale stays open

If a court sets a sale aside, the municipal tax lien stays in place.

Marketable Titles Act s. 6 (consolidation of Sept 1, 2015); Municipal Government Act ss. 133(4), 146–147, 155–156 (Halifax: Charter ss. 147, 161–162, 170–171), consolidated to April 9, 2026. Checked July 20, 2026.

After the deed: registration starts a six-year window in which a tax deed can generally be challenged, and the second wave of due diligence begins.

Careful: The six years run from the date the tax deed is registered. Auction day, the end of redemption, deed delivery and the first entry into the building are different dates, and none of them starts this clock.

Words on this page

Also on this page: redemption period the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period

The window is a reason to get title advice now. The purchaser needs the deed, parcel register, legal description, relevant instruments, sale record and a legal opinion when ownership decisions begin. Counsel applies the timing rule and its exceptions to any claimed defect, excluded land, fraud allegation, boundary problem or other dispute.

What the deed carries forward

Foundry Street's registered right-of-way continues under the rule from Chapter 8, serving the house behind. Before placing materials, fencing or equipment where another parcel may have passage rights, the owner gets the source instrument and learns its route, purpose, maintenance terms and permitted use. The lawyer interprets the registered instruments. A surveyor can relate the legal description and visible occupation to the ground, so work is planned around the real rights and boundaries.

The parcel's own access is the mirror question. A visible driveway or mapped road beside the parcel does not give it legal frontage, a public-road connection or a registered right to pass. Those come from title, plans and a lawyer's reading of them. The deed changes the ownership stage; a missing access instrument is still missing afterwards, and an aerial image still falls short of a survey.

Insurance changes stage too. A policy or binder written for the certificate holder may have terms tied to that conditional interest, the occupancy and the known condition. The new owner gives the insurer and broker the registered-deed information and any updated possession or building facts. The policy and the underwriting response decide whether coverage continues, changes or must be replaced.

The people in the house

Foundry Street was visibly occupied when Chapter 8 last looked at it.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Careful: Possession does not arrive with registration. Cape Breton Regional Municipality (CBRM), for example, says it does not remove residents or provide access, and Foundry Street's municipality needs its own current check. The owner proceeds through counsel and the lawful process that fits the facts. Locks, utilities, rent demands and belongings all wait for that process.

Once lawful possession or authorized access is established, plan the first entry as an unknown-condition event. Check the insurance terms, occupant rights, contractor authority, building safety and environmental concerns before anyone treats the premises as an ordinary renovation site. A powerful title document can sit beside an unstable stair, exposed wiring, a fuel leak or stored chemicals.

The owner now holds three records. The registered deed for the correct Parcel Identification Number (PID) states the land interest and supplies the date that starts the Marketable Titles Act period. The title opinion explains the deed and the current land record. Those two form the centre of the title file, and around them sit any continuing easements or rights-of-way, court order, boundary questions, registration requirements and unresolved property-specific qualifications. The possession file shows who is present and which lawful route governs access and control. Physical due diligence begins when those files support the move.

The second due-diligence wave

The first wave of due diligence helped decide whether to bid. It worked from a distance, under the sale conditions, while ownership and lawful access were unresolved. **Post-deed due diligence** is the planned reopening of the intended-use, condition, cost and permission files once ownership has changed and better evidence is lawfully available. Some questions will stay open; the evidence you can gather has changed.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **easement** a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Foundry Street's pre-bid plan was modest and conditional: stabilize the occupied building, understand the right-of-way and, if the evidence supported it, prepare a small rental rehabilitation. It stayed conditional after registration. The post-deed file starts by restating that use in plain words. Rental rehabilitation touches occupancy, fire safety, building work, insurance, services, financing and local land-use rules. A plan that passed rough screening may fail once those systems return real costs or restrictions.

Municipal letters sharpen part of the picture. CBRM, for example, currently offers two. A zoning confirmation letter confirms the zoning and the applicable land-use by-law provisions identified by planning staff; whether a proposed design will receive permits is a separate decision. A municipal clearance letter reports specified outstanding items in municipal records: building-code orders, by-law orders and fire-code violations. A defect nobody reported or recorded is a job for an inspection. Ask for the letter that matches the question, keep its date and qualifications, and take a difficult answer to the right staff member or professional.

Property Valuation Services Corporation (PVSC) lets the public find assessments by civic address or Assessment Account Number (AAN), with broader searches including by assessment range. Its open data shows assessed and taxable assessed values over several years, and a parcel sheet may carry the dated account and assessment. The assessed value is a mass-appraisal estimate tied to a stated valuation date and to the physical state recorded at a stated condition date. The taxable assessed value may differ, including through the Capped Assessment Program, and transfer-related eligibility can also change.

Foundry Street records the year, value type and source beside each number, and its budget calls the figure an assessment. Market price, condition, repair cost, resale prospects and the maximum bid need evidence built for those jobs. The tax adviser and municipality handle the taxable assessment and rates.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **CBRM** Cape Breton Regional Municipality · **PVSC** Property Valuation Services Corporation · **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **right-of-way** a legal right to cross someone else's land

Lawful access now turns pre-bid unknowns into qualified observations. A building professional may find that the roof needs more than the temporary protection imagined during redemption. Electrical, structural, fire or moisture evidence may change the order of work. Service providers can confirm whether a connection exists, whether it works and what restoration would take. An insurer can underwrite the real occupancy and condition.

On the environmental side, provincial guidance explains that contamination can affect soil, water and air. A map layer, a historic image or a neighbouring use can justify a question. A qualified environmental professional answers it from the site's history, the materials observed and the proposed work, and the owner follows the property-specific regulatory route that results. Wells, on-site sewage, coastlines, flood context, mine workings and the other layers from earlier chapters work the same way. Their map symbols are retrieval handles: after the deed, the owner goes back to the current official record, gets an inspection or professional interpretation where needed, and writes down what is still unknown.

Now suppose the evidence changes the economics. The clearance file shows an unresolved order, the building review expands the immediate stabilization work, and the insurer will cover only a tightly controlled vacant-building phase. That is the earlier screen doing its job, leaving room for better evidence to change the next decision.

The project can be narrowed, delayed, stabilized for later work, prepared for a lawful resale, or taken back to advisers for a different route. Ownership owes the pre-bid story no loyalty. It owes responsible treatment of the land, the people connected to it and the evidence now available.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **GST** Goods and Services Tax · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

Foundry Street's updated decision record

This record closes the second wave. It states the intended use, the evidence dates, the material unknowns, the professional or municipal handoffs and the next authorized expenditure. It is worth more than a victory photograph, because it shows what the deed has made possible and what is still unsolved.

The money takes its own road

The deed gives the purchaser title to the land. The sale money and any challenge to the sale follow their own routes.

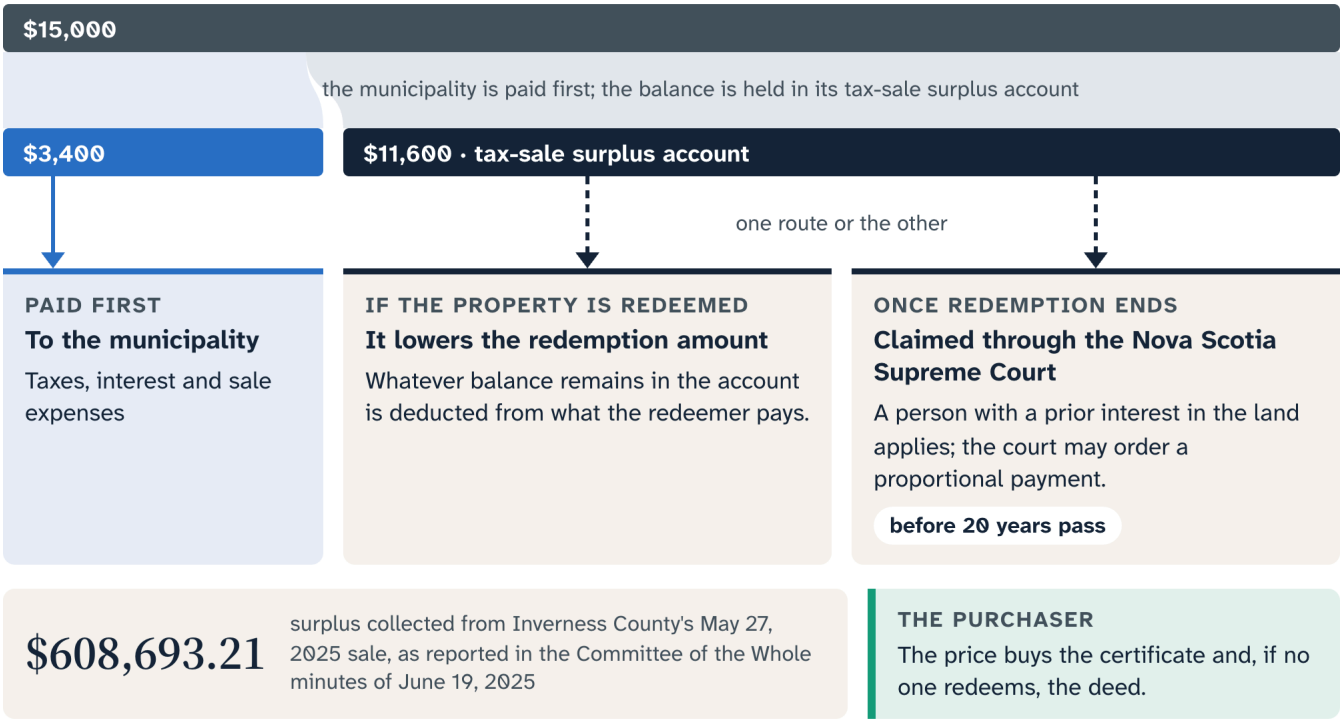
Sale proceeds first pay the municipality's required amounts. A **tax-sale surplus account** is the municipality's statutory account for what remains. It is a record of money, separate from the question of which interests still burden the land. Had the property been redeemed, the balance would have reduced the redemption price, as Chapter 11 showed.

After the redemption period, a person claiming an interest in land sold for taxes may apply to the Nova Scotia Supreme Court, before twenty years have passed from the sale. The court may order proportional payment from the surplus account.

Words on this page

Also on this page: surplus money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **redemption period** the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back

Purchase money: the winning bid example: $15,000 bid, $3,400 owed



Municipal Government Act ss. 146–147, 152 (Halifax: Charter ss. 161–162, 167), consolidated to April 9, 2026. Example amounts are illustrative.

Where the money goes: sale proceeds pay the municipality's amounts first; any balance waits in the tax-sale surplus account for people with prior interests to claim through the Supreme Court.

Elena, a fictional former co-owner whose interest may have attached to the property before the sale, learns that the sale left a balance. She makes no demand of the new deed holder and no claim against the land. She takes the notices, her ownership documents and the sale information to a lawyer.

The route says nothing yet about her standing, evidence, share or result. Her lawyer identifies the parties, proof and court procedure. Her twenty-year limit runs from the sale date; Foundry Street's six-year period runs from registration. Writing both dates in one file keeps the word "deadline" from blurring two unrelated clocks.

Try it

A file lists four dates: the sale, the end of redemption, deed delivery and deed registration. Which starts the six-month redemption

Words on this page

Also on this page: **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **redemption period** the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back

period, the six-year Marketable Titles Act period and the twenty-year limit for a surplus application?

Answer: The sale date starts the six months and the twenty years. Registration starts the six years. The end of redemption opens the surplus application, and deed delivery starts none of these clocks.

When someone challenges the sale

A challenge to the sale travels on another track. A claimant may allege that the sale included land that should have been left out, that a required step failed, or that another statutory ground applies. Those allegations need the complete record and legal advice, and a court may decide them. The six-year limit described earlier, with its exceptions, governs when an action to set aside the deed can be brought.

If a tax sale is set aside, the Municipal Government Act provides that the tax lien is not discharged. A set-aside is no simple rewind to the earlier positions with the municipality's claim gone. Counsel explains the effect of the order, the surviving lien and any related remedy.

Three files stay separate even when they concern the same sale:

- the registered deed and title opinion support the owner's land decisions;
- the municipal accounting and court materials govern a claimant's possible share of the surplus;
- the sale record, the statute and the legal process govern a claimed defect or remedy.

Keeping them apart prevents two opposite errors: a deed holder taking surplus money the statute reserves for another process, and a former interest holder treating a possible claim to proceeds as present possession or control of the land.

Words on this page

Also on this page: redemption period the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back · **tax lien** the municipality's legal claim on a property for unpaid tax

Foundry Street ends the chapter with a registered deed, an active title and possession file, and a revised plan built on evidence that was out of reach at the auction. Elena's surplus file runs on its own track, and a contested-sale file, if one appears, goes to counsel. That is why the deed is a beginning: it changes the legal stage and the evidence the owner can gather, and it leaves lawful routes open for people whose claims concern the proceeds or the sale itself.

The method now runs from first notice to post-deed file. The last skill is recognition: know the current stage, open the right evidence record, and know when the map hands the matter to a municipality, registry, surveyor, insurer, tax adviser, environmental professional or lawyer.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 109(4) (tax-sale deed exempt from municipal deed transfer tax), s. 133(4) (tax lien not discharged when a sale is set aside), ss. 146–147 (proceeds, surplus account and Supreme Court applications), ss. 155–156 (deed request, fee and effect).
- Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026: s. 147(4), ss. 161–162, ss. 170–171 (parallel Halifax provisions).
- Marketable Titles Act (Nova Scotia), standalone consolidation dated 1 September 2015: s. 6 (six-year period to set aside a tax deed, exceptions and preserved damages claims).
- Nova Scotia, Municipal deed transfer and property tax service (Affidavit of Value) and Land Registry fees page, checked 20 July 2026.
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page (occupied properties) and Zoning Confirmation and Municipal Clearance page, checked 20 July 2026.
- Property Valuation Services Corporation, Find an Assessment, 2026 assessment-notice guidance and datazONE assessed-value history, checked 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Environment and Climate Change, Environmental Registry and Contaminated Sites pages, checked 20 July 2026.
- Nova Scotia Residential Tenancies, tenant and landlord resources, checked 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **tax lien** the municipality's legal claim on a property for unpaid tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid · **tax deed** the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period

13 Chapter 13 A File That Knows Its Limits

Three composite files test the whole method and end three different ways. You will sort a file, route its open questions, write a decision, and keep a record that stays useful after the sale.

In Chapter 1, Harbour Road was one fictional row in a strong municipal packet. The packet supplied facts, maps and registry material and left their meaning to the bidder's research. Twelve chapters later, the test is whether that research holds when the facts change.

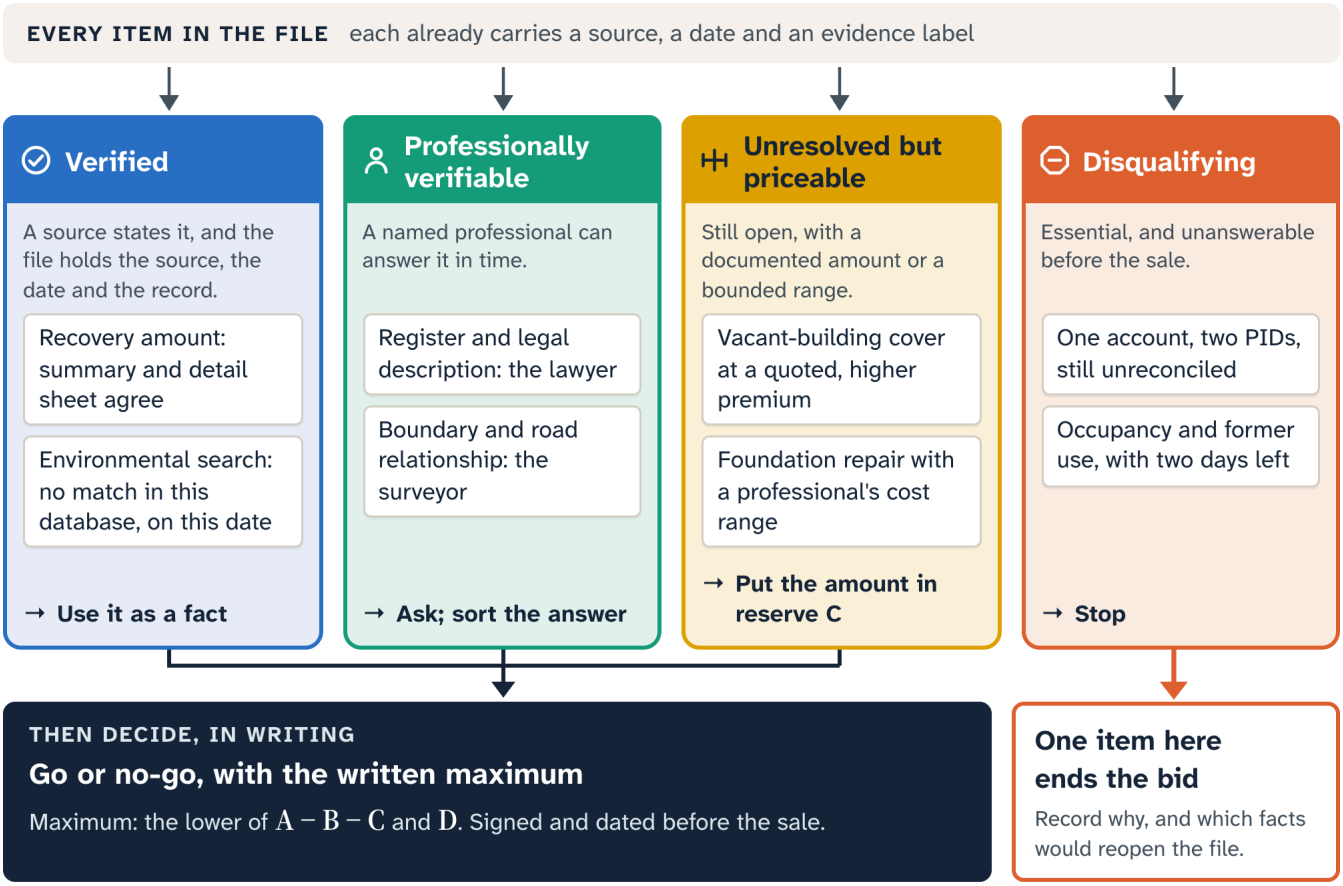
Three new files arrive, all fictional composites with no live property behind them. Alder Crossing's notice appears to cover two parcels. Union Workshop is a building that appears occupied and may once have been a workshop. Meadow Line is vacant land whose records fit together better than the others. Each file is built the same way: dated notice, exact parcel, bounded context, open questions, and the authority that answers next. The endings differ.

Sort, label, route, decide

Once a file is built, four moves turn it into a decision. Sort every item into one of Chapter 4's four buckets: verified, professionally verifiable, unresolved but priceable, or disqualifying. Label it with its source, its date and one of the five evidence labels from the same chapter. Route each open question to the person or office that can answer it. Then decide, in writing.

Words on this page

Earlier words: **GST** Goods and Services Tax · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid



Bucket tests as set out in chapter 4; examples from the book's fictional composite files. A, B, C and D are the lines of the written-maximum worksheet in chapter 9.

Sort every item in the file into one of four buckets before deciding. A single item in the last bucket ends the bid.

Alder Crossing: one account, two parcels

Alder Crossing's municipal row lists one account and two Parcel Identification Numbers (PIDs). Searching the stated address returns an authoritative civic point inside the first parcel. The second PID selects a separate shape next door. On the aerial image the first parcel holds a roof, so it looks like the obvious subject.

Before sorting, write one sentence with four parts:

- the verified fact: the dated notice lists one account with two PIDs, and the civic point sits inside one of the two graphical parcel outlines;

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number

- the open question: what interest the municipality intends to sell, and how the PIDs, the account, the legal descriptions and any building relate;
- the next authority: the municipality's current notice or confirmation, and counsel reading the land records;
- the consequence: stop, with both parcels kept in the file, however memorable the roof makes one of them.

The map did its job by finding a parcel to investigate, and the Assessment Account Number (AAN) adds taxation context. The municipal record and the land records settle which registered interests are included. Until they reconcile the two PIDs, the title request, the use analysis and any maximum bid all wait.

Alder Crossing is a complete stop result. The researcher can state what matched, what conflicted, who answers next, and why the records choose the parcel, whatever the aerial image suggests.

Union Workshop: open questions on a short clock

Union Workshop's notice gives one account and one PID, and the aerial image shows a substantial building. A street-level view of the exterior, taken from a lawful public position, suggests the premises are occupied. Older directories link the address to repair work. The current public environmental search finds no matching contaminated-site notice for the exact parcel.

Careful: The fictional notice offers no entry and no help removing anyone living there. Where Cape Breton Regional Municipality serves as the public comparison, its guidance expressly declines both; a real event's current terms still need checking. An empty environmental search speaks for that one source on that date.

Each clue gets its own route. Occupancy goes to a lawyer-reviewed possession and tenancy file: who is present, their legal status, and whether vacant possession can be obtained. Former use and current condition go to a property-specific environmental and

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

building review of the soil, water, air, building materials and contents. Planning, fire and building officials report what their records cover, and an insurer responds to the actual use, occupancy and condition.

The assessment gives dated mass-appraisal and taxation context, including the classification shown by the public source, and that classification feeds the tax route. If the event terms say harmonized sales tax (HST) applies to vacant land or commercially assessed property, that is an important instruction for that event. Federal treatment still depends on the seller, the property, its use and the transaction, so the classification is a prompt for transaction-specific tax advice.

Now add the clock. The sale is two days away, no lawful inspection is possible, occupancy is unresolved, and the environmental review needs more time than remains. The researcher resists inventing a reserve big enough to hide the unknowns, and records why they are unpriceable for now and which facts would reopen the file. The bidder owns the decision to stop.

That is a harder kind of completion than Alder Crossing's. One identity conflict can govern a file cleanly; several interacting unknowns can stall one with no single dramatic defect. The research still kept occupancy, the assessment and a clean database screen from becoming false comfort.

Try it

Union Workshop's environmental search returned no match. Which bucket does that result go in?

Answer: Verified, as a search result: this database, on this date, held no matching notice. The soil, water and building are separate items. With two days left and no review possible, they sit in the disqualifying bucket.

Meadow Line: a file ready for a decision

Meadow Line's records line up, which makes it the most research-ready of the three files. That phrase describes the evidence and nothing more.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax

Meadow Line's file, layer by layer, with the route for each open question:

- Identity: the summary entry and detail sheet agree on the recovery amount, the AAN leads to the assessment account, and the PID selects the land the municipal material describes. The lawyer reviews the parcel register and legal description.
- Orientation and access: the parcel sits near community services, and its graphical outline lies beside a mapped public road on gentle contours. The lawyer confirms frontage from the access evidence. A surveyor joins if the boundary or road relationship matters to the plan.
- Planning: a current zoning-confirmation response addresses the stated vacant-land use, identifying current zoning and the provisions that apply. Permits, servicing confirmation and project approval are separate steps. Zone, frontage, well and septic assumptions are written down, with three written questions for municipal planning staff. The municipality answers the exact frontage, lot, intended-use and approval questions.
- Screening: the environmental, well, sewage, coastal and mine searches return no mapped intersection calling for an immediate specialist. Each is listed with its source's coverage and currency limits, and inspection, service and site professionals test what the public record leaves open.

The standard for the whole file is decision-critical: every uncertainty that could change the decision is resolved or given a defensible treatment.

Historical results stay out of the value column. Inverness's records from its May 2025 sale show published bids often exceeding recovery amounts, and its official sources differ on some counts. That is useful evidence about competition and record completeness at that event.

If the essential legal and use questions come back with acceptable answers, Meadow Line moves to an all-in cost file. It holds the intended use, current tax advice, professional, carrying and site costs, and a reserve for the uncertainty that evidence can price. The supported value boundary from Chapter 9, less those costs, gives the written maximum, and the energy of the room leaves it there.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **recovery amount** the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

Payment readiness is a separate gate. If the bidder lacks the authority, accepted funds or balance route that the current event terms require, the file is not ready, whatever the spreadsheet says.

So Meadow Line reaches a decision point. The evidence may support taking part under a fixed maximum and a verified payment plan, and the researcher can explain how the file got there. The bidder decides whether to proceed. The file declares no bargain and recommends no bid.

Three endings

The three files end three ways: a stop on parcel identity, a stop on time, and a bounded file handed to the bidder. Each ending is a record of why, and each is useful, Meadow Line's included if the bidder stops when bidding passes the written maximum. A purchase is one possible ending. A documented decision to stay out can be just as complete.

The record that survives the event

Then the world moves. A parcel is withdrawn, a bidder pays, an owner redeems, a certificate holder requests a deed, an inspection contradicts the pre-bid screen. A file that holds only a screenshot and a conclusion goes stale or misleading with each change.

The stable core is short: dated municipal notice, exact identifiers, bounded context, visible unknowns, next authority and decision consequence. Refresh the municipal source before acting. Keep the AAN, PID, civic point, graphical boundary and legal description in their separate jobs. Give each map result its source, retrieval date and limitation, and address each unknown to a named professional or public authority. Meadow Line's one-page file has exactly that shape.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **AAN** Assessment Account Number · **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **legal description** the registry's written description of a parcel

RESEARCH FILE · MEADOW LINE — fictional composite · vacant land · all dates 2026

	ENTRY	SOURCE · DATE	LABEL
Event	Auction Tue Sep 22 · lien 63 · redeemable	Sale notice · **Sep 8**	Verified record
	Recovery $4,286.40: summary and detail agree	Both sheets · **Sep 8**	Verified record
	Still listed on the live notice	Municipal page · **Sep 21**	Verified record
Parcel	PID •••••417 selects the described land	Notice, map · **Sep 9**	Verified record
	AAN •••••208 opens the assessment account	PVSC search · **Sep 9**	Verified record
	Register and legal description → **lawyer**	Detail sheet · **Sep 10**	Professional verification needed
Access	Beside a mapped public road; gentle contours	Map layers · **Sep 9**	Screening clue
	Open ground appears to reach the road edge	Aerial image · **Sep 9**	Visual interpretation
	Frontage on that road → **lawyer**, due Sep 21	Asked · **Sep 10**	No-go until resolved
	Boundary and road → **surveyor**, if needed	Drafted · **Sep 10**	Professional verification needed
Planning	Zoning response covers the vacant-land use	Planning office · **Sep 14**	Verified record
	Three written questions → **planning staff** Permits, servicing and approval are separate steps	Sent · **Sep 15**	Professional verification needed
Screening	Five searches: no mapped intersection	Provincial data · **Sep 9**	Screening clue
	each with its limits noted: environmental registry · well logs · sewage: 7-year records · coastal: scenario map · mine openings: incomplete list		
	Condition, well, septic → **site professionals** after lawful access	Scope noted · **Sep 15**	Professional verification needed
Decision	Payment: authority, funds, balance route	Bank letter · **Sep 17**	Verified record
	Go if the frontage answer is acceptable	This file · **Sep 18**	No-go until resolved

WRITTEN MAXIMUM · FROM THE ALL-IN COST FILE, SEP 17

$9,500

The lower of A – B – C ($21,000 – $7,000 – $4,500) and D ($12,000)

B: tax advice, professional, carrying and site costs · C: reserve for priceable unknowns

The bidder decides

Signed and dated Sep 18, before the sale

Identifiers masked. Fields follow the book's research method and the NS Marks The Spot parcel record (source commit d3114b5c, checked July 20, 2026).

Meadow Line's research file on one page: every line carries a source, a date and a label.

Subscription land-record material, such as Property Online pages, stays in the governed working file unless its reuse is authorized, because it is subscriber-only and carries owner details. A public

Words on this page

Earlier words: GST Goods and Services Tax · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **surplus** money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid

explanation names the question and the need for registry review. The public map stays owner-free and parcel-first.

When the world changes, add a **stage record**, a new dated line in the file. It states the controlling document, the power or duty it creates, its boundary, the next authorized action and the event that will end that stage. Earlier entries stay as dated evidence of what was known. Authority to act comes from the current stage.

If Meadow Line is withdrawn before its row is called, the file records the withdrawal and its municipal source, closes the bid action and keeps the earlier research date. If payment instead produces a certificate in the redeemable branch, the file opens the certificate-holder records. Full payment of the redemption amount to the treasurer ends the purchaser's rights. An unredeemed sale can move to the deed request and a new ownership file when the applicable wait and the municipal process permit it.

The registered deed has real statutory effect on title. Survey, possession, inspection, access and development approval keep their own routes, and the post-deed file replaces screenable unknowns with better, lawfully obtained evidence where it can.

The map and the people

A better public map follows the same record. It makes the municipal notice easy to find, selects the exact PID, shows dated context, states what each source returned and sends the user to the direct authority. It can show public assessed and taxable assessed values when their year and type are unmistakable. It leaves out property scores, predicted values, invented nearest civic addresses, implied access rights and any hidden default layer that changes what an empty result means.

The same record divides the work. The researcher reconciles published sources, keeps disagreements visible, runs reproducible public screens and writes precise questions. Lawyers, surveyors, public officials and qualified site professionals own their

Words on this page

Also on this page: **PID** Parcel Identification Number · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale

conclusions. The bidder owns the risk tolerance, the financing and the final decision.

Back in Port Hood

Picture the parish hall in Port Hood again. The treasurer has a list, registered bidders wait, and the people beyond the room still have interests far larger than any row on it. When the first parcel is called, the municipality is there to collect.

What has changed is how you read the row. It is a notice connected to a parcel. The parcel sits in bounded context, its unknowns stay visible, and its questions go to the people authorized to answer them. That record is enough to support a careful decision. It is also enough to explain, in public and without a sales pitch, how tax-sale research in Nova Scotia can be useful.

Where this comes from

- Municipal Government Act (Nova Scotia), consolidated to 9 April 2026: s. 148 (payment), s. 150 (certificate of sale), ss. 152–154 (redemption and the end of the purchaser's rights), ss. 155–156 (deed request and effect).
- Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Tax Sales page and FAQ (occupancy, entry, HST); Canada Revenue Agency, *Real Property and the GST/HST*; both checked 20 July 2026.
- Property Valuation Services Corporation assessment search and assessed-value history; Nova Scotia Environmental Registry and Contaminated Sites pages; checked July 2026.
- Municipality of the County of Inverness, May 2025 tax-sale result sheet and Committee of the Whole minutes of 19 June 2025.
- NS Marks The Spot, source commit d3114b5c, production capture 20 July 2026.

Words on this page

Also on this page: **FAQ** frequently asked questions · **HST** Harmonized Sales Tax · **GST** Goods and Services Tax · **NS** Nova Scotia · **treasurer** the municipal official who runs the tax sale · **certificate of sale** the document a purchaser receives after paying in full

Glossary and index of abbreviations

Every word the footers explain, with the page where it is first defined.

AAN Assessment Account Number: the number for a property's assessment and tax account. 17

CBRM Cape Breton Regional Municipality 59

certificate of sale the document a purchaser receives after paying in full: it is registered at the land registry and gives limited powers to protect the property until the deed. 27

easement a right to use part of someone else's land for a purpose: such as a driveway, a utility line or drainage. 33

encumbrance a claim or charge registered against land: such as a mortgage, lien or judgment. 8

FAQ frequently asked questions 34

fee simple full ownership of land 33

GST Goods and Services Tax 105

HST Harmonized Sales Tax 101

legal description the registry's written description of a parcel: its boundaries and the rights that go with it, read by a lawyer or surveyor. 6

notice of intent the formal warning that a property will be sold: served on the owner and interest holders, with sixty days to pay before the sale. 11

NS Nova Scotia 3

NSPRD Nova Scotia Property Records Database: the Province's mapped parcel boundaries. 39

PDF Portable Document Format: a file that looks the same on every screen and printer. 2

PID Parcel Identification Number: the eight-digit number for a mapped land parcel in Nova Scotia's land records. 17

PVSC Property Valuation Services Corporation: the body that assesses property in Nova Scotia for municipal taxation. 49

recovery amount the taxes, interest and sale expenses being collected: the amount a municipality advertises for a lien. Some call it the minimum or opening bid. 7

redemption period the six months after a sale when an owner or interest holder may pay and take the property back: lost when taxes were more than six years in arrears at the time of sale. 23

right-of-way a legal right to cross someone else's land: usually registered on title; a path in use may or may not have one. 33

surplus money left from a sale after the municipality's amounts are paid: it is held in the tax-sale surplus account for people with prior interests to claim. 85

tax deed the deed a municipality gives the purchaser after the redemption period: it vests title free of encumbrances, as the statute specifies; easements and rights-of-way continue. 27

tax lien the municipality's legal claim on a property for unpaid tax: it ranks ahead of other claims and needs no registration. 8

tender a sale by sealed written offers: opened after a deadline, used instead of an auction with council's consent. 11

treasurer the municipal official who runs the tax sale 5

Sources and credits

Where the facts come from

Each chapter ends with its own list of official sources. The main ones are:

- the Municipal Government Act, consolidated to 9 April 2026, and the Halifax Regional Municipality Charter, consolidated to 1 May 2026, both from the Nova Scotia Legislature: nslegislature.ca;
- the Marketable Titles Act, as consolidated on 1 September 2015;
- municipal tax-sale pages, notices, packets, minutes and result sheets from Inverness, Cape Breton Regional Municipality, Halifax, Richmond, Pictou, Annapolis, Kings, Chester and Victoria, each dated in the text;
- the Province's land-information services: Property Online, the Nova Scotia property boundary and aerial imagery services, and Property Valuation Services Corporation's public assessment search.

The full research record, with every claim and its source, is public: github.com/dfakkeldy/explainer-audiobooks, in the folder docs/nova-scotia-tax-sale-book.

Charts and diagrams

The charts of past sale results use the municipalities' own published results, compiled in NS Marks The Spot's results catalogue (source revision 43e40b0b8, October 2026). Rows with an unknown, withdrawn or unsold outcome are left out of the ratio charts. The diagrams of the legal process follow the statute sections named in each chapter's sources.

The map

Screenshots in Chapter 5 show NS Marks The Spot, a free web map at kinnokilabs.com/apps/nsmarksthespot/map. Contains information obtained under license from the Province of Nova Scotia which is provided without warranty or liability for errors or omissions. The map's Data & licences page links the Province's licence for each service it shows. Map data also © OpenStreetMap contributors.

People and tools

Written and researched by Dan Fakkeldy. The first edition was researched, written and produced with OpenAI Codex. This illustrated edition was rewritten, illustrated and laid out with Claude, by Anthropic.

The book is laid out with Pandoc and Google Chrome, and checked with Poppler and EPUBCheck. The text is set in Source Serif 4 by Frank Grießhammer for Adobe, and the labels, footers and diagrams in Atkinson Hyperlegible Next by the Braille Institute, designed for readers with low vision. Both fonts are used under the SIL Open Font License.

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